

PRICE \$10.99

APRIL 20, 2026

THE NEW YORKER



The New Yorker Magazine

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By [Hilton Als](#), [Emily Nussbaum](#), [Sheldon Pearce](#), [Brian Seibert](#), and [Rachel Syme](#)

April 10, 2026

[You're reading the Goings On newsletter, a guide to what we're watching, listening to, and doing this week. **Sign up to receive it in your inbox.**](#)

The brilliant seventy-seven-year old German-born artist **Isa Genzken** makes work that, like her near-contemporary David Hammons's, not only defines her epoch but shatters it. Assembling sculptures with a variety of materials, ranging from concrete and plastic children's toys to film and pantyhose, Genzken has, throughout her career, put together shows that are environments rather than installations—environments that destabilize the viewer by playing up the artist's love of schematic improvisation. To enter a Genzken show is to see that she has a plan, but there's no road map: her work is best viewed or, rather, understood when you accept the open-ended order she employs to create the elements of her pieces, resulting in a kind of Teutonic chaos.



“Untitled,” from 2016. Art work by Isa Genzken / Glenstone Museum Collection / © VG Bild-Kunst / Courtesy the artist / David Zwirner / Galerie Daniel Buchholz

You can see this at work in the terrific show [**“Projects for Outside,”**](#) at Galerie Buchholz (through April 25), which looks closely at public spaces; New York is a big feature here, along with its architecture and scale. In Genzken’s hands, examining height and content becomes a fantastic exploration of the politics that define a world divided between the queer and the straight, a universe delineated by grids that do not, even with the best of intentions, stay orderly, because how can they? We’re humans living every day in the mess of history, whether we know it or not. There are some pieces in another show of hers currently on at David Zwirner on Walker Street, [**“Vacation”**](#) (through April 18), that are similar to those you’ll see uptown at Buchholz. Pieces from the great “World Receiver” series, on view here and at Buchholz, are very funny; they’re blocks of cement with aerials attached, but what does cement receive, or communicate? Yet, whereas the Buchholz show has a very clear and elegiac focus, the show at 52 Walker—which takes its title from Genzken’s proclamation that “the entire art system urgently needs a vacation”—offers a different and, in a way, more contained, vanilla view of the artist’s far-ranging intellect and sense of play amid the rubble of the world. Still, no matter how schematic she gets, you can’t hold Genzken down. She’s there to trouble you because she’s a firm believer in good *and* bad trouble, that which makes the world go round.—*Hilton Als*



About Town

Broadway

Joe Mantello's wrenchingly beautiful, simple staging of Arthur Miller's **"Death of a Salesman"** is set in a decaying underworld, a cavernous garage with colossal, chipped columns and a red sedan that looms like an altar. Lying in this crypt is Nathan Lane's Willy Loman, a tragic humbug, his delusions contradicted by the ruins around him. Lane's is a tender take on the role: he's a little guy punching above his weight, not a bruiser gone to seed—a hype man haunted by two pairs of sons, past and present, who roam, wearily, through his splintered psyche. It's a soulful interpretation that's perfectly matched by Christopher Abbott's quietly turbulent Biff, whose heroic breakdown at Lane's knees—"I'm *nothing!*"—is so powerful that it threatens to bring the columns tumbling down.—*Emily Nussbaum* ([Winter Garden](#); through Aug. 9.)

Indie Rock

In the early nineties, the British indie band **Heavenly** struck out in pursuit of the most infectious guitar-pop melody. Born from the embers of the eighties band Talulah Gosh, Heavenly, led by the singer and guitarist Amelia Fletcher, shuffled forward with her riffy, effervescent playing style, gradually growing more sophisticated across four LPs and an EP, without any loss of buoyancy. Right before the release of "Operation Heavenly" (1996), Amelia's brother, Mathew, the band's drummer, died by suicide, and the band's remaining members retired its name. They reconvened for a one-off, as Marine Research, but broke up in 1999. This February, after a nearly thirty-year absence, Heavenly returned, with a new album, "Highway to Heavenly," shambling on with its holy mission.—*Sheldon Pearce* ([Bowery Ballroom](#); April 18.)

Pop



Raye. Photograph by Aliyah Otchere

The début album by **Raye**, “My 21st Century Blues,” felt like a win for artists. Nearly a decade in the making, the LP was issued independently by the British singer-songwriter after a public dispute with and separation from Polydor, her label of seven years, which she claimed would not release her record. When “My 21st Century Blues” was finally liberated, it was a revelation—personal and singular, curious and self-confident, blending blues, house, and dancehall with pop, and breaking the record for the most Brit Awards wins in a night. Her new album, “This Music May Contain Hope,” is even more ambitious, if a bit melodramatic, its wide-screen cinematic drama splitting the difference between earnestness and theatricality.—S.P. ([Radio City Music Hall](#); April 15-16.)

Dance

This spring is seeing a rare flocking of “Firebird” ballets: first, there was the return of Alexei Ratmanský’s, at American Ballet Theatre, and upcoming is the familiar appearance of Balanchine’s at New York City Ballet. But the most important sighting of the mythical Stravinskian fowl might be the revival of **Dance Theatre of Harlem’s** 1982 version, migrating back to New York for the first time in more than twenty years. Choreographed by the Balanchine associate John Taras, it flourishes in the lush Caribbean fantasy of Geoffrey Holder’s sets and costumes. The Harlem dancers also ignite more recent works, by Robert Garland and William Forsythe.—*Brian Seibert* ([New York City Center](#); April 16-19.)

Dance



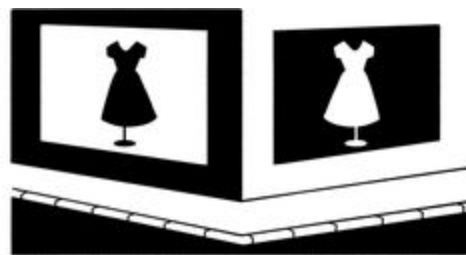
A.I.M by Kyle Abraham performs “Cassette Vol. 1.” Photograph by Christopher Duggan

A London-based friend introduced me to the choreographer **Kyle Abraham’s** work at Sadler’s Wells Theatre in 2025, and, while watching

his piece “An Untitled Love,” I experienced a feeling that I hadn’t had in the theatre in quite some time: love—not only for the dancers, the choreography, and the setting but for the ethos, which was, ultimately, about how joyful connections can be, should be. At Skirball, A.I.M by Kyle Abraham performs the New York City première of Abraham’s “Cassette Vol.1.” The piece draws on the choreographer’s love of eighties pop culture, on R. & B. and New Wave music, on artists who came before him, Bill T. Jones and Arnie Zane among them. I can’t imagine that the work isn’t a poem—poetry in motion—itself.—*Hilton Als* ([Skirball](#); April 16-18.)

Movies

Howard Brookner’s extraordinary 1985 documentary, **“Robert Wilson and the Civil Wars,”** makes one weep for what could have been, and what was. We watch as the great and charismatic director Wilson collaborates with six international theatre companies, in Germany, Japan, the U.S., and elsewhere, to put on a twelve-hour work about war, power, and humanity for the 1984 Summer Olympics, in Los Angeles. We learn something about Wilson’s childhood in conservative Waco, Texas, and his process, as described by collaborators such as the composer Philip Glass and the performer Sheryl Sutton. Tall, queer, and handsome, Wilson navigates the fund-raising world with an elegance and calm that belies the cliché of the “fiery” director, while Brookner’s camera is anything but aggressive.—*H.A.* ([BAM Rose Cinemas](#); April 17-23.)



On and Off the Avenue

Rachel Syme dives into a trendy online bargain bin.



Illustration by Holly Szczypka

I hail from a long line of women who love a good bargain: flea-market hagglers, dollar-bin divers, Maxxinistas. The thrill of the deal can get me into trouble, though; a few years back, I forbade myself from acquiring stuff merely because it was on sale. Imagine my surprise (and slight trepidation) then, when I recently came across **Martie**, a splashy-looking online discount site that was packed with items I already liked—Olipop sodas, Partake cookies, Momofuku noodles, Bonne Maman jams, Bastide soaps, Fishwife smoked salmon—all heavily marked down, some at more than seventy per cent off. What was the catch? I called up one of the founders, Kari Morris, who explained to me that, in 2021, she and her business partner, Louise Fritjofsson, founded Martie after seeing a gap in the discount-retail marketplace. Morris and Fritjofsson's first venture, in 2019, was a line of artisanal baking mixes. One holiday season, they found themselves with more than a thousand unsold boxes of vegan gingerbread mix. Their options were to donate the excess inventory, sell it off to an old-school resale chain like TJ Maxx, or chuck it. They felt that there had to be a more exciting way to give perfectly usable products a second life—so they created it. Martie now buys bulk overstock from trendy companies, then ships orders from its Texas warehouse. Many of the constantly rotating goods have a best-by date within six months, but it also sells some brand-new items, both from emerging businesses hoping to find new fans and from brands that are sunseting (such as, currently, Areaware, a soon closing

home-goods purveyor). “We want to take the ‘ick’ out of liquidation,” Morris told me. She also noted that, while Martie’s ultimate mission is to reduce waste, in these precarious times, the savings are the biggest draw. “A lot of people want to do good,” she said. “But *everyone* wants a really good deal.”

P.S. Good stuff on the internet:

- [A treasury of dedications](#)
- [The ultimate “Cribs”](#)
- [How John Steinbeck tricked his kids into reading](#)

An earlier version of this article misstated the name of the gallery where Isa Genzken’s show appears.

[Hilton Als](#), a staff writer at *The New Yorker*, won the 2017 Pulitzer Prize for criticism. He is the editor of “[God Made My Face: A Collective Portrait of James Baldwin](#).”

[Emily Nussbaum](#), a staff writer at *The New Yorker* since 2011, is the magazine’s theatre critic. Her books include “[Cue The Sun!: The Invention of Reality TV](#).”

[Sheldon Pearce](#) is a music writer for *The New Yorker*’s *Goings On* newsletter.

[Brian Seibert](#) has been contributing to *The New Yorker* since 2002. He is the author of “[What the Eye Hears: A History of Tap Dancing](#),” which won an Anisfield-Wolf Book Award. His writing appears in the *New York Times* and the *New York Review of Books*. A Guggenheim fellow, he teaches at Yale University.

[Rachel Syme](#) is a staff writer at *The New Yorker*. She has covered Hollywood, style, literature, music, and other cultural subjects since 2012.

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[The Food Scene](#)

A Malaysian Menu Laced with the Flavors of Brooklyn

Kelang, in Greenpoint, offers a modern, wide-ranging definition of culinary authenticity.

By [Helen Rosner](#)

April 5, 2026



Christopher Low, the chef-owner of Kelang, modelled its interior design on the films of Wong Kar Wai. Photographs by Jingyu Lin for The New Yorker

[You're reading the Food Scene newsletter, Helen Rosner's guide to what, where, and how to eat. Sign up to receive it in your inbox.](#)

The best thing on the menu at Kelang, a Malaysian restaurant in Greenpoint that opened in December, is a puffy paratha on a bed of spiced red-lentil dal, topped with creamy Italian stracciatella cheese. Depending on who you are, where you're from, and how rigid you are in your notions of gastronomic interpolation, this will strike you as either an absurd concept or a brilliant one. Kelang is part of a new crop of restaurants that celebrate the cultural synthesis of many immigrant groups that coexist in tight proximity to one another, from the Southeast Asian-kissed Italian American joint [JR & Son](#) to the Southern-meets-Sichuan fried-chicken spot Pecking House. What these places are doing isn't "fusion" in the cynical sense, wherein a chef from one culture raids another for decorative elements. It's something

more personal, less calculated. Kelang's paratha isn't a pizza, but it's not *not* a pizza; it's chewy, wheaty, savory, creamy, and fresh, with a bit of heat in the dal and a brightening zing of green from a tangle of herbs on top.

This intermingling isn't exactly a new phenomenon (birria ramen! Pastrami burritos! Gumbo!), but Kelang's approach feels specific to this moment. Call it the second-generation turn: the cooking of children whose palates belong not to their parents' homelands but to the cities that they were raised in; cooks making food that doesn't attempt to re-create someplace distant, in space or in memory, so much as to reflect their actual lives, which are hybrid and hyphenated, deeply rooted yet widely branching. Kelang's owner, Christopher Low, is an American-born son of Malaysian parents. He grew up in Brooklyn, eating his parents' cooking in addition to the Haitian and Jamaican food of his neighbors and friends. In 2022, he, his parents, and his sister opened a restaurant, Hainan Chicken House, in Sunset Park, a counter-service spot named in celebration of a regional culinary export that's hugely popular in Malaysia: poached chicken, fragrant with scallions and ginger, served with chicken-infused rice and sauces. The restaurant became a minor sensation—the titular dish is terrific, silken and subtle and rich, but what most stood out was a rotating lineup of specials, mostly hawker-style Malaysian fare, particularly the food of Klang, his parents' home town, on Malaysia's western coast.

At Kelang (the restaurant is named for an archaic spelling of the city's name), those dishes are brought to the fore and woven with flavors from Low's life in Brooklyn. There's the paratha, of course, with its playful Neapolitan flourishes, but also a *rendang*, a Malaysian style of curry in which the sauce simmers down to almost a rich glaze, here made with tender shreds of oxtail—smoked first, Caribbean style. It's served alongside rice cooked with mushrooms and herbs, a clever mashup of Malaysian *nasi ulam* and Haitian *djon djon*. Low isn't the first to do a curry-chicken potpie, but his version is rich and warm, with airy, shattery pastry reminiscent of roti, flaky and slick with butter.

Not all dishes on the menu make you play a game of spot-the-references; some dishes are just terrific for terrific's sake. Take, for instance, the clay-pot *bak kut teh*, featuring big hunks of pork (belly, trotter, rib) bobbling

around in an intense, herbal broth in which they've braised for ages, or the "moonlight *kway teow*," a stir-fried dish of wide rice noodles that are near-black with dark soy sauce, with a yellow orb of egg yolk in the center; its flavor is sultry and craggy from smoked clams and *wok hei*. *Rojak*, a spicy-savory fruit salad that's a signature Malaysian dish, is made with seasonal fruit (guava and pineapple, among others, on my visits), plus crunchy cucumbers tossed in a gorgeous dressing tangy with fermented shrimp paste. Hainanese chicken—the dish that started it all—is available at dinner, and is impeccable: a steamy, silky half bird, foot coquettishly still attached, alongside a cluster of bowls containing sauces, rice, and a broth that strikes the ideal midpoint between fussy from-scratch freshness and bouillon nostalgia. I especially loved a dish of abacus seeds—chewy little dumplings made from taro, which the menu cheekily identifies as "gnocchi," sauteed with smoked mushrooms and fiery chiles.

Helen, Help Me!

[E-mail your questions](#) about dining, eating, and anything food-related, and Helen may respond in a future newsletter.

Low didn't originally set out to become a restaurateur—he's a filmmaker by training, and he's cited the works of [Wong Kar Wai](#) as a primary influence on the interior design of Kelang. The space, previously a medical office, is boxy, with a certain high-ceilinged sterility, but Low has staged it like a movie set to conjure a lush, melancholy romanticism, with deep-red banquettes, tropical vines, gilt-edged mirrors, and, at the U-shaped bar, bent-bamboo chairs, with a boudoir-pink fringe. If the low, blushing lighting doesn't get you in the mood for love, maybe a drink will help: a Martini dirtied up with a splash of fish sauce, a Negroni with notes of cherry blossom and lemongrass, or a Longsan Lahhh, a note-perfect non-alcoholic cocktail with smoky tea, fruit juice, and a bit of chile-pepper heat. Service, on my visits, was a bit spacey, but it's been tightening up; the tone of the place seems to be in progress, too, oscillating between that of a neighborhood joint, an amorous date-night nook, and a sceney hot spot. But that sort of multiplicity plays well here: Kelang is a little bit of many things, all wrapped up together, in a way that totally works. ♦

[Helen Rosner](#), a staff writer at *The New Yorker*, has received multiple James Beard Awards, including one in 2025 for her [Profile of the food personality Padma Lakshmi](#).

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The Talk of the Town

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By David Remnick | From the first day of his Presidency, Trump has posed an emergency to both his country and the world.

- **[Sam Wang, Politician-in-Training](#)**

By Gabriel Debenedetti | The neuroscientist went from analyzing elections to running for Congress. But can this rookie win over New Jersey locals—and Trump voters?

- **[What Wallace Shawn Did Before His “Moth Days”](#)**

By Sarah Larson | When the two lead actresses in Shawn’s play called in sick, their understudies scrambled to prep in the dressing room. The stand-ins? Deborah Eisenberg and Shawn himself.

- **[Sandy Liang Puts a Bow on It](#)**

By Emilia Petrarca | The designer will add frills to anything—from Dr. Dre headphones to Gap hoodies. At the Frick’s “Ruffles & Ribbons” exhibit, she confronts the deeper meaning of decadence.

- **[Ed Solomon’s Family Portrait](#)**

By Emma Allen | The screenwriter’s latest film, “The Christophers,” stars Ian McKellen as a lapsed artist. While gallery-hopping, Solomon reflects on his relationship with his painter mother, who recently put down her own paintbrush.

[Comment](#)

Trump's Strategic and Moral Failure in Iran

From the first day of his Presidency, Trump has posed an emergency to both his country and the world.

By [David Remnick](#)

April 10, 2026



Photo illustration by Cristiana Couceiro; Source photographs from Getty

Not many years ago, a ruthless man with an uneasy mind took power in his country and created a cult of personality. In the center of the capital, he erected a gold statue of himself that rotated with the sun. He stashed billions in a foreign bank. He closed the academy of sciences, the ballet, the philharmonic, the circus, and all provincial libraries. His autobiography became the nation's spiritual guide. He banned dogs from the capital for their "unappealing odor." He renamed the months: January for himself, April for his mother. He was fond of melons. The second Sunday of August became National Melon Day. Such was the world of Saparmurat Niyazov,

Turkmenistan's leader from 1985 until his death, by cardiac arrest, in 2006. For the Turkmen people, there was nothing comical about life under his dictatorship. He barred dissent and packed his jails with prisoners of conscience. The only consolation was that he could not impose his grandiosity on the globe.

Donald Trump, by contrast, has, from the first day of his Presidency, posed an emergency to both his country and the world, even as he has ceaselessly invoked the language of "emergency" to inflate threats, suspend norms, and expand his own power. A decade ago, he was already making statements that flouted the ordinary standards of adult behavior. When it came to North Korea, for example, he alternated between cooing words of affection for Kim Jong Un and issuing taunts that mixed nuclear brinkmanship with masculine insecurity: "I too have a Nuclear Button, but it is a much bigger & more powerful one than his, and my Button works!"

Trump embodies the notion that, with age, you become what you always were, only more so. In the final days of the 2024 campaign, he met with the *Wall Street Journal's* editorial board. When asked whether he would deploy the U.S. military if China, under Xi Jinping, were to blockade Taiwan, Trump replied, "I wouldn't have to, because he respects me, and he knows I'm fucking crazy."

The MAGA coalition has long countenanced Trump's bigotry and cruelty. But now, with the repeated violations of an America First foreign policy, his poll numbers have plummeted. Since returning to office, Trump has ordered military strikes on Iraq, Nigeria, Somalia, Syria, Yemen, Venezuela, and Iran, and has felt little need to provide a coherent rationale for any of them. According to reporting by Maggie Haberman and Jonathan Swan, of the *Times*, Trump and his national-security advisers gathered in the Situation Room on February 11th to listen to the Israeli Prime Minister, Benjamin Netanyahu, argue for a coordinated attack on Iran. Even though the Secretary of State, Marco Rubio, the C.I.A. director, John Ratcliffe, and the chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff, Dan Caine, made their reservations plain—Rubio called Netanyahu's talk of regime change "bullshit"—Trump blundered ahead. And, as in the days of the Turkmen dictator, everyone fell into line.

But when the Iranian regime failed to collapse or capitulate, when Netanyahu's prediction of a national uprising failed to materialize, Trump turned to threats of war crimes and genocide against the very people he claimed to be helping liberate:

A whole civilization will die tonight, never to be brought back again. I don't want that to happen, but it probably will. However, now that we have Complete and Total Regime Change, where different, smarter, and less radicalized minds prevail, maybe something revolutionarily wonderful can happen, WHO KNOWS?

These were not the words of a strategist. They were the words of a maniac. And they had a galvanizing effect, though hardly in the way Trump might have intended. Some of his erstwhile acolytes—Marjorie Taylor Greene, Tucker Carlson, Alex Jones—seem to have woken up to how dangerous he has always been. Yet around the Cabinet table, at Mar-a-Lago, and in the Republican caucus on Capitol Hill, it is gospel that his deranged threats forced a ceasefire and scored a major victory. The President's war, though, seems poised to achieve little that was not already available through prewar diplomacy, or through some renewed version of the Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action, or J.C.P.O.A., the Iran nuclear deal secured by the Obama Administration.

In fact, the original sin of this disaster was Trump's abandonment of that deal, in 2018. For all its limits, it had stalled Iran's march toward an atomic weapon. But Netanyahu, long eager for a full-scale war against Iran—aimed not only at its nuclear program but at its proxies, such as Hezbollah—shrewdly played on Trump's vanity and his contempt for Barack Obama. Trump destroyed the J.C.P.O.A. with nothing to replace it.

So the war stands as a strategic failure and a moral calamity. The ceasefire is already fragile. "The whole point of this exercise was supposedly to advance the cause of freedom in Iran," Karim Sadjadpour, a Washington-based specialist on the country, said. "To go from 'help is on the way' to 'we are going to wipe out your civilization' is strategic malpractice." According to Danny Citrinowicz, an Iran expert who formerly worked in Israeli intelligence, Trump's principal envoys to the region, Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner, almost certainly misread Iran's capabilities and

intentions. “This is a colossal disaster and should never have happened,” Citrinowicz said, noting that it will “haunt the region and world for many years to come.”

In the opening days of the war, the United States and Israel killed Ayatollah Ali Khamenei and wiped out much of Iran’s defense and intelligence leadership, apparently believing that the regime would somehow give way to “moderates” and “pragmatists.” Instead, the theocracy and the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps remain in place, equally radical, equally repressive, and more determined than ever to acquire the ultimate deterrent: a nuclear weapon. Why give up that pursuit, as Libya did, and leave yourself exposed, when you can, like North Korea, achieve it and deter attack?

Trump has gone far toward shattering what’s left of America’s global stature. His preposterous bluster about Greenland, Cuba, and *NATO* has undermined the postwar alliance. He has humiliated and betrayed the Ukrainian President, Volodymyr Zelensky. And all the while Vladimir Putin, who aims to press Ukraine for still more territory, and Xi Jinping, who keeps Taiwan in view, watch the spectacle of Donald Trump for what it reveals about both his instability and the cratering credibility of American leadership.

In the midst of the war, Trump released plans for his Presidential library. Its centerpiece will be an auditorium with an immense gold statue of himself. Whether it will turn with the sun is not yet known. ♦

David Remnick has been the editor of *The New Yorker* since 1998 and a staff writer since 1992. He is the author of seven books; the most recent is “[Holding the Note](#),” a collection of his profiles of musicians.

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[Stump Dept.](#)

Sam Wang, Politician-in-Training

The neuroscientist went from analyzing elections to running for Congress. But can this rookie win over New Jersey locals—and Trump voters?

By [Gabriel Debenedetti](#)

April 13, 2026



Illustration by João Fazenda

Veronica, a pug with a spiky pink collar, trudged alongside her sister Betty, a thirteen-year-old hound, in Princeton one recent wet morning. They were led by their owner, the neuroscientist and brand-new congressional

candidate Sam Wang, who was out looking for voters. Wang, who is fifty-eight and wore rectangular glasses and a big blue campaign button, is still getting the hang of interacting with would-be constituents. A few weeks earlier, he had walked through a snowstorm to a pancake restaurant. “My wife said, ‘If you’re really serious about this, you will ask everybody in this diner for their signature,’ ” he recalled. “I said, ‘My God, do I have to?’ ”

Wang had grown accustomed to another side of politics. His academic work is on early brain development, but for the past decade he has been a celebrity among online liberals and election nerds. In 2004, he started aggregating Presidential polls and became a prominent enough analyst that *Time* named his rivalry with Nate Silver one of its “Top 10 Feuds” of 2014. Two years later, *Wired* crowned him the “new king of the presidential election data mountain” just before Election Day; soon afterward, he swallowed a cricket on CNN because he’d publicly vowed that if Donald Trump earned more than two hundred and forty electoral votes, he’d “eat a bug.” He then turned his focus to electoral reforms, especially on gerrymandering, and advised New Jersey on its map-drawing in 2021. So far, in his campaign, he said, “I’m extremely tempted to do my own data work. But there are other smart data workers. Only I can go meet voters.”

Wang is one of thirteen candidates running in June’s Democratic primary to represent an educated, diverse, mostly progressive district. His platform includes defending science and abolishing *ICE* and the Electoral College. He recently argued outside a Princeton movie theatre with a voter who insisted that the only research grants losing funding were “D.E.I. grants.” “And I’m, like, ‘When I write a grant on sensory processing and how it influences dendritic pruning, that is not a D.E.I. grant,’ ” he said.

Eventually, Betty stopped and squatted. Wang grimaced, eying his neighbor’s yard. “Betty, we’re going to learn the word ‘easement,’ ” he said. He concluded that there were no voters on this walk and headed for home. He was due at a nearby café to thank his volunteers.

Outside the café, a nuclear-policy expert thanked him for running, and a small crowd formed. One man, John, said he was an independent voter—he’d volunteered for Trump—and asked for Wang’s position on Iran (Wang: we need congressional approval to declare war) and illegal immigration

(*ICE* isn't the answer). He told Wang that he was concerned about communism, and Wang shared that his own parents had fled China in 1949.

John took out his phone. "I'm reading about you right now on Wikipedia. In 2016, you predicted Hillary would win?"

"It's important to own mistakes," Wang said, a politician already.

A campaign volunteer approached: the café was packed, so they were relocating to a seafood restaurant two doors down. Wang turned to his supporters, who included a pediatrician, a genomics researcher, and a Princeton University neuroscience colleague. They celebrated getting Wang on the ballot, and the conversation drifted to A.I. "I find A.I. to be kind of impressive, but also scary," Wang said. "When people were first discovering radiation—'Oh, radiation's really good. We should put radium in everything! We should put radium in beverages!' We're in this weird, unregulated moment in A.I. where we just think it's wonderful and put it everywhere: 'Let's put A.I. in TVs! Let's put A.I. in our furniture!'"

The regulation talk brought them back to Trump. Neha Saraiya, the pediatrician, said that she'd seen an explosion in vaccine skepticism. "It's like my knowledge went out the window after hard-earned years of God knows, medical-school debt, and everything. It's like there's no value to science."

Wang nodded, firmly. These days, he said, "it is harder to see causes and effects. Look at Trump! Trump is somehow acting surprised that the price of gas is going up." He laughed. "Someone online said your average Warhammer player would be better at waging this war than Donald Trump."

As the volunteers packed up, Wang turned to Roy Sparrow, an eighty-six-year-old former N.Y.U. professor in a campaign hat, to talk about the No Kings rally happening the next day at his retirement community. Wang told Sparrow, a veteran of both the Air Force and the protests at Berkeley in the sixties, that he thought he'd seen a "Heart tribute band" on the schedule—was it an homage to the rock group from Seattle? Sparrow, who plays the ukulele, clarified: "We call ourselves the Heartthrobs because many of us have heart conditions."

A woman wearing headphones waved to Wang. Smelling a potential voter, he started to approach, but then stopped. “I would’ve said hi to her,” he said. “But she seemed like she was on the phone.” ♦

[Gabriel Debenedetti](#) writes about politics. He is the author of “[The Long Alliance: The Imperfect Union of Joe Biden and Barack Obama](#).”

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What Wallace Shawn Did Before His “Moth Days”

When the two lead actresses in Shawn’s play called in sick, their understudies scrambled to prep in the dressing room. The stand-ins? Deborah Eisenberg and Shawn himself.

By [Sarah Larson](#)

April 13, 2026



Illustration by João Fazenda

On April 1st, in a cozy subterranean dressing room at Greenwich House Theatre, before curtain for Wallace Shawn’s play “What We Did Before Our Moth Days,” two understudies prepared for their débuts. The play has four characters: a husband (Josh Hamilton), a wife (Maria Dizzia), their son (John Early), and the husband’s secret girlfriend (Hope Davis). That day, Dizzia and Davis had both tested positive for *COVID*, so Shawn, eighty-

two, and his partner, Deborah Eisenberg, eighty, had agreed to fill in—Eisenberg as the wife and Shawn as the girlfriend. The switcheroo was particularly charged because “Moth Days” centers on an urbane Manhattan family with strong similarities to and differences from Shawn’s own: Dick, the husband, is a happy-go-lucky novelist (the playwright’s father, William Shawn, was the editor of this magazine for thirty-five years); Elaine, the mistress, is a pulp-fiction writer (William Shawn had a decades-long relationship with one of his star reporters, Lillian Ross); Tim, the son, is an articulate wastrel.

The dressing room had a haimish vibe: red floor, lighted mirrors, chessboard. Shawn, script in hand, wore a black heated jacket and jeans; he sat beside Early, mustachioed and leather-jacketed. “We haven’t had a chance to read through this scene,” Shawn said. “And we only have twenty-six minutes.” They began rehearsing, observed by Eisenberg, white-haired and composed; Hamilton, putting socks on; and the producer Scott Rudin, beaming, in a tan sweater and sneakers adorned with cartoon eyeballs. In the scene, the son and the girlfriend meet for a glass of wine to discuss the father, who has died.

“I think you and I would have liked each other!” Shawn, as the girlfriend, said, in his inimitable way: incisive, melodic, wry. “I said to your father all the time, ‘Look, I know it would be a little bit dishonest, but couldn’t the three of us just secretly meet?’ ” In the background, Hamilton took photographs.

“Moth Days” is directed, with minimal staging, by Shawn’s collaborator of many decades, André Gregory. The characters sit in chairs and speak in eloquent monologues, “My Dinner with André” style.

“I guess he figured that if you and he and I had been secretly visiting with each other, that would add to the sneakiness and sleaziness of the whole situation,” Shawn, as the girlfriend, went on. (“Company, this is your half-hour call,” a voice on the P.A. said.) A few beats later, Early, as Tim, said that he was raised “to be so decent, and yet I’m as sleazy as they come!” They laughed. “Maybe it’s for the best that we didn’t ever meet,” Early said. “These two sleazy people. We might have become mean.”

“Mean! Yes! Mean! Mean!” Shawn cried. They laughed more, as did Rudin, who seemed to be having the time of his life.

Early, as himself, said, “I’m not going to say the next line. In the play, I will.” It was 6:41 *P.M.* “Oh, my God.” He pointed at Shawn and Eisenberg and announced, “The two of them should eat something.” Eisenberg walked to Shawn and rubbed his balding head affectionately.

“It’ll be amazing! A total blast,” Rudin said.

Onstage, Shawn apologized to the audience for the changeup, but said that, understudy-wise, “Deborah Eisenberg and I are, frankly, the people in New York City most equipped to play these parts.” The audience laughed. The performance went well—the chemistry between Shawn and Early a particular highlight. The actors bowed, looking relieved. Back in the dressing room, the mood was buoyant.



“LIKE AND SUBSCRIBEE!”
Cartoon by Olivia Noble

“It was surreal and wonderful,” Hamilton said.

“Extremely weird,” Eisenberg said.

“It was Scott’s idea for Deborah and me to be the understudies, many months ago,” Shawn said. “Of course, the expectation is that the understudy will never go on.”

“That’s certainly what I expected,” Eisenberg said. They’d got the call that morning. “I’d just finished preparing my taxes, which is where my mind

has been,” she said. “All my anxiety has been about my taxes and not about doing the show.”

“I wrote it, but we’ve both seen it many, many times,” Shawn said. “We do know the play well.”

“Speak for yourself,” Eisenberg said. “I love the play, but it’s vast, vast. It keeps unfolding.” The cast had rehearsed “Moth Days” for more than a year and a half, Shawn said. “And, inevitably, it’s absorbed into their bones.”

Eisenberg added, “And the premise is, I don’t even know how to articulate this, but you’re not pretending anything. You’re having an experience. Maria Dizzia is uncanny, phenomenal. But there’s no way I could try to be like Maria. I could only do it as I can do it.”

“André wouldn’t want us to imitate them,” Shawn said. “That would be absolutely against his way of working.”

Would they reprise these roles the next night? “Of course, unless Scott was horrified,” Shawn said. “But, you know, I haven’t seen him in such a good mood for a long time.” ♦

[Sarah Larson](#), a staff writer, has been contributing to The New Yorker since 2007.

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[Trimmings Dept.](#)

Sandy Liang Puts a Bow on It

The designer will add frills to anything—from Dr. Dre headphones to Gap hoodies. At the Frick’s “Ruffles & Ribbons” exhibit, she confronts the deeper meaning of decadence.

By [Emilia Petrarca](#)

April 13, 2026



Illustration by João Fazenda

The fashion designer Sandy Liang recently boarded a hundred-year-old wood-panelled elevator in the basement of the Frick Collection and rode it to the museum’s first floor. There, she was ushered into the Cabinet Gallery for a private preview of “Ruffles & Ribbons,” a new exhibition of two

dozen fashion plates, the hand-colored engravings that preceded fashion magazines, from the time of Marie Antoinette.

It's a title that could be given to any of Liang's recent collections, which feature a multitude of ruffles, ribbons, and bows—a dress from her Fall 2026 show was made entirely of the latter. One logo for her eponymous brand, which she founded in 2014 after graduating from Parsons, is a bright-pink bow. From her store on Orchard Street, not far from her family's Cantonese restaurant, Congee Village, she's sold bow-shaped earrings, leather bags with bows, bow-adorned puffer jackets (for humans and dogs), and hair bows of every ilk. Last year, partnering with Gap, she put bows on hoodies, trenchcoats, and jeans. She's also teamed up with Beats by Dre for bow-patterned headphones, and with the Japanese brand Subu for beribboned pink slippers. Collectively, her designs call to mind the 2011 "Portlandia" sketch "Put a Bird on It!"—only with a different "B" word.

In 2023, social media pronounced Liang the leader of a "great bow-pocalypse." The trend was so prolific that, in September of that year, a headline in the *Times* asked, "Have We Officially Reached Peak Ribbon?"

As the Frick's "Ruffles & Ribbons" proves, there is no such thing. Organized by the curatorial fellow Yifu Liu, the show has trimmings in just about every frame. The idea was to lure visitors in with notions of decadence and frills, and then force them to confront the harsh realities of imperialism, colonialism, and the relentlessness of the fashion cycle. "Even the simplest, most frivolous fashions carry all these histories with them," Liu said. "We named it 'Ruffles & Ribbons' kind of as a subversion. We made it so cute and so delicious. But, when you look at these images and you read the captions, you realize, Oh, these are historically significant works of art."

The first plate depicts the world's earliest bow-fluencer, Marie Antoinette. In it, she wears an elaborate red court gown with a wide hoop. In the second, a woman wears a *chemise à la reine*, a style of white dress the Queen popularized "that looks like what you're wearing," Liu said, pointing at Liang, who had on a white poplin baby-doll dress, with ribbons embroidered on the sleeves, and tulip-print leggings—both of her own

design. Liu was wearing a black blazer, starched white culottes, and black oxfords.

Liang, a longtime follower of *Marie Antoinette* (Sofia Coppola's 2006 biopic is one of her favorite movies), was eager to learn more about the Queen's shopping habits. She *oohed* when Liu explained that ruffles were originally used to hide seams, which were left mostly unfixed so that expensive fabric could be reused when trends inevitably changed, and *aahed* at the sight of a *lévite*, an Ottoman-inspired open-front gown that was tied at the waist with a ribbon, which Marie Antoinette wore when she was pregnant.

With a seemingly unlimited clothing budget and access to goods and ideas from around the globe, the Queen had a vast, ever-evolving wardrobe. This meant that the public was constantly racing to keep up, turning to fashion plates to see, for example, whether they should style their curls in tall, "Bridgerton"-esque poufs or let them dangle from under a hat. Each year, Marie Antoinette ordered up to three hundred new gowns, and the winds changed accordingly.

"You've kind of killed the romance for me," Liang said at the end of the tour. "Fashion nowadays is so fast—nobody has any time to think. You just have to put stuff out. I always thought that in Marie Antoinette's day, you bought what you liked. But even she, or the women of that era, felt the pressure." She sighed. "And there wasn't even Instagram."

Liu nodded: "It was intensely stressful for them." Even worse, he added, "a lot of these women had gout."

In a pink, chandeliered room in the Gilded Age mansion of a dead steel magnate, the past and present melded in a manner that was both unsettling and affirming. (Everyone knows what happened to Marie Antoinette.) In many ways, Liang felt validated. "The thing about ribbons and bows—do you ever get tired of them? I still get excited when I see a bow in a painting."

At the end of the visit, an employee who wore bow-shaped earrings pointed out a wooden chest with gilded detailing that had belonged to Marie

Antoinette. Liang bent down to examine it. “Look!” she said, pointing to a motif in the center. “A bow.” ♦

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[The Pictures](#)

Ed Solomon's Family Portrait

The screenwriter's latest film, "The Christophers," stars Ian McKellen as a lapsed artist. While gallery-hopping, Solomon reflects on his relationship with his mother, who recently put down her own paintbrush.

By [Emma Allen](#)

April 13, 2026



Illustration by João Fazenda

"You know how sometimes you don't know what something is really about?" the London-based screenwriter Ed Solomon ("Men in Black," the "Bill & Ted" movies) cryptically asked the other day, in SoHo. "And, in fact, you block yourself emotionally from it completely?" The question was

posed in a claustrophobe's nightmare of an unmarked elevator, entered from street level, which felt like it could lead anywhere—perhaps to Socrates' Athens or the Mongol Empire. The destination, alas, was only the Tara Downs art gallery.

"I like this piece," Solomon noted, peering at a semiabstract work by Sofía Sinibaldi, "Remediation (The Past Creates the Future)." His latest film, "The Christophers," directed by Steven Soderbergh, features Michaela Coel as a disillusioned young painter who's hired by the money-grubbing children of a bitter, lapsed artist (Ian McKellen) to forge some of his unfinished portraits. Coel signs on as McKellen's assistant; shifts in desiderata and allegiance ensue.

"I always wanted to make a movie about the relationships that I've had with certain mentors," Solomon said—specifically, four male figures who, feeling villainized or betrayed, retreated from the public eye. Over pints one night, Soderbergh mentioned toying with the idea of a "chamber kind of thing—think of 'The Dresser,' but with more of a Patricia Highsmith bent." Maybe this was Solomon's chance.

They shot the film in nineteen days, in 2025. Solomon realized recently that his mother, Maxine, had inspired the script, too. "She's a painter! She quit for nine years to be a parent. But she returned to it." She's since had to retire, at ninety-two. Solomon pulled up Maxine's website, where she quotes the artist Richard Diebenkorn: "I can never accomplish what I want. Only what I would have wanted had I thought of it beforehand." Maxine used both additive and subtractive painting processes to build textured canvases. "The more she did, the more she would obfuscate," Solomon said.

His mother taught him "never to paint within the lines," a lesson he plans to impart to his youngest, crayon-wielding child. In "The Christophers," Coel's character first starts painting after seeing the show "Enfant Terrible," made up of work created by art stars in their youth. McKellen's character supplied a piece titled "Anyone Can Do This and Call It Art."

At Dimin gallery, Solomon studied a blue-and-orange canvas, and explained that his mom favored a specific type of paintbrush. Around

twenty-five years ago, the manufacturer stopped making them. “They were basically dead stock,” Solomon said. She rallied her artist friends around San Francisco to all order a bunch.

“Every year, she’d go through *one* brush,” Solomon said. “And two years ago was her last brush. I have photos of her holding that brush.” McKellen’s character hasn’t painted in decades. He’s kept himself afloat by slinging quips on a reality-TV show called “Art Fight” (he tells one contestant to title a piece “Why My Therapist Chose Early Retirement No. 7”) and filming Cameo videos for fans, in a blue beret, by the glow of a ring light.

At Bortolami gallery, Solomon said that he had consulted the Pop artist Jann Haworth, who co-designed the “Sgt. Pepper” album cover, to get a sense of the British art world of McKellen’s character’s prime. “When Michaela is verbally undressing Ian, and basically saying, ‘I know you better than you think I know you, and I know you maybe even better than you are willing to acknowledge you know yourself’—I wrote a version of that speech with Jann’s help,” Solomon said. He also sent it to his mother for review.

Solomon strolled over to the Odeon, for some art respite and fries, and recounted watching both “Bill & Ted’s Excellent Adventure” and “The Christophers” at a Toronto film festival, during which he’d noticed a through line: “ ‘Bill & Ted’ is a film about the exuberance of two very optimistic people who really believe that their art”—a metal band called Wyld Stallyns—“matters, and that they will live forever through their art. And then here you have this movie about two people who have given up on the idea of letting others see their work.”

Another adviser on “The Christophers” was the art restorer Lisa Rosen, who offered tips on pulling off a convincing restoration (or forgery). “She was talking about literally the ability now to find an artist’s DNA on material,” Solomon said. In the film, Coel digs up some of McKellen’s old paintbrushes that she says “have been dead stock for decades” and remarks, “The microfibres alone would vet—huge.” ♦

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Why I Wanted to Keep My Marriage a Secret

It's not that I was embarrassed by Hugh or that I thought someone better might come along. I just shudder when I hear a man say the words "my husband."

By [David Sedaris](#)

April 13, 2026



Illustration by Jack Smyth

There's a lunch place Hugh and I often take people to in Amsterdam. I like it because it's quick—no waiting around for menus or the check. You order and pay at the counter, and the food is good, which is to say that it's not too Dutch. At night, a leisurely meal is fine, but in a city where the stores open late and close relatively early, I can always feel the clock ticking, especially if one or more of my sisters is with me.

On my most recent visit, it was Gretchen. The restaurant was half full when we arrived and took a table beside a group of six people in their early thirties. I guessed that they were in the middle of a business lunch and that their business was something I would never be able to understand: they optimized output strategies or were leasing the letter "W" to some country that never knew it needed it. None of them sounded like a native English

speaker, but that was the language they were all using. “Me, I will be getting married next summer,” said one of the three men in their party after they’d all put their tablets and laptops away. He was balding and seemed to have no eyebrows.

“Congratulations!” said the woman seated across from him. Then they all raised their glasses in a toast.

“Do you think you’ll get married next summer?” I asked Gretchen, who is two years my junior and was wearing a tentlike black-and-white striped dress that looked good with her long silver hair. It was a ridiculous question, like asking if she might become a stripper or an electrician.

“I can’t,” she said.

Hugh asked why, and she pointed at me with her fork. “When I was twelve, David made me sign a contract swearing I’d stay single for the rest of my life.”

“I forgot all about that,” I said.

Gretchen turned to Hugh. “He made Amy sign one, too.”

“Why?” Hugh asked.

“I didn’t want to lose them,” I said. “You know how it is—girls get married, then they start having kids and you never see them again or never want to, because they’ve been remolded by their awful, controlling husbands.”

“O.K.,” Hugh said. “But a contract?”

“I drew them up all the time,” I told him. “Once, I bought Amy and Tiffany’s bedroom for a dollar. They were in kindergarten and the second grade and thought that, with fifty cents each, they were rich now.”

All these years later, I could still see their room so clearly: its dark, almost black wood panelling, their checkerboard-tiled floor. It was three times the size of mine and a lot quieter. I’d just bullied their mattresses into the hall

when my mother showed up and put an end to it. “But I have a contract!” I told her. “They signed it. The matter has been legally settled.”

The bedroom exchange never went through, but both Amy and Gretchen have honored our 1970 agreement. Gretchen has a long-term boyfriend who lives in another town, but Amy hasn’t even dated since the early two-thousands. I used to refer to them as spinsters. Then I learned that, historically, the word applies only to unmarried women up to the age of twenty-five or so. After that, they’re called thornbacks, a thornback being a bottom-feeding skatelike fish with sharp spikes running along its spine.

Meanwhile, an unmarried man of the same age is simply called a bachelor, or, in gaming circles, a wizard.

Often I think that I did my sisters, particularly Amy, a favor. Oh, to be single and accountable to no one. Then Hugh will do something sweet and I’ll remember that it can actually be nice to have someone around. Recently, for example, he trimmed my toenails. I used to do it myself, but now I have arthritis in my back and can only reach my feet in Arizona.

I didn’t *ask* Hugh to clip my nails. He just saw two of my toes poking out from the holes they’d stabbed in my socks and offered. Watching him tackle the worst of it with a pipe cutter, I thought of a poorly drawn syndicated comic strip that used to run in the Raleigh newspaper. Each pictured a boy and girl who were naked but had no genitalia. “Love is” was written near the top of the frame, then every day, beneath it, there would be an example: “love is . . . laughing at the same old joke,” “ . . . wearing ‘his’ and ‘hers’ T-shirts,” “ . . . quietly watching a hummingbird having lunch.”

I don’t recall “love is . . . clipping his amber, daggerlike toenails,” but then, I didn’t read it every day.

Of course, love is different from marriage. It can exist within a marriage, flickering like a tea-light candle at the bottom of a hurricane glass, but it’s hardly guaranteed to endure. That’s why one doesn’t want to draw too much attention to it. Having a wedding or an engagement party, running off to couples therapy, renewing your vows: isn’t that all just courting disaster?

How hypocritical that of me, Amy, and Gretchen, the only one married is me. It happened in 2016 and was done secretly—it was essentially a shotgun wedding, completely the idea of my banker, Cindy, and undertaken solely for financial reasons. We did it at the county courthouse in the small town of Beaufort, North Carolina. Entering the building late that spring morning meant passing through a metal detector. *This is the last time I'll empty my pockets as a single person*, I thought, surrendering my wallet and the old man's leather coin purse I've carried since 1992.

Neither Hugh nor I was particularly dressed up, though we weren't slobs, either. We probably looked as if we were being audited: slacks, freshly ironed button-down shirts, and the facial expressions you assume after learning that the doctor who'll be checking your prostate decided to grow his nails out. At least that was my expression. *Just close your eyes and think of the money you'll be saving*, I told myself.

I guess that, during the ceremony, I recited whatever words I was instructed to: "I solemnly swear" and "in sickness and in health." Hugh and I would never kiss in public, so at the end we shook hands. Neither of us choked up. The wedding took a matter of minutes. Afterward we thanked the magistrate and the white-haired stranger who acted as our second witness. Then we went with our banker to a sad sandwich place for lunch.

Aside from saving money, all I cared about was keeping my marriage a secret. It's not that I was embarrassed by Hugh or that I thought someone better might come along. I just shudder when I hear a man say the words "my husband." Something about it sets off alarm bells in me. It's like "my unicycle" or "my rescue ferret"—just creepy. Before same-sex marriage became legal, I hated the word "partner."

"Is that your partner?" someone would ask, referring to Hugh.

"My boyfriend," I'd correct them.

Now it's, "Is that your husband?" People just assume it for some reason.

"God, no," I say. "He's just my boyfriend."

I have lied in interviews, on forms; wherever the question is asked, the answer is “Nope. We just live together.” My best friend doesn’t know that I’m married. Neither does Amy, Gretchen, or anyone else in my family. Hugh and I don’t celebrate our anniversary, and I’d be at a complete loss if asked to give the month, much less the date. The season I recall, but nothing else. Years go by without my remembering it ever happened, then Hugh will threaten to divorce me, and I’ll say, “How can you divorce me when we were never . . . fuck.”

In this day and age, can’t I be a husband but *identify* as a boyfriend?

I think of all the wedding pictures I see in the *Times*, both gay and straight. The people who plan years in advance, who spend great fortunes, and for what? You love someone. You want to build a life together—great, but why bother other people with it? Why make them buy unflattering outfits and get on airplanes to places only you think are fun? Why do they have to give you gifts or, worse still, listen to your handcrafted vows, which are always just a string of clichés: “When we met, I knew I’d found my soulmate.”

I’ve never liked that term, but I think I might hate its replacement even more: “My person.”

Honestly?, I think whenever I hear it. Let’s say that in a world of more than eight billion people there is a single individual who was meant to fit you like a puzzle piece. What are the odds, then, that they live in your same apartment complex or that the two of you wound up at the same community college eight miles from your house and six and a half from theirs? Why has no one you’ve ever known found their person standing outside an electronics superstore in Busan, South Korea, or baking bricks in a kiln in India? Why do so very few people have to leave their state, let alone their country, to find the one person they’re supposedly meant for?

I met Hugh twelve blocks from my apartment in New York and often wonder, *What if I hadn’t gone with my friend Lily to his loft to borrow a ladder that night? What if we’d missed each other?* Had that been the case, he’d have found someone else, as would I, most likely. I never had that “There you are!” feeling, the way my sister Gretchen did a few days before we went to Amsterdam, when she found a Daniela Gregis blouse at the

Dover Street Market in London. It was made of thick cotton and was white on the outside and soft pink on the inside, like a shell. “I have been looking for this shirt all my life,” she said, holding it to her face and breathing it in, the way I’ve seen people do when reunited with a lost child.

I was happy to meet Hugh. I hoped it might work out between us and am delighted that it has. When I tell people that we’re breaking up after thirty-five years together—which I do all the time as a joke—hardly anyone believes me, which is frustrating but also a sign that to our friends and family we seem like a pretty good fit.

Married, though!

My father thought that was all his daughters were good for. “That guy’s just taking advantage of you,” he said when Amy, aged twenty-three, moved in with her Greek boyfriend in Raleigh, and Gretchen, not long afterward, moved in with her Greek boyfriend in Providence, Rhode Island.

I said to him, “At least they’re Greek.” But he wanted all of the boxes ticked. Lisa got married. So did Paul. Tiffany had boyfriends but never married any of them, most often because they already had wives.

I hadn’t presented any of those siblings with contracts, though. It wasn’t that I didn’t like them, just that I could bear the thought of losing them to their new families. We’d write, I’d imagined. Every so often we’d talk on the phone. Plans would be sketched for shared vacations, but something would probably come up.

With Amy and Gretchen, it was different. I drew up their contracts because I didn’t want anyone else in their hearts. At fourteen, I didn’t know that you could actually stuff quite a few people in there and still have room left for hobbies and addictions. My sisters certainly haven’t lost me to Hugh. If anything, it was our careers that posed a threat to our time together.

That’s something that never occurred to me when I was in the eighth grade, maybe because I couldn’t imagine myself with an actual profession. I mean, could a person make a *living* jerking off into an athletic sock?

I remember learning a few years back that a close friend had undergone treatment for breast cancer. We were in contact during her hospitalization and recovery, yet she never mentioned a word of it. When she finally told me, I felt relieved that she was O.K. but also insulted and shut out. Would that be Amy's and Gretchen's reaction to my marriage? That day in the Amsterdam restaurant, I was right on the verge of confessing, imagining how liberating it might feel to finally come clean, when Hugh stood up and reached for his jacket. "If you two want to hit the next couple of stores on your list, we have to get going," he said.

I looked up at him and thought, *Would it kill you to give me a few extra minutes?* Yet I got to my feet, and willingly. He's so controlling, yet so very handsome, my husband. ♦

[David Sedaris](#) has contributed to *The New Yorker* since 1995. He is the author of the children's book "[The Selfish Sister](#)" and the essay collection "[The Land and Its People](#)," among other books.

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[Onward and Upward with the Arts](#)

Radu Jude, the Bard of Bucharest

The director's native city drives him crazy—and drives him to make loony, brilliant films.

By [Rebecca Mead](#)

April 13, 2026



Jude's films are often collages, combining everything from archival footage to A.I. Photograph by Bogdan Tutuneanu for The New Yorker

A visitor to Bucharest, Romania's capital, will notice that many of the city's buildings—which range from graceful Belle Époque mansions constructed in the late nineteenth century to unlovely apartment complexes thrown up during postwar urbanization—are marked with a bright-red disk. Unlike the blue plaques affixed to residences in London, which indicate where notable figures once lived, or the *Stolpersteine* (or stumbling stones) embedded in the sidewalks of German cities to mark the former homes of Holocaust victims, Bucharest's red disks are not commemorative but predictive. “It means that, in the next earthquake, this building could fall down,” Radu

Jude, the Romanian film director, explained to me recently, when I met him in the capital, his native city.

It's been forty-nine years since Bucharest was last devastated by a major earthquake, on March 4, 1977. Dozens of flimsy apartment buildings collapsed; nearly fifteen hundred residents died. Nicolae Ceaușescu, Romania's Communist leader, seized the opportunity to remake the ravaged city, ordering not just the demolition of compromised structures but a more extensive urban clearance. The entire neighborhood of Uranus, whose historic churches were built along hilly, cobblestoned streets, was razed. In its place rose the grandiose Palace of the Parliament—a neoclassical hulk that is the second-largest administrative building in the world, surpassed only by the Pentagon.

Before the building was completed, Ceaușescu's reign ended in revolution. In December, 1989, at the conclusion of a year when Communist regimes across Eastern Europe were collapsing, Ceaușescu ordered the violent quashing of demonstrations in the western city of Timișoara. Dozens of protesters died, and not long afterward Ceaușescu, while delivering a speech from the balcony of the Communist Party's Bucharest headquarters, was jeered into silence by a furious public. He was soon captured by the Romanian Army as he attempted to flee the country. On Christmas Day, a military tribunal sentenced him to death and executed him by firing squad.

Jude, who was born a month after the 1977 earthquake, was twelve when this political earthquake occurred. "The rumors about what had happened in Timișoara, and how many people were killed, were everywhere," he recalled, as we sat in the office of his video editor, in an elegant villa in central Bucharest. When the revolution happened, he told me, he was spending the Christmas holidays with his grandparents, in a village outside the city, "but it was quite close to a military airport, so you could hear gunshots." After footage of Ceaușescu's corpse was broadcast on television, "there was a huge joy—you could *feel* the change." His grandfather cursed the former leader while Jude's grandmother wept at Ceaușescu's execution—not because she admired him but because, Jude said, "it felt like a loss of something that was essential to her." As it turned out, he noted, "many more people were killed *after* Ceaușescu left, because of the chaos." The

dictator's successor, Ion Iliescu, viciously crushed pro-democracy demonstrations. It took until the end of 1991 for a new constitution to be established.



*"It's Timmy—his future is going to be a dystopian nightmare."
Cartoon by Robert Leighton*

Similarly, Ceaușescu's authoritarian makeover of Bucharest has been dwarfed by unbridled development since the revolution. "The earthquake destroyed houses everywhere," Jude said. "But there was much more destruction, in a paradoxical way, in a free society—by bad planning, bad management, corrupt politicians, and greedy real-estate investors. There are more monuments of architecture destroyed *after* the revolution than in Ceaușescu's time." We headed out into the streets, and Jude led me to sites of vanished historic structures: a nineteenth-century marketplace demolished to accommodate a widened road, an ornate cinema whose only remnants are a few bricks littering a parking lot. As we navigated sidewalks narrowed by late-winter heaps of dirty snow, Jude, who is a big, bearish man with bristly salt-and-pepper hair and a scruff of beard, pointed out the buildings marked with red disks. Other signs warned of danger from crumbling masonry overhead, though there was none of the scaffolding that might accompany such notices. Jude mentioned that a friend of his, who had recently returned from Odesa, in Ukraine, had said that Bucharest resembles a wartime city more than Odesa does.

Jude isn't particularly fond of Bucharest, which is traffic-clogged, bedevilled by corruption, and generally exhausting. And he is afraid of the

next quake—a when-not-if proposition, given Romania’s turbulent geology. Still, apart from his preschool years, when he lived with his grandparents, and a few months in 2023, when he had a fellowship in Berlin, he has spent his entire life there. (He speaks fluent English, the lingua franca of the film industry in Eastern Europe.) Although Romania has a well-documented emigration problem—between the revolution and 2021, the country lost nearly a fifth of its population—Jude prefers to stay put. “For life, it’s terrible, but for cinema it’s a city that reveals itself—that shows what it has behind,” he explained. “Somehow, the ideologies, the politics, the philosophy, the aesthetics—it’s all very easy to grasp. It’s not like other cities, where they look clean but, behind, you find something more shady going on. Here, it’s nothing more complicated than what is obvious.”

As we approached his apartment building, Jude pointed out a Beaux-Arts mansion that had been extended vertically into a complex of modern apartments, with glass balconies hovering above an intricately wrought frontage. “This was also considered a monument,” Jude said. “They had the right to develop it, but they had to keep the façade.” He rapped the surface with his knuckles. Instead of the dull solidity of stone, it had the resonance of hollow wood. Rather than restore the façade, as required, the developer had replaced it with a false one. “It’s just a fake thing, and it’s already falling apart—it’s insulting the intelligence of everyone,” Jude said. The wall was as insubstantial as a set on a film studio’s back lot. “I think they used the same carpenter that we do,” he said.

The unanticipated consequences of transformational change are energetically explored in Jude’s films. He works in a bracingly wide variety of forms, from documentary shorts to dramatic features, and he sometimes combines them—say, with the incorporation of archival footage into a satire, or with an abrupt shift in tone from the essayistic to the narrative. Often, his subject is what he calls the “brutal capitalism” of contemporary Romania, as well as the country’s rising neofascist nationalist movement, which demonizes the European Union—the country became a member in 2007—and valorizes authoritarians of the past, from Vlad the Impaler to Ceaușescu. “To tell people, ‘Now you have freedom of travelling, or of speech’—they say, ‘The problem is we don’t have anything to eat,’ ” Jude explained. “In a certain way, the regime was better for them. The disaster of

the new regime is that it rejected everything that was good, at least in intention, in the Communist society, so the capitalism we have is much harsher than in other, Western countries.”



A still from “I Do Not Care If We Go Down in History as Barbarians” (2019). Photograph by Silviu Ghetie / Courtesy Hi Film Productions

Jude’s first feature film, “The Happiest Girl in the World,” released in 2009, is a bittersweet drama centered on a provincial girl’s conflict with her parents; in its contemporary realism and nuanced social observation, it resembles the work of other directors belonging to the so-called Romanian New Wave, which flourished in the two-thousands. (Jude was an assistant director on one of the standouts from that period, Cristi Puiu’s “The Death of Mr. Lazarescu,” a 2006 film about a dying man who keeps getting turned away by Bucharest hospitals.) But Jude’s subsequent movies have gone in a less conventional direction. In “I Do Not Care If We Go Down in History as Barbarians,” released in 2019, he tackled an event from 1941 that had been expunged from classrooms during the Communist era: the dictator Ion Antonescu’s collaboration with the Nazis in the massacre of tens of thousands of Jews in Odesa. (The title, characteristic of Jude in its vibrant wordiness, comes from a speech by Romania’s foreign minister at the time.) In the film, a modern-day young female director, Mariana, played by Ioana Iacob, stages a reënactment of the massacre at a square in Bucharest. Jude juxtaposes archival footage of Nazi executions with a shocking yet appallingly entertaining reprise of the Odesa massacre; to depict it, he recruited battle reënactors on Facebook. The reputation of Antonescu, who was executed for war crimes in 1946, has been undergoing a perverse rehabilitation by Romania’s far right, and “Barbarians” decries not just the atrocities of the past but also the delusions of the present. “The idea was

that Romanians were always victims, victims, victims, and that we never did anything wrong as a country, as a community, to anybody else,” he said. “And, even if you *don’t* buy the propaganda, it gets into you somehow. You say, ‘Well, I’m Romanian, I would never kill someone.’ And then, when you discover that’s not true, you feel really shaken. *I felt really shaken.*”

In “Do Not Expect Too Much from the End of the World,” released in 2024, Angela Răducanu, an overworked producer of television commercials, spends a hectic day driving ceaselessly around Bucharest’s congested streets. The character, played by Ilinca Manolache, is meeting job candidates for a project commissioned by an Austrian corporation; she needs to cast an injured employee for a worker-safety film. This main narrative, shot in grainy black-and-white Super 16-mm. film, is intercut with color clips from a Romanian movie made during the Ceaușescu era —“Angela Goes On,” directed by Lucian Bratu—which dramatizes the life of a female taxi-driver. In a surreal intertextual turn, Bratu’s Angela, played by Dorina Lazăr, appears in Jude’s contemporary Bucharest. She is now the mother of a grownup son, Ovidiu, who uses a wheelchair because of a work-related injury—and who gets the dubious honor of appearing in the corporate video.

The braiding of an old film into a new one is an inspired device for highlighting history’s continuities and discontinuities. Bratu’s movie was lighthearted in tone, but it had passages that betrayed some of the harsher dimensions of existence under Communism. Jude slows down Bratu’s footage when that director’s camera incidentally captures people waiting in a long line to buy groceries or pans across a street that was later flattened to make way for Ceaușescu’s Palace of the Parliament. Manolache, who has appeared in several of Jude’s movies, told me, “Radu’s films are political, like Godard’s films are. But it’s more than that. They are sensual, they have moments of extreme fragility, and they are very beautiful.” Her character spends her endless day of driving in a sequin-covered T-shirt minidress. The impractical outfit is an expression of Angela Răducanu’s suppressed creativity: her dress dances in the light even as she is immobilized behind the wheel.

“End of the World” offers a potent counterpoint to the German director Maren Ade’s film “Toni Erdmann,” an acclaimed 2016 comedy that stars Sandra Hüller as a German business consultant making her way in Bucharest’s Wild West of neoliberal capitalism. In “Toni Erdmann,” the city is a depressing way station for a striving international executive. Jude, by contrast, looks at Bucharest from the perspective of Romanians, who understandably resent being poor subalterns within the European Union. To help make the point, Jude cast the distinguished German actress Nina Hoss as a haughty Austrian executive, who appears as a privileged outsider scanning the city’s streets from the back seat of Angela Răducanu’s vehicle. Andrei Gorzo and Veronica Lazăr, Romanian film scholars, have described “End of the World” as perhaps “the most relentless cinematic attack on capitalism in the history of Romanian cinema—not excluding its state-socialist era.” Jude said, “During the dictatorship, we believed that whatever is wrong is because it’s a dictatorship. Then, after the revolution, it was something like ‘There is all this chaos because this is still the transition period—there’s no money, it’s a poor country.’ And then, after ten years of that, in the last twenty-five years, it’s obvious that it’s *not* that. It’s just that society is unable to organize itself.”

“Bad Luck Banging or Loony Porn,” which won the Golden Bear in Berlin in 2021, centers on a schoolteacher named Emi whose homemade sex tape accidentally goes viral. A similar scandal befell a Romanian teacher, Oana Zaharia, who lost her job; Jude reached out to her on Facebook, then gave her a small part in the movie. “Bad Luck Banging” scathingly critiques the hypocrisies of Romanian attitudes toward sex; Emi gets pilloried for having what appears to be an enjoyable conjugal relationship, even as the society around her is grotesquely pornified. (A billboard showing a woman’s face tilted upward and her tongue sticking out is accompanied by the slogan “I Like It Deep.”) The film is structured as a triptych, and its second section features vignettes and images that give context to the humiliation that Emi experiences in the third. A clip of a woman performing fellatio is set alongside text noting that “blowjob” is the most frequently searched term in an online dictionary, followed by “empathy”; an archival clip of schoolchildren singing a martial anthem is captioned “Children: political prisoners of their parents.” Jude told me that his predilection for montage was influenced by Sergei Eisenstein, the Russian director. Eisenstein’s

“greatest discovery,” Jude said, was that onscreen you could “put one element next to another, or more, in order to break narrative and create an idea.” Jude went on, “I feel that where there is montage, there is poetry as opposed to narrative, which could be considered prose. I like to mix them.”



The harried protagonist of “Do Not Expect Too Much from the End of the World,” released in 2024. Photograph courtesy 4ProofFilm

Most of Jude’s recent feature films have a female protagonist, many of whom, like Emi, resist the conservative or inhumane forces around them. Jude told me, “Maybe one or two years ago, I would have said it’s pure coincidence. But, given that it’s five films, it must be more than that.” By focussing on female characters, Jude invites sympathy for individuals who are structurally less empowered than their male peers, just as Romania occupies a position of weakness in relation to its European neighbors. Manolache, a prominent feminist figure in Romania, told me, “I don’t know if I would have been able to write something as punk, as powerful, and feminist as Radu did for my part” in “End of the World.” The character of Angela Răducănu, she said, “is very powerful and fearless, and like a beast.” Zaharia told me, “I think Radu is fascinated by women—he thinks women are very complex and very smart. You feel respected, and you don’t feel objectified. You feel like he is interested in your soul, in your mind.”

This spring, Jude is releasing another examination of Romania’s complicated status within Europe, “Kontinental ’25.” The title indicates Jude’s debt to Roberto Rossellini’s “Europe ’51,” in which Ingrid Bergman plays a woman in Italy reckoning with her son’s suicide. The protagonist of “Kontinental ’25” is Orsolya, a former professor of Roman law turned bailiff, played by Eszter Tompa, who is traumatized by the suicide of an elderly homeless man whom she had to turn out of a derelict building that is

going to be converted into a boutique hotel. “Kontinental ’25,” which won the Silver Bear for Best Screenplay at last year’s Berlin Film Festival, combines coruscating satire with profound empathy. The suicide occurs right at the start, and the remainder of the film consists largely of anxious conversations that Orsolya has with others, in which she seeks to express and expiate her feelings of guilt. She and a friend discuss making donations to charity through the sanitizing distance of a monthly surcharge on a mobile-phone bill. Her Orthodox priest reassures her that nobody is without sin. This glib absolution helps Orsolya move past feelings of self-recrimination, and she embarks on a trip to Greece that she’s delayed. But, once Jude shows her heading off, he forces the viewer to focus on the dehumanizing economic forces that caused the suicide in the first place: the film concludes with a long essayistic montage of recently built apartments, any of which could have sheltered the dead man.

“Kontinental ’25” is set in the northern city of Cluj, and Jude shot it in ten days, using an iPhone—a technical challenge that he also set for himself in the making of another movie released this year, “Dracula,” which was filmed with the same crew, equipment, and, in some cases, cast as “Kontinental ’25.” With a budget of only about a million euros for “Dracula,” the doubling up was partly an economic decision, but Jude told me that he was also inspired by Roger Corman, the Hollywood B-movie director: “Corman said, ‘You’re in the location, you have horses, you have actors, you have costumes, whatever. So why don’t you make *two* movies?’ ”

Drawing on Romania’s proud national mythology concerning the original Dracula, the fifteenth-century ruler also known as Vlad the Impaler, Jude presents sketches in different modes, from broad comedy and historical drama to cheesily rendered A.I. sequences. Several scenes are set in a vampire-themed restaurant, whose stake-bearing Western dinner guests chase a hapless Dracula, played by Gabriel Spahiu, through medieval streets; it’s what Monty Python might have done had vampires been part of British popular culture. Meanwhile, a tour guide’s account of an event from Vlad the Impaler’s life—he rounded up disabled and elderly residents, locked them inside a building, then set it aflame—reminds viewers that the nation’s hero was a proto-Nazi. To the extent that the various sections of the

film are connected, it is through the character of a director using A.I. to brainstorm ideas for a movie about Dracula—a stand-in for Jude, who was given funding to make the film after half jokingly proposing the idea at the International Film Festival Rotterdam. Until then, Jude had never read Bram Stoker’s novel, which was suppressed during the Communist era, its supernatural themes being out of alignment with Romania’s view of itself as a modern industrial nation. Once Jude read the book, he realized that he couldn’t do a straightforward adaptation. “I don’t care about vampires,” he explained. “I ended up doing what I liked, but it was a process of fighting with the material—and also finding a way that is not Hollywood, not big-budget. I couldn’t compete with that even if I wanted to.”

The movie’s antic humor evokes the international Fluxus movement of the nineteen-sixties and seventies, which made political arguments through outrageous absurdity. “Dracula” is bawdy from its opening scene, which offers sixteen A.I.-generated iterations of the titular vampire announcing, “I am Vlad the Impaler, Dracula. You can suck my cock.” Uncharacteristically for Jude, the movie lacks a rounded individual at its center, which may be why some viewers—myself included—found more to admire than to enjoy. Manohla Dargis, of the *Times*, called it “a gleefully crude and vulgar go-for-broke provocation that is as grindingly repetitive as it is self-amused.” Loyal cinephiles have characterized the work as a deliberate affront. Victor Morozov, an academic who has written widely on Jude’s œuvre, told me, “After producing some very satisfying and accomplished films, I think he felt a need to basically destroy this heritage and produce an anti-artistic gesture.” Morozov continued, “In today’s economy of images, when we feel that we’ve seen everything, and everything has been banalized, and our sensibility is a lot more equipped to deal with shocking material, to still be able to produce a negative reaction like this—to me, it is interesting.”



An image from the essayistic conclusion of “Kontinental ’25.” Photograph courtesy SagaFilm / RT Features

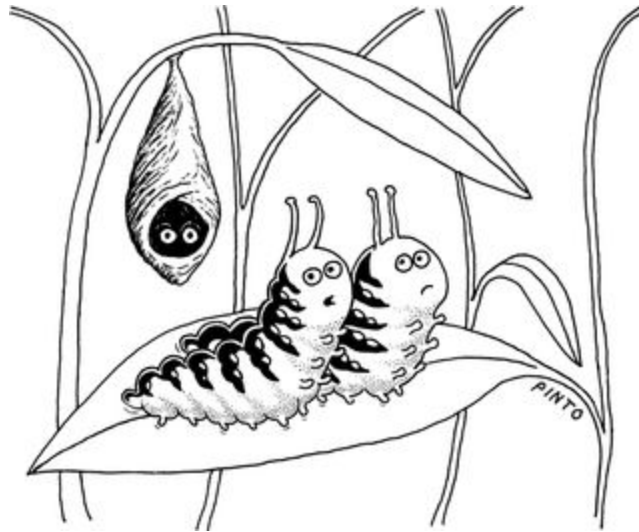
Jude is proud of his “Dracula,” which he believes is the “lightest film I have made, and the funniest—the most full of storytelling and bad jokes, like Bocaccio’s Decameron or ‘The Canterbury Tales.’ ” The hostile reviews surprised him, he explained over dinner one evening, at his cozy, book-lined apartment. He lives there with his partner, Raluca Munteanu, who does public-relations work for N.G.O.s, and their ten-year-old son. (Jude also has a twenty-year-old son, from an earlier relationship.) As Munteanu served an endive tart, Jude poured wine and fiddled with an arrangement of magnets on the refrigerator, adjusting a postcard of Queen Elizabeth II so that a cigar-shaped metal magnet angled lewdly toward her mouth. Jude once told me he was a bit embarrassed that some critics and viewers have depicted him as a kind of pornographer. “I am not,” he insisted, pointing out that the obscenities of “Dracula” were, in part, an ironic commentary on a filmmaker’s contract with his audience. “Most commercial films are supposed to have sex, nudity, genre elements, and violence, and since this film is supposed to be a commercial film—sort of—I delivered what I am supposed to,” he said. “I am still amazed that the people I made all these choices *for* rejected it.”

American film-festival audiences, Jude noted over dinner, had objected not just to the vulgarity but to his use of A.I., given the technology’s potential erosion of film-industry jobs. “There wasn’t a single interview that wasn’t half focussed on A.I.,” he said. “Whereas here, it didn’t seem like such a big deal, because we don’t have a big industry.” The notion that A.I. should be taboo among auteurs hadn’t occurred to Jude, who used it in part for its amusingly janky aesthetic and in part because it allowed him to include scenes—such as a horse-drawn carriage violently flipping out of control—

that he couldn't afford to shoot. Jude's productivity is such that the rejection of "Dracula" stings less than it might if he'd taken several years to make the film, and, besides, he believes that it may stand the test of time. He observed, good-naturedly, "All failed artists hope that posterity will make them the new Emily Dickinson."

As more wine was poured, our conversation turned to Andrew Tate, the loutish, misogynistic British American influencer who moved to Romania in 2017, because of what he perceived as its lax law enforcement. "He said in an interview that you can rape someone and nothing will happen!" Jude said. (Tate's words were "I'm not a fucking rapist, but I like the idea of just being able to do what I want.") Jude became aware of Tate's existence a few years ago, when his older son, Alex, then around fourteen, stumbled across Tate's videos on YouTube. All adolescent boys are exposed to the manosphere; not all spot its most notorious avatar driving through their city in a luxury car, as Alex recently did.

Munteanu got out her phone to show Jude an Instagram reel she'd seen earlier that day, of an A.I.-generated Donald Trump wearing a vampire's cloak and speaking in a familiar, disjointed cascade: "Hello, Romania, *ă bună ziua*, very mysterious country, very spooky, we love Romania, mountains, forests, castles, very dramatic." Romania is extremely online. It has one of the highest rates of social-media use in Europe, with nearly half the population on TikTok. Jude is an omnivorous consumer of social-media slop. Its combination of inventiveness and mundanity reminds him of the early films of the Lumière brothers, who paved the way for modern cinema with their invention of the cinematograph. TikTok and similar platforms have, he said, "a kind of dumbness that I think is enriching, in a way." He added, "I think sometimes Trump reaches this level of dumbness that makes it fascinating. Like this video of him throwing shit on protesters"—an A.I.-generated clip, reposted by the President on the same day as a No Kings rally, of Trump flying in a military plane and dropping feces on demonstrators. Jude has never been to the United States; he'd like to go, he told me, but wants to stay for several weeks, rather than jetting in and out for a film festival. Of the clip, Jude said, "If he was an artist, I would say, 'Wow, he's great.' The problem is that he is the President."



*"Your brother is creeping me out."
Cartoon by Enrico Pinto*

In Romanian politics, social media has had its own outsized influence. In the first round of the country's 2024 Presidential election, a far-right candidate, Călin Georgescu, who had campaigned largely on TikTok, scored a surprise upset; the result was annulled by Romania's constitutional court and the election delayed. The annulment was controversial; even some of Georgescu's leftist detractors argued that the decision was anti-democratic. Others, including Jude, felt that Georgescu should have been barred from running at all, given that he had spoken approvingly of Antonescu, and promoting Fascism is illegal in Romania. "I think it was O.K. to stop the election, though it is not a good sign altogether," Jude said. (Georgescu was banned from the rerun election after claims of Russian interference in the first round.) He and Munteanu had been ready to move to Berlin if the right-wing candidate who remained in the race, George Simion, had won the subsequent election. "We were packing," she told me.

Ultimately, their preferred candidate, a moderate, prevailed, but Jude said that he is disappointed with the new administration's policies, which have cut already paltry funding for public education. (Both of his sons have attended public school.) Jude teaches periodically at a university in Cluj, and he's been appalled to see how the persistent underfunding of education has set back Romanian students compared with those he has taught in Germany and Spain. "They want to study cinema, but they cannot write two sentences," he said. "I always say that we in Romania must work much

harder than our Western colleagues, not only because they are richer but also because they are better equipped from the outset. It's really painful to say it, but it's true."

Jude wasn't born into the intelligentsia: his father worked as a technical planner for public transportation in Bucharest, and his mother was a typist. His paternal grandparents were peasants in Transylvania; his maternal grandparents were also peasants, and his grandmother was illiterate. The village where they lived permitted some private farming but also required inhabitants to contribute to a collective farm. "They had a cow, for milk, and you were forced, as a peasant, to give the calves of the cow to the collective farm," he told me. "My grandfather did what basically everybody did—suffocate the calf when it was born and pretend that it was born dead, just so as not to give it to the collective farm."

Jude moved to Bucharest to join his parents when he started school. "The countryside was a kind of paradise lost for me," he said. He discovered film in his teens, when a friend urged him to join the Romanian Cinémathèque. "Before the revolution, the Cinémathèque was like a citadel—it was very difficult to get in if you were not someone from the regime," he told me. "You had to bribe someone to get the permits. After the revolution, it was open to everybody, but nobody went anymore, because there were other things that were much more interesting," such as participating in street demonstrations. An unenthusiastic student at a high school specializing in math—he thought that he was pretty good at the subject until he met his classmates—Jude spent his free time working his way through the Cinémathèque's patchy archive. Many of the imported color films had been reproduced in black-and-white during the Communist era, as an economizing measure. " 'Apocalypse Now' was black-and-white. 'The Godfather' was black-and-white," he told me. " 'Taxi Driver' made a big impression, in a black-and-white copy. I realized only many years later, seeing Scorsese on TV, when he complained about the red color in the print, that it was originally in color." (To avoid an X rating, Scorsese had reluctantly agreed to desaturate the blood-red color in the grisly final scene.) The movies weren't subtitled, and sometimes a screening included a live narrator doing simultaneous translation into Romanian. After this perverse introduction to Hollywood films, Jude expanded his cinematic

compass by going to the British Council, where he watched VHS tapes of works by ambitious British directors—Peter Greenaway, Derek Jarman, Ken Loach.

Jude applied to Bucharest's prestigious film school three times, but on each occasion he was rejected. Instead, he enrolled at a school for television production. In the late nineties and early two-thousands, Romania became a destination for international TV and film projects whose creators wanted to hire crews who were cheap and willing to endure unlimited hours. After graduating, Jude began working as an assistant on movies and also in advertising. Western directors had prestige, even when they lacked talent—which left Romanians like himself doing the grunt work. He told me, “I was the assistant of a director for a shoot, and he was trembling the morning of the shoot, and he said, ‘I’m telling you, but it’s only between us—I actually sent a friend’s show reel to the agency. I have never directed anything in my life, and I don’t know what to do.’ He was an American.” At the same time, the foreigners’ budgets gave Jude the opportunity to try out equipment he couldn’t otherwise get his hands on, like the Foxy crane, which allows for sweeping, high-angle shots. “In the preproduction meeting, I would say, ‘For this shot, we need a Foxy crane,’ and they would say, ‘How much is that?’ And I would say, ‘Three thousand euros,’ ” he remembered. “For a commercial that had a production budget of a million, three thousand euros was nothing.”

Alexandru Teodorescu, a Romanian producer who has worked on Jude's most recent releases, told me, “When Radu was a director for advertisements, I feel like he was upset from minute No. 1 on set.” The hours were excessive, Jude recalled: “It was like a mantra—they would say, ‘Well, we know when a film day starts, but you never know when it will end.’ Sometimes it would be eight hours, sometimes twelve, twenty, twenty-eight.” “End of the World” was inspired in part by the story of a production assistant who died in a car crash after working an obscenely long shift.

From the start, Jude found the advertising business vacuous, though he infused his projects with his impish wit. In one of his commercials, for a cellphone provider, Ceaușescu himself is interrupted mid-speech by the ringing of a mobile phone. (The tagline: “First you earned your right to

speak freely—now you want to speak for free!”) Jude was painfully conscious of the despoiling of his creative talents. He recalled a pivotal conversation with Alexandru Dabija, a theatre director who is a generation Jude’s senior. “I was speaking with him on the phone, and I said, ‘What are you doing?’ ” Jude remembered. “He said, ‘Oh, I’m doing these Chekhov plays, Shakespeare plays, Molière. What are you doing?’ And I said, ‘Well, I’m shooting a beer commercial, a mustard commercial, a yogurt commercial.’ And he said, ‘Why the fuck are you doing that?’ ”

Thus far, Jude has made films only in and about Romania. He is not, however, averse to the idea of working in other contexts and languages. His next feature, which he hopes will be on the festival circuit later this year, is loosely adapted from the French novel “The Diary of a Chambermaid,” by Octave Mirbeau, which was published in 1900. Shot in France and partially underwritten by a French production company, Jude’s interpretation transposes the maid’s experience to that of a Romanian immigrant. (The script is in both French and Romanian.) Also on the slate is a Frankenstein project that he intends to make with Sebastian Stan, the Romanian American actor who played a young Donald Trump in the 2024 movie “The Apprentice.” The Frankenstein film, Jude told me, will be provocatively set at a C.I.A. black site that was established in Bucharest in the early two-thousands for covert U.S. interrogations of Al Qaeda suspects. If Jude seems prolific, it’s because he spent so many years in advertising, working on things he didn’t want to make, he told me; but his productivity is also the result of a voracious curiosity.

Last year, Jude even became an actor for the first time, taking a small role in a forthcoming film, “The Unknown_,”_ by the French director Arthur Harari. (Harari was a co-writer, with his wife, Justine Triet, of the 2023 film “Anatomy of a Fall,” which Triet directed.) Harari told me that he chose Jude partly because “you can’t really tell which is his social background—he could be a university teacher as well as a crane operator.” He also liked the timbre of Jude’s voice, which, Harari noted, “goes from low to high pitch in a microsecond. It’s extremely lively and surprising.”

One morning while I was visiting Jude, he had to rerecord some dialogue for Harari’s movie, which was in postproduction in Paris, and so I joined

him at a studio on the outskirts of Bucharest, with the French team appearing on Zoom on a laptop. As the scene was projected onto a screen, Jude seemed slightly horrified to see himself in front of the camera rather than behind it. He explained that, half a dozen years ago, he had suffered a bout of Bell's palsy that had caused facial paralysis, from which he had not entirely recovered, though to my eye he had no impairment. "I cannot blow a balloon—that's the test to see if you are completely cured," he told me. I remarked that it was just as well he didn't work as a clown. "Well, I *am* a clown," he responded.

He then delivered some angry dialogue, in Romanian, for the scene. Harari asked for a translation of one line, and Jude happily provided it: "It means, 'Fuck your dead relatives of your mother.' "

The next film Jude plans to make is based on "Miorița," a centuries-old Romanian ballad in which a shepherd is warned by a talking ewe that he will be murdered by other shepherders. Rather than escape, the shepherd accepts his death. Jude said, "It is interesting that this ballad provoked, and still provokes, a lot of thinking that we Romanians are historically unable to react to anything, because our fundamental text is about a shepherd who, when he is informed that he is going to be killed, says, 'I accept my fate.' "

Jude had already identified one of two locations in which his adaptation would be shot—a well-preserved ancient village outside Bucharest. Now he was searching for its counterpart—a modern office building, on the edge of the capital, that he hoped would overlook fields where sheep might graze. One morning, I joined him to scout a prospective location in a corporate park. We entered an atrium where modular couches were surrounded by luxuriantly filled planters, all enclosed by ten stories of glass-walled offices.

"It feels old-fashioned," Jude observed. "It's like things that are developed here were developed thirty or forty years ago in other places."

We toured an office space, formerly occupied by a German transportation-and-logistics company. Conference rooms were identified by the names of other, more prosperous cities—London, Brussels. A wall bore the oversized image of a young man wearing a hard hat, heroically gazing into the

distance like a figure on a Soviet mural. Beneath was English corporatese: “Win Together: We succeed by collaborating with partners and customers—working as one team to create global solutions beyond borders.” From a window, Jude looked down on a scrubby expanse where multiple apartment buildings were under construction. “They build these things where there’s no infrastructure around—no roads, no schools, no hospitals,” he said. “Sometimes the roads are so narrow that fire trucks cannot get in.”

We descended in an elevator, joining two young people, one holding a phone on a selfie stick, the other clutching a ceremonial platter bearing several pairs of scissors. They were evidently readying themselves for an opening ceremony of some kind. In a plaza outside, we discovered the occasion—the opening of a branch of Froo, a subsidiary of a Polish convenience-store chain.

Jude told me that he was feeling bad about some of the criticisms he’d made of Bucharest. “Maybe it sounded too harsh and superior, because there are things I like, of course,” he said. “It’s more a frustration of feeling the potential and the possible healthier development, and instead it goes in the opposite direction.” Later, he explained that sometimes he even liked the city’s chaos and the way its visual conjunctions were themselves a kind of montage. “It is full of readymades,” he said. “It is a Duchampian city.”

The scene unfolding outside the office building was loaded with juxtapositions. Someone was costumed as a carton of French fries; another individual, dressed as a hot dog, hurried past, looking suspiciously like he’d just sneaked off for a cigarette. As we were speaking, Jude was interrupted by an amplified voice in accented English: “Store No. 200—Wow! You absolutely proved that ‘impossible’ is not true.”

Jude needed to get back to the city center. He planned to take the subway; he once had a driver’s license, but he let it lapse and is in no hurry to get a new one. He wouldn’t even ride in my Uber. It would be faster his way, he assured me. He observed, “In Ceaușescu times, you had to make a lot of effort to get a car—to be put on a list and wait months, sometimes years. After the revolution, there was an explosion of luxury cars, as a Western fashion. You have people living in poverty, living in bad conditions, or eating very badly, just to afford these cars, so it grew again as a symbol of

distinction. Maybe there is a bit more awareness that it's not the greatest idea in the world to have cars one on top of another. But it still is like that."

Jude went on, "I used to bike a lot, and I used to take my kid to kindergarten on the bike, going by back streets. The kindergarten had a medical assistant who checked the kids' health, and she was always saying that my kid had a rash, or was coughing, or something. I was always so stressed, because then your day would be ruined because you couldn't put him in kindergarten. She was like Trunchbull in 'Matilda.' Then, one day, she was smiling at me, and she said, 'I didn't know you were a famous director—I saw you on TV last night!' From that day on, even if my kid was coughing like crazy, it was, like, 'No, no, he's fine, he's not sick.' And I realized—she was judging by the car. All the people coming from the luxury cars would be spared. In my case, I compensated for the car because I was on TV."

Having delivered this Romanian parable, Jude went on his way. A few minutes later, from somewhere underground, he texted me a news item showing a black-and-white photograph of a crane digging into an enormous pile of rubble, with onlookers standing nearby. It was the forty-ninth anniversary of the earthquake. As I looked out from my car window, stuck in traffic, it was hard to discern its impact. Or maybe its impact was everywhere. ♦

*[Rebecca Mead](#) joined *The New Yorker* as a staff writer in 1997. Her books include "[Home/Land: A Memoir of Departure and Return](#)."*

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[Letter from New Orleans](#)

The Car-Crash Conspiracy

High-speed accidents, crooked lawyers, and poor people desperate for cash—it was the kind of scheme that could have been cooked up only in the Big Easy.

By [Patrick Radden Keefe](#)

April 13, 2026



A stretch of highway in New Orleans mysteriously became an asphalt Bermuda Triangle—a treacherous gantlet best avoided. Illustration by Thomas Merceron

On any given day, roughly three million tractor-trailers ferry goods along American highways, and it is only because of some perverse collective disavowal that any of us, in our dinky cars, agree to share the road with them. Large trucks account for five per cent of the vehicles in the United States but play a role in ten per cent of fatal accidents. A fully loaded eighteen-wheeler can weigh eighty thousand pounds. It takes time for such vehicles to accelerate to highway speeds, but, by the same physics, once they've achieved such velocity it takes time for them to stop. A big rig thundering along a freeway at sixty-five miles per hour is a juggernaut: even if the driver slams the brakes, the truck will advance the length of two football fields before finally coming to a halt.

In America, more than five thousand people are killed each year in accidents involving large trucks, and the victims tend to be occupants of smaller vehicles. A sedan or an S.U.V.—even a school bus—is no match for the magnitude of an eighteen-wheeler. Witnesses and survivors of such accidents have likened the sound of impact to a bomb blast. When a car

rear-ends a tractor-trailer, it can result in a grisly scenario known as “underride,” in which the lower half of the car wedges beneath the trailer while the upper half is sheared away or mangled. Sometimes, in the vivid language of accident investigators, the crash can make a car “telescope,” or crumple like a beer can. In 1967, the actress Jayne Mansfield perished when a Buick she was riding in crashed into a tractor-trailer; afterward, rear-impact guards—colloquially known as Mansfield bars—became a standard feature on the back of trucks. This reduced, but did not eliminate, underride fatalities. In most of Europe, similar barriers line the sides of cargo trailers, preventing cars from sliding laterally beneath a big rig. But in the U.S. the trucking industry has resisted the introduction of such additional safeguards, citing cost.

People get dismembered in accidents with tractor-trailers. In some crashes, a car is flattened so thoroughly that emergency workers cannot immediately tell how many bodies it contains. In 2009, in Oklahoma, a tractor-trailer failed to slow for traffic and crushed a Hyundai Sonata and a Kia Spectra. Ten people died. In 2023, a man named Danny Glen Tiner was driving an eighteen-wheeler at sixty-eight miles an hour on a highway near Chandler, Arizona, when he became distracted by a TikTok video on his phone and plowed into stopped traffic, killing five. (He pleaded guilty to negligent homicide and was sentenced to twenty-two years in prison.) In the milliseconds before a collision, truck drivers are often powerless to avert disaster. Having activated the brakes but unable to stop, they brace for impact. Sometimes they close their eyes.

A 2003 federal law mandates that truckers cannot drive their routes for more than eleven hours a day, to maintain alertness, and today’s large trucks are so computerized that they operate almost like airplanes, correcting for human shortcomings. Most accidents involving big rigs aren’t fatal. But there are a lot of them—half a million or so each year—and they adhere to certain actuarial probabilities. Large-truck crashes tend to happen on weekdays, often at night. You might suppose that there’d be more fatal accidents in densely populated regions, but the opposite is true: drivers are most apt to speed recklessly, or succumb to fatigue, on freight corridors that run through rural areas.

About a decade ago, however, the city of New Orleans began experiencing accidents involving eighteen-wheelers with a frequency that was anomalous—and alarming. The sudden spike in big-rig collisions occurred in just one area: a fourteen-mile stretch of Interstate 10 that runs through a neighborhood on the outskirts of the city known as New Orleans East. Starting around 2015, scores of accidents involving tractor-trailers and passenger cars were reported in the area each year, often resulting in damage to the cars and medical care for occupants who reported injuries. In 2004, there were sixty-nine sideswipe accidents in New Orleans in which a passenger vehicle collided with a large truck. By 2017, the annual number had nearly tripled. When insurance adjusters examined the roadway where the crashes were happening, there were no obvious hazards—like faulty lighting or an especially steep grade—that could account for this newfound profusion. For truckers, that stretch of New Orleans East had become an asphalt Bermuda Triangle—a treacherous gantlet best avoided.



Cartoon by Bruce Eric Kaplan

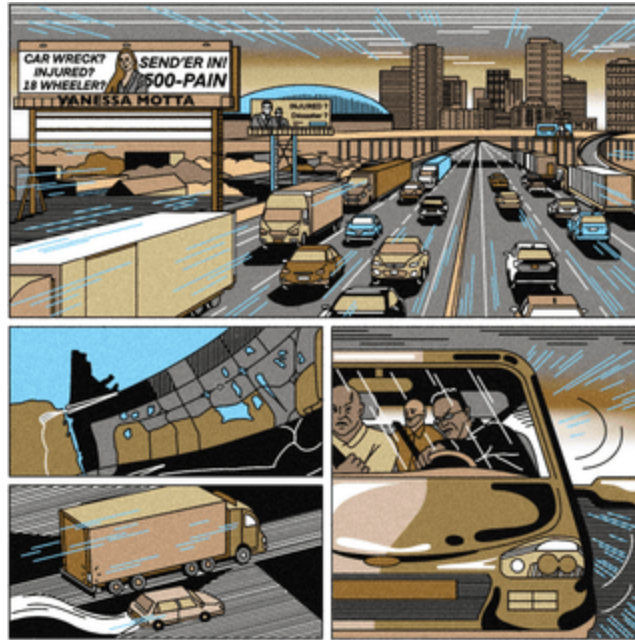
Another confounding feature of the crashes was that, in virtually all of them, the cars contained multiple occupants. For years, the typical number of passengers in a car wreck in Louisiana had been consistent, averaging 1.4. But, when the frequency of accidents involving large trucks started to climb in New Orleans, so, too, did the number of occupants. Suddenly, it became typical for at least three people to be in a car at the time of a collision. When Helmut Schneider, a business professor at Louisiana State University, calculated the likelihood of such a rise in accidents involving so many people taking place in such a contained geographic area, he

determined that the odds of this all happening by chance were one in seven hundred and fifty trillion.

One afternoon in May, 2017, a driver named Lee Mulligan was transporting a trailer full of Walmart products from Hattiesburg, Mississippi, to Harvey, Louisiana. Mulligan, fifty-three and ruddy, had been driving professionally since 1985. Like fighter pilots, truck drivers sometimes adopt a handle, to identify themselves on CB radio. Mulligan's was Stagger Lee. At sunup that morning, he'd done a full vehicle inspection, checking the lights, brakes, mirrors, wipers. It was a brand-new truck, with everything in good condition.

Traffic was relatively light that day, and Mulligan was driving west in the left lane of I-10, near Exit 241. He wanted to move into the center lane, but, as he later explained, when your vehicle is sixty feet long, changing lanes is "a process." Activating his turn signal, Mulligan checked the mirror on the right side of his cab and noticed a blue Nissan Altima in the middle lane, close enough that it would be risky to pull ahead of it. So he clicked off the turn signal and waited. When the Nissan dropped back, Mulligan signalled once more.

"I eased in," he said. But, as he gently maneuvered rightward, he checked the mirror again and was startled to see the Nissan reappear, right on his tail. The truck was so big and the car so small that when they collided Mulligan didn't feel a thing. But in the mirror he saw the front of the Nissan smashing into the right flank of his trailer.



The scheme worked, in part, because New Orleans is what tort-reform advocates have called a “judicial hellhole”—a plaintiff-friendly arena where jurors tend to be sympathetic toward working-class locals and happy to slap a jumbo penalty on a faceless corporation. Illustrations by Thomas Mercer

Even glancing contact between a passenger car and a semi truck is often enough to send the smaller vehicle pinwheeling across the highway. But in this case Mulligan was lucky: the driver of the Nissan maintained control. When it was safe to pull onto the shoulder, Mulligan did so, and the Nissan followed. A diminutive forty-nine-year-old Black woman, Demetra Henderson-Burkhalter, got out. Her clothes were wet; in the impact, she’d lost control of her bladder. She had two passengers with her, a man named Gregory Offray and a woman named Jacqueline Thompson. A passing driver stopped and reported that he had witnessed the accident.

Someone from the sheriff’s office arrived, and they all moved to the parking lot of an abandoned Holiday Inn, which had stood derelict since Hurricane Katrina, more than a decade earlier. Mulligan took photographs of the damage to the Nissan: ugly scrapes lined the driver’s side, and the rearview mirror on that side had been ripped off. But, as he later explained in a deposition, something seemed amiss. It wasn’t just that the Nissan hadn’t fallen back when Mulligan began changing lanes; the driver had seemed to *accelerate* as he was trying to enter the center lane, causing the crash. As he testified, “I believe she gassed it and came up and hit me.”

The idea that anyone not afflicted by a death wish might initiate a high-speed accident with a thirty-eight-ton tractor-trailer seemed ludicrous. Two occupants of the Nissan reported serious injuries; a subsequent lawsuit against Mulligan and Walmart stated that, when Mulligan had slid “suddenly and without warning” into the car’s path, Henderson-Burkhalter and Thompson had been badly hurt, to the point that both underwent spinal surgery. Their suit cited “severe physical pain and suffering as well as keen emotional anguish.” The witness to the crash agreed that Mulligan had driven recklessly.

In preparation for the lawsuit, the defendants hired a consultant named Wayne Winkler, a former Louisiana state trooper who now worked as an accident reconstructionist. Winkler had studied thousands of wrecks. When he examined this one, he found that it shared striking similarities with many other crashes in New Orleans East during the previous eighteen months. All of them involved a car sideswiping the back of a tractor-trailer that was making a lane change. In many cases, a witness in another car had flagged the truck driver down. There were invariably multiple people in the damaged car, who subsequently claimed injuries and commenced litigation. Winkler identified at least sixty-four recent incidents that fit this general description.

Attorneys for the defendants began investigating, and learned that one of the passengers in the car, Jacqueline Thompson, was a member of the Harris family, a sprawling New Orleans clan comprising dozens of relatives. It turned out that many Harrises had been plaintiffs in personal-injury cases involving crashes with tractor-trailers. A man named Ryan Harris—who went by Red and owned Networth Motors, an auto-body shop just off I-10—had been in phone contact with numerous family members and other individuals who ended up filing truck-collision lawsuits. And just a month before Mulligan’s accident there had been a crash on I-10 in which a truck collided with a Lincoln Town Car carrying Harris’s aunt, along with her husband, her blind brother, and her teen-aged granddaughter.

Demetra Henderson-Burkhalter, meanwhile, had also exchanged many calls with a New Orleans man named Cornelius Garrison III, who had been a plaintiff in a lawsuit arising from a truck collision in 2015 and had been

listed as a witness to *another* collision in 2014. Around the time of Henderson-Burkhalter's accident with Mulligan, she had spoken with Garrison on nearly thirty occasions, including on two calls in the hours before the collision, three calls right around the time of the crash, and seven calls later that day. Garrison had also communicated with Red Harris, other members of the Harris family, and numerous other people who had crashed into big rigs. As a lawyer who examined these records subsequently wrote, Garrison appeared to be "the link between the plaintiffs in all of these incidents."

The roads of New Orleans are cluttered with serried ranks of billboards touting the services of personal-injury lawyers. Watch a single episode of the "Today" show on the local NBC affiliate and you might encounter twenty different commercials for such attorneys. Chief among them is Morris Bart, who pioneered this kind of blanket advertising in Louisiana in the nineteen-eighties, and is so ubiquitous that many locals can recite his tagline: "One call, that's all." Bart argues that such promotion has a salutary social function, reaching people in underserved communities who might not otherwise be aware that they are entitled to aggressive, contingency-fee advocacy. But, really, this is a volume business. Firms take on vast numbers of cases, generally aiming to settle with insurance companies rather than go to trial. (Detractors contend that this might be the actual meaning of "One call, that's all.") And the competition is cutthroat. Bart claims to have recovered more than a billion dollars for his clients, but downstream of him are scores of challengers angling to catch some of that action for themselves. "It's like 'The Hunger Games,' " a local lawyer told me.

A few years ago, Bart sued a lawyer named Brad Egenberg, claiming that Egenberg had made ad purchases on Google to steer users searching for "Morris Bart" or "One call, that's all" to his own firm's website. The number of bodily-injury claims stemming from auto accidents in Louisiana is twice the national average. For attorneys in an overcrowded marketplace, in a city with casual ethics and a weakness for flamboyance, an outlandish sales pitch can be the best way to break through. Egenberg is a braggadocious impresario who features in dozens of ads, sporting big sunglasses and sometimes a fur coat and generally carrying on like the stimulant-addled lawyer played by Sean Penn in "Carlito's Way." Egenberg

refers to himself as “His Bradjesty,” and has a catchphrase of his own: “Greedy for Ju\$stice.” When we spoke recently, Egenberg asked if I had seen his TV spots, and I ventured that they were somewhat over the top. “I get a lot of phone calls,” he said, with punchy assurance. “What do you want me to do, stand there in a suit?”



Cartoon by Roz Chast

Franklin Delano Roosevelt once described a “pettifogger”—an unscrupulous, bottom-feeding attorney—as “a man who is small, mean and tricky, and picayune.” New Orleans has long been notorious for embracing such scoundrels, a reputation that isn’t exactly helped by the fact that, for many years, disgraced attorneys who lost their licenses in Louisiana and applied for readmission to the bar often got it. One lawyer of particular infamy, who stole from clients and ended up going to prison, had to be disbarred three times before he finally gave up. As a local columnist once remarked, Louisiana exhibits “a kindheartedness towards sleazy attorneys that lay thieves might envy.”

For decades, New Orleans personal-injury lawyers have relied on an informal army of “runners” to bring them fresh cases. Though technically illegal, this mode of direct solicitation has grown into its own ancillary industry: runners are not lawyers but well-connected hustlers who monitor police scanners and know people at towing companies. They often swarm

after a car crash, plucking future plaintiffs from the wreckage and shepherding them to law offices downtown. (Somebody's got to chase the ambulance.) In the nineteen-nineties, a group of attorneys known as the Canal Street Cartel, for the thoroughfare bordering the French Quarter where they maintained offices, were indicted for operating a huge network of runners and paying bounties as high as five hundred dollars for each client they brought in the door.

Cornelius Garrison—the purported link to many of the car-crash cases—worked as a runner. Genial, slender, and very tall, he was born in 1966, and grew up in a housing project in the Upper Ninth Ward. He was known to many as Slim. Garrison had two adult sons and three grandchildren, but also a baby girl from a more recent relationship. Over the years, he had held various jobs, from working the fry station at a Ruth's Chris Steak House to polishing the floors at tourist hotels. Although he'd been arrested several times, for writing bad checks and other minor offenses, he had generally maintained a low profile, and still lived with his mother. He kept his hair in a neat high-top fade, got his nails manicured, and drove a cream Cadillac Escalade.

Insurance scams involving deliberate auto collisions have a long history. Two decades ago, the Federal Bureau of Investigation issued an advisory about “Staged Auto Accident Fraud,” warning of daredevils in cars “crammed full of passengers” who braked abruptly, causing the vehicle behind to rear-end them, then filed bogus claims about soft-tissue injuries, which were “difficult for doctors to confirm.” Attempting such a stunt with an eighteen-wheeler, however, marked a dramatic—and potentially suicidal—escalation. But if the risks were vast, so were the potential rewards. Whereas insurance coverage on the average passenger car might be as low as fifteen thousand dollars per bodily injury, tractor-trailers often carry policies worth at least a million dollars, offering the prospect of a much bigger payout.

Smashing into a speeding truck is obviously dangerous, but the fraudsters sought to mitigate the chance of fatalities by appointing designated drivers who were skillful enough to hit a truck with sufficient force to cause damage to their own car—but not so much that they would end up getting

flattened. Such drivers came to be known, in the vernacular of this criminal ecosystem, as “slammers.” In New Orleans, one of the earliest slammers was a jovial fellow named Damian Labeaud, who, starting in 2010, recruited passengers from the local community with the promise of insurance payouts, then took them hunting on the freeway for a truck.

“Watching and seeing, that’s the only training I had,” Labeaud subsequently recalled. “You got to know how an eighteen-wheeler move.” You must also drive with utmost precision, he pointed out, so that “you don’t get killed.” (Labeaud has pleaded guilty to federal charges for his role in staging accidents, and is currently awaiting sentencing.) As a slammer, he worked closely with crooked lawyers, communicating in a rudimentary code. “I’m about to go fishing,” he’d tell them. “Want me to bring you some lunch?”

Garrison learned the business from a pioneering slammer named Jeffrey Derouselle. In 2009, Derouselle was involved in an accident in which a Ford Explorer he was driving collided with an eighteen-wheeler. One of the passengers in the car was Garrison’s older son. By 2015, Garrison and Derouselle were working together as slammers, collaborating with a lawyer named Jason Giles, who was a partner at a prominent Canal Street personal-injury outfit, the King Firm. According to court documents, Giles directed Garrison and Derouselle to bring him twenty-five cases a month, promising to pay them thirteen hundred dollars for each passenger they enlisted.

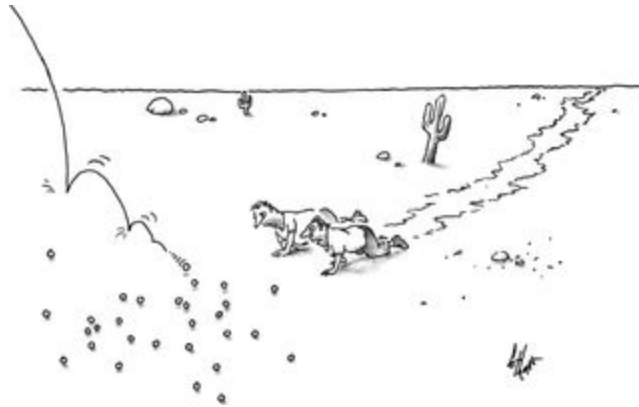
It was surprisingly easy to find locals willing to risk their lives for money. Nearly a quarter of New Orleans residents live in poverty, and the prospect of a substantial windfall for a few hours’ work apparently outweighed any fear of getting into a car that was about to take part in a high-speed accident. Besides, the involvement of lawyers, with their downtown office suites, perfumed the whole arrangement with an aroma of respectability.

In poor, predominantly Black neighborhoods, Garrison developed a reputation as a man to see if you had financial difficulties. “Talk to Slim,” locals would advise friends who needed money. “He can help you out.” Entire families signed up to ride with the slammers. People packed into cars with their aging relatives and their preteen children. At least one of the passengers was pregnant.

Garrison turned out to be a preternaturally coolheaded driver. If he were to misjudge the point of impact by even a few millimetres, or to exert a little too much pressure on the gas pedal while accelerating into a collision, the car could easily spin out or, worse, underride the trailer, decapitating everyone in the vehicle. “Your car running good?” he would ask his passengers, who generally supplied their own automobiles for the staged accidents. Like a seasoned getaway driver, Garrison wanted to know about a heavy gas pedal or a squishy brake—any quirk that might have fatal consequences.

“He ain’t talk too much,” a former passenger said of Garrison, describing how focussed the slammer became when scanning a highway for a promising target. When Garrison found an eighteen-wheeler, he’d stalk it from a distance, like a lion trailing a wildebeest, until the truck signalled a lane change. Then he’d speed up. “ ‘We’re gonna hit it,’ ” the former passenger recalled him saying. “And then . . . *bam*.”

Garrison typically coördinated with a second car—a so-called “spotter”—because it was helpful to have an ostensibly neutral bystander who could say that he’d witnessed the accident. After sideswiping a tractor-trailer, Garrison would pull over while the spotter sped ahead to flag down the truck’s driver. Meanwhile, Garrison would scramble out of the driver’s seat, allowing one of his passengers to get behind the wheel. Because the goal of the conspiracy was to file lawsuits, Garrison could not be named as the driver in too many accidents—that could expose the whole scheme. Instead, he would simply walk away from the crash. Often, the spotter car would pick him up and follow the truck while the slammer car stayed behind, allowing Garrison to pretend to have witnessed the very accident he’d just caused.



"There's a driving range around here somewhere."

Cartoon by Frank Cotham

In the course of several years, Garrison staged scores of truck crashes. Miraculously, although some of his passengers may have sustained mild injuries, not a single one was maimed or killed. Garrison himself occasionally complained of aches and pains that he attributed to the many impacts. Juanisha Winchester, a woman he dated after becoming a slammer, recalled, "He didn't say what he did. He told me to stay out of his business, basically." But she came to understand that Garrison "did accidents" for a living.

"I'm going to handle my business," he'd tell Winchester before heading off in search of a truck to collide with. Sometimes, when he came home, she would pick fragments of broken glass out of his hair.

In May, 2016, the slammer who had taught Garrison, Jeffrey Derouselle, was shot to death, apparently over an unrelated matter. As Garrison later explained, he did not want to "deal with middlemen anymore," so he pivoted away from the King Firm and forged a partnership with a young attorney who had only just graduated from law school. Her name was Vanessa Motta.

Growing up, Motta had trained as a dancer, and as an adult she retained the broad-shouldered physicality and ferocious competitive instincts of a serious athlete. Born in Caracas, Venezuela, she spent her childhood in Florida and then attended Chapman University, in Orange, California, before working as a stunt double in Hollywood for several years. She appeared in fight scenes and chase sequences in dozens of movies and

television shows, including “Sons of Anarchy” and “The Dukes of Hazzard: The Beginning.” Motta is tall and long-limbed, with a small, round face, an olive complexion, and brown hair that whips about theatrically when she is kicking ass. At the 2010 Taurus World Stunt Awards, she was nominated in the Best Fire category for her work on a reboot of “Friday the 13th.” Motta became romantically involved with another stunt professional, Jeff Brockton, who is credited in hundreds of productions, from “Speed 2: Cruise Control” to “Sinners.” The couple had a daughter in 2010, and named her Julia, for Julia Roberts.

During Motta’s years as a stuntwoman, Louisiana was becoming a major hub for film production, because it offered significant tax incentives to studios. (“Hollywood South, baby!” Ray Nagin, then New Orleans’s mayor, proclaimed in 2005.) Like many below-the-line Hollywood professionals, Motta and Brockton opted to relocate, buying a home in Slidell, on the north side of Lake Pontchartrain, in 2011. But their relationship didn’t last, and the movie studios moved on, lured away by new incentives in other states. Julia had been born with a kidney disease, which would eventually necessitate a transplant. Motta, perhaps recognizing that she couldn’t rely on stunt work forever, enrolled in law school at Loyola University New Orleans. She passed the bar in 2016, and joined a personal-injury firm. But, after falling out with her boss, she was fired, and, with a mere seven months of legal experience, she struck out on her own.

Motta moved her fledgling practice, Motta Law, into a small office building at 525 Clay Street, in Kenner, just west of New Orleans. A modest beige-brick structure that housed several other law offices, it occupied an inauspicious location abutting a railroad track. The landlord was a local man named Sean Alfortish. Rawboned and muscular, he had a macho affability. At forty-nine, he was fourteen years older than Motta, but they began dating almost immediately—and, soon enough, got engaged. Alfortish worked for a “medical factoring” company, which financed treatment for people who had been injured in accidents and collected money from their settlements. Motta was looking for accident cases in order to build Motta Law. Her new boyfriend introduced her to Cornelius Garrison.

The whole staged-accident conspiracy required a close relationship between slammers and attorneys. Alfortish had worked as a lawyer himself. His e-mail address was LawQB@aol.com, and when Garrison first met him he got the impression that Alfortish was still a practicing attorney. The truth was more colorful. Alfortish had been disbarred after pleading guilty, in 2011, to a conspiracy charge relating to his tenure as the president of a nonprofit, the Louisiana Horsemen's Benevolent & Protective Association, which advocates on behalf of professionals in the horse-racing business. In that role, he had been "a showman," one association member told me, strutting around tracks with a racecard sticking out of his back pocket. One press account described him as "the peacock of the paddock." But a financial audit revealed that Alfortish had been skimming money, some of which had been earmarked for hurricane relief, to pay for vacations to Aruba and to Grand Cayman, and for a new sound system at his home. He was also found to have clinched his second term as president through a ballot-rigging scheme.

"Ever since I was a kid, I took up for people who couldn't fight for themselves," Alfortish proclaimed at his sentencing, unwilling to let the contrition he was supposed to be expressing entirely drown out his self-regard. The judge, unmoved, observed that some people commit crimes because they've been "kicked around by society," but that Alfortish—with his law degree—was not such a person. "Society has a right to expect *more* from you," the judge said.

Alfortish served more than two years in prison before returning, quite unreformed, to New Orleans. According to authorities, he soon started working with Garrison to stage accidents. Although by this point Garrison had already been plying the slammer trade for several years, Alfortish wasn't shy about offering him tactical advice. Garrison would later recall, for example, that Alfortish had cautioned him to limit the number of passengers to three, because four might raise "red flags." Alfortish, who is white, tended to code-switch with Garrison, slipping into a Black American vernacular, and when referring to the passengers who rode in the slammers' cars he drew on his equestrian past, calling them "horses." According to Garrison, Alfortish sometimes recruited passengers himself. And, through

the medical-factoring company, he lined up financing for post-accident procedures.

Motta's role in the scheme was to initiate lawsuits against trucking and insurance companies in accident cases brought to her by Alfortish and Garrison. Her paperwork was sloppy—her court filings were riddled with typos—but she compensated with performative dudgeon. “A commercial driver is not a *normal* driver,” she would tell a jury. She said that her many clients were “like family,” and tended to speak to people in a register of exaggerated familiarity, calling them “my love” and touching their arm or shoulder. Motta took on dozens of cases involving crashes with large trucks, many of them linked to Garrison, and she was soon earning sums that were improbable for a newly minted law graduate. In 2018, Alfortish and Motta bought a home for \$1.25 million on a cul-de-sac in the Lakeview neighborhood of New Orleans. According to later testimony by Motta's accountant, her annual income abruptly “jumped into the millions” after she started handling large-truck accidents.

Perhaps it was inevitable that Motta, as a personal-injury attorney looking to make a mark in New Orleans, would star in a TV commercial.

“Stuntwoman turned badass attorney,” a gravelly voiced announcer intoned over clips of Motta brawling in movies. “She knows . . . how to make them *pay*.” Motta started using her own slogan: “Send ’er in.” She even put up a billboard. It featured an image of her karate-kicking a truck.



In collaboration with personal-injury lawyers, some residents not only got themselves into dangerous accidents; they underwent unnecessary surgeries in order to increase the potential payoff.

Alfortish paid Garrison for his work as a slammer by check. At first, Garrison would simply cash the checks, but before long he was making so much money that he opened a bank account. Alfortish told Garrison that, if anyone ever questioned him about the origin of these funds, he should adopt a cover story about earning the money through construction jobs. Garrison started staging truck accidents with such frequency that it was hard for Motta to keep up with the caseload. One Christmas, Alfortish surprised Garrison with a twenty-five-thousand-dollar bonus.

Garrison was generous with his money, doling out a hundred dollars here and there to people in his life. At one point, he intimated to his sister, Andrea Garrison-Robertson, that he was making so much that “you won’t never have to work again.” Motta was “impressed with what I was able to do” behind the wheel, Garrison later said. She even suggested that she might hook him up “with people in Los Angeles to do stunt driving.”

Motta’s most lucrative accident cases involved surgical procedures. Because pain is so subjective—and because of the difficulty in substantiating conditions such as whiplash and soft-tissue damage—surgery had the benefit not just of running up the clinical expense of an accident but

also of seeming to ratify its legitimacy. After all, who would agree to be cut open on an operating table if it weren't necessary?

Quite a lot of people, it turns out. According to Garrison, Alfortish explicitly advised that a participant would “get more money from the lawsuit” if he had surgery. Court documents suggest that Motta would sometimes become “upset” with clients who resisted this idea and would “harass” them until they agreed. One of Motta’s clients, a passenger named Dacha DeGruy, recalled, “She was saying if I get the surgery it’s more money. She said it would be ‘big-girl money.’ ” Degruy, who hadn’t actually been injured, declined Motta’s request, because, as she later explained, “I was kind of afraid to get surgery at twenty-one.” In 2018, Motta e-mailed an associate about a client who *had* consented to an unnecessary surgical procedure. “I was able to persuade him,” she wrote. “LOL.”

Astonishingly, Motta, Alfortish, and Garrison appear to have assumed that they could continue staging accident after accident on I-10, and filing lawsuits for insurance money, without ever being detected. Jim Donelon, the former insurance commissioner of Louisiana, later exclaimed to the press, “How dumb can you be? There’s a lot of intersections with eighteen-wheelers available to be targeted without doing it at the same corner over and over again.”

But the truth is that, even after trucking companies figured out what was happening in New Orleans, many were still inclined to settle, rather than attempt to convince a jury that they had been victims of fraud. Advocates of tort reform have described New Orleans as a “judicial hellhole,” a plaintiff-friendly arena where jurors tend to be sympathetic toward working-class locals and happy to slap a jumbo penalty on a faceless corporation. Peter Strasser, who served as a U.S. Attorney in New Orleans from 2018 to 2021, told me that, although the fraud was “obvious” to the trucking companies, they paid anyway, reasoning, “If we take this to a jury trial, then we’re *really* screwed.”

Of course, this willingness to settle only encouraged further fraud. It didn’t really hurt the insurance companies, either—they just raised their premiums. According to Donelon, fraudulent-accident claims relating to

big-rig collisions increased the average yearly insurance costs for each family in Louisiana by as much as six hundred dollars. And, as another New Orleans attorney pointed out to me, skyrocketing premiums led “lots of people to drive without insurance, which in turn raises everybody’s rates even more.” The trucking companies, which often end up assuming some of the cost of settling, increase their prices, which in turn drives up the price of consumer goods. “It’s just a snowball of economic catastrophe,” the lawyer said.

Even so, by 2018, the fraud in New Orleans had grown so undeniable that the trucking companies and their lawyers could no longer ignore it. They ultimately tallied two hundred and forty-six truck accidents that appeared to have been staged in the area—and pinpointed Garrison as a common denominator in many of them. But, when they tried to obtain his phone records, Motta, acting on his behalf, fought vociferously to stop them, citing privacy rights. When defense attorneys insinuated that many of Motta’s accident cases seemed to have been staged, she counterpunched aggressively. If that were true, she scoffed, it would be “the largest conspiracy since the JFK assassination.” Not squeamish about playing a race card when the opportunity presented itself, Motta accused her opponents of believing that “if a person in the African American community knows or has any family relationship . . . with another person in the African American community who has ever been involved in an accident,” then they must be a “fraudulent individual.”

Behind her resolute façade, however, Motta was anxious. Law firms were drawing up lists of people associated with suspicious accidents, and it didn’t take a data scientist to notice some patterns. Just as Garrison had been instructed in the slammer’s art by Jeffrey Derouselle, Garrison had in turn taught Red Harris how to be a slammer. All told, at least twenty members of the Harris family had taken part in staged accidents. Harris initially got involved after his mother participated in a slammer accident and gave him Garrison’s phone number. In a kind of apprenticeship system, Harris first worked as a spotter, then graduated to driving slammer cars. As he put it, “Cornelius taught me the game.”

Motta began representing Harris, along with numerous members of his immediate and extended family. One of the law firms defending the trucking companies tallied fifty-three accidents that were connected to Motta and other attorneys with offices at 525 Clay Street. Motta had taken on so many cases that she enlisted a lawyer named Jason Baer to help her. One day, Baer texted her to express his concern that Garrison's name was associated with too many crashes. "He's fucked," Baer wrote. "Way too much out there on him." In fact, Baer told Motta, he'd heard that federal prosecutors might be looking into Garrison.

"Omg!!" Motta wrote. "I don't deserve this."

Baer appeared perplexed by this coy pretense of innocence. He later wrote, "Vanessa, you seem to forget that we have spoken with Cornelius Garrison and he admitted to running cases for lawyers."

In January, 2019, another law firm representing the trucking companies passed information that it had gathered to the F.B.I., and the Bureau, working with federal prosecutors, quietly opened an investigation. Its code name was Operation Sideswipe. That October, Garrison was arrested by local police, on an unrelated charge. While he was in custody, F.B.I. agents paid him a visit, and Garrison agreed to secretly coöperate with their investigation.

One of the primary corridors running through New Orleans East is Chef Menteur Highway, a name that dates to the French colonial period and translates as "Chief Liar." New Orleans East, originally established in the nineteen-sixties as a mostly white bedroom community sprawling toward the Mississippi border, eventually became a predominantly Black area. It was pummelled by Katrina and has never fully recovered. Sarah M. Broom, in her 2019 memoir, "The Yellow House," notes that New Orleans East is "cut off" from the rest of the city by the Industrial Canal and can seem like a void to people from elsewhere—"a blank space on someone else's map." The area, an expanse of more than a hundred square miles, has been chronically under-resourced. According to the *Times-Picayune*, on some nights as few as four police officers patrol the entire district. Chef Menteur runs roughly parallel to the stretch of I-10 where the slammers staged so many accidents; Alfortish advised Garrison that it was best to do his

slamming in a place where local—not state—police would respond, presumably because they were overworked and understaffed, and therefore more likely to generate a pro-forma accident report than to investigate. But another reason so many participants in the conspiracy selected New Orleans East may simply be that it was home. As Motta once put it, “People in east know each other . . . and all do business.”

One day, defense attorneys representing a trucking company studied the Facebook page of one of Motta’s former clients, Tiffany Turner, who’d been involved in a 2017 crash in which a Chevy Impala collided with a tractor-trailer. Turner had a son who had been in the accident with her, and two other sons who had been involved in separate truck collisions the same month she had; her ex-husband had been in yet another truck accident earlier that year. Turner’s case had frustrated the defense lawyers who had tried to investigate it: one passenger had claimed to be unable to answer questions because she suffered from schizophrenia, bipolar disorder, insomnia, asthma, sleep apnea, and high blood pressure. On Turner’s Facebook page, however, the defense attorneys discovered a tantalizing comment posted from the account of a woman named Marlene Kennedy. It said, “TiffanyTurner sitting accidents up with 18 wheelers . . . now that’s f***** up.” Kennedy went on to suggest that the F.B.I. was “looking for Tiffany Turner and her crew that hang in Gentilly by Burger King.” (Gentilly is adjacent to New Orleans East.)



“My people, rejoice! I start therapy next week!”

Cartoon by Ellis Rosen

In April, 2018, Kennedy was at a Church's Texas Chicken on Chef Menteur when she was approached by a private investigator. Kennedy, who was in her late fifties, had cropped hair and a rueful smile. Her life had not been easy. She had struggled with addiction for decades and been imprisoned numerous times for shoplifting. In 2014, her daughter was fatally shot outside her home. Kennedy, for all her struggles, had a salty irrepressibility. It wasn't just Turner staging accidents, she informed the private investigator; *lots* of people in New Orleans East were doing it. Some even argued that it was "legal," she explained, because they were getting paid by lawyers. "It's three generations of them doing it!" she exclaimed. People she knew were buying new cars, new furniture. Kennedy herself was financially "desperate," she confessed, because of her addiction. She seemed envious of the money that people like Turner were making. But she would never participate in a slammer accident, she said. "Don't seem right to me," she declared. Besides, Kennedy added, with her luck she'd probably die in the crash.

As Kennedy talked, she caught herself, realizing that she might be acting imprudently. She wondered aloud if she could go into "witness protection," noting, "People kill you behind that kind of stuff."

"You want to try to be anonymous?" the private investigator asked, without making any commitments.

"That's right," Kennedy confirmed. Seeming reassured, she said, "I'm gonna take me some Suboxone and call it a fucking day."

The private investigator did not keep Kennedy anonymous. The Facebook comment about Tiffany Turner was eventually entered into evidence, and lawyers asked to depose Kennedy in their cases. By then, she was locked up—shoplifting again—and it was at St. Tammany Parish Jail that she received a visit from a woman she'd never met: Vanessa Motta.

Accompanying Motta was a man who Kennedy assumed was a police officer—understandably enough, given that he wore a badge on his hip and a hat that said "*POLICE*." His name was Eddie Compass, and he hadn't actually been a police officer since resigning as the chief of the New Orleans Police Department in 2005, in the immediate aftermath of

Hurricane Katrina. Compass now oversaw security at a local college, and moonlighted as an investigator for personal-injury attorneys.

His presence made Kennedy nervous. (She later said, of New Orleans cops, “They dirty.”) Motta had prepared an affidavit for Kennedy to sign, which retracted the Facebook comment and anything else she might have said about staged accidents. Kennedy, recognizing that she was being asked to sign a false statement, declined. So Motta and Compass left. But some days later they visited her again, and this time she signed. The document said, “I, Marlene Kennedy, do not know or have any personal knowledge of any fraud committed by anyone in any case,” and specified that she didn’t know anything about Tiffany Turner, Motta’s former client. The affidavit went on to claim that “investigators took advantage of me and my addiction,” suggesting that Kennedy had been paid off by insurance companies—she hadn’t—and concluding, “I said things that were not true so that I can get ‘cash.’ ”

Motta, triumphant, took the affidavit to get notarized. She was unaware that, like Garrison, Kennedy had also been approached by the F.B.I. The whole second meeting had been secretly recorded.

If Garrison was an exceptional slammer, he also turned out to be a stellar government informant. As a Department of Justice filing later acknowledged, “Garrison’s cooperation was extensive.” Across multiple meetings with F.B.I. agents and prosecutors, he implicated both Motta and Alfortish. In an initial interview, Garrison, who appeared to have a soft spot for Motta, claimed to agents that she “did not know the accidents were staged.” But soon he conceded that she had to have known, “because there were so many.”

An F.B.I. report from one of these sessions noted that, whenever Garrison staged collisions with big rigs, he “always drove,” because “it was potentially dangerous if someone did not know how to do them correctly.” Immediately following a crash, Garrison would hurry out of the car, telling one of the passengers, “Get in the driver’s seat and call 911.” (On at least one occasion, a truck’s onboard camera system captured video of this hasty two-step.)

In the interviews, Garrison confirmed that he had received a hundred and ninety-two thousand dollars' worth of checks from Alfortish. Federal authorities realized that, with Garrison's critical evidence, they could construct a major case. On one level, the slammer conspiracy was an amusing example of New Orleans chicanery at its most baroque, a tale of literal highway robbery so antic and absurd that it seemed like the plot of an Elmore Leonard novel. But, on a deeper level, it was an awful parable of economic desperation in twenty-first-century America. Scores of poor Black Louisianans had volunteered for what was effectively Russian roulette, risking their own lives and the lives of their loved ones in the hope of a onetime payout. The attorneys, by contrast, were well educated and mostly white, and would almost certainly have been loath to climb into a car with Garrison and go looking for a truck to hit. Of course, the lawyers had reaped the bulk of the financial rewards. Motta routinely demanded six- or seven-figure settlements, and contingency fees often ran as high as forty per cent. Actual payments to clients, however, could take years to come through, when they came through at all.

The reason Garrison was such a prized witness was that he straddled both ends of the conspiracy, liaising between down-and-out passengers and their felonious attorneys; he was the linchpin of the entire operation. In addition to the lawyers, there were doctors. When Motta and Alfortish referred clients to spinal surgeons and pain specialists, they used the same clinicians again and again, among them Peter Liechty, a surgeon who ran the One Spine Institute, and Eric Lonseth, a pain physician in Metairie. (Liechty died in 2024; Lonseth did not respond to requests for comment.) Actual spinal surgery was routine in these cases, and many of Motta's clients bore scars from their procedures. To a shocking degree, the passengers appeared to rely on Motta and Alfortish not just for legal counsel but also for medical advice. "This case is going to be surgical and its a good one," Alfortish wrote in a 2017 e-mail. On one occasion, a client of Motta's slipped and called her Dr. Vanessa.

In January, 2020, one of the law firms representing the trucking companies sent Garrison a subpoena, asking him to sit for a deposition. Garrison told the F.B.I., and the Bureau proposed a secret surveillance operation. A few days later, Garrison, wearing a wire, met Alfortish at a local gas station and

showed him the subpoena, which indicated that at the deposition he would be asked to lay out his connections to passengers in one of the crashes.

“You don’t know anything about that,” Alfortish said, coaching Garrison to claim that he “did not know anyone” related to the case.

When Motta learned of the deposition, she seemed unsure what to do. Like Alfortish, she wanted Garrison to say that he didn’t know anyone involved. But she couldn’t serve as his attorney at the deposition, because their whole arrangement necessitated some degree of deniability—and because she already represented the person who had initiated the lawsuit in question. Motta said that she’d found someone—an “old friend”—and they went to an office building downtown to meet him. As they ascended in an elevator, Motta assured Garrison that this lawyer had already been taught the cover story that Alfortish had been paying Garrison for construction work. She intimated that this new lawyer was a big personality. “He talks a little too much,” she said. “But funny, funny guy.” Entering an office suite, they were greeted by Brad Egenberg, the lawyer whose slogan was “Greedy for Ju\$stice.” His Bradjesty.

Prior to the meeting, Egenberg and his wife had dined with Motta and Alfortish. Egenberg later explained that he’d agreed to work with Garrison as a favor to Motta; he told me that he’d related to her as a fellow up-and-coming personal-injury lawyer. (He disputes the idea that they were personal friends, however, and he insists that he knew nothing about Alfortish concealing payments to Garrison under the pretense of construction.) In any case, Egenberg did not end up representing Garrison for long, because *another* lawyer, a public defender named Claude Kelly, got in touch to say that he was actually Garrison’s counsel.

The revelation that Garrison had already engaged a public defender—and hadn’t told Motta about it—likely prompted her to suspect that he was working with the Feds. Garrison told his F.B.I. handlers that he wasn’t sure whom to trust—and that he no longer felt safe. As Kelly would later testify, Garrison seemed particularly fearful of Alfortish.

“He don’t play,” Garrison said.

That winter, Motta and Alfortish took a vacation to the Bahamas. After returning, the couple suggested to Garrison that perhaps he might also enjoy island life—permanently. Alfortish “offered to move me to the Bahamas,” Garrison reported to the F.B.I.

“It’s falling heavy right now,” Alfortish told Garrison in one recorded conversation. As Garrison subsequently related, Alfortish proposed a new scheme. He would pay Garrison half a million dollars if he “took the fall.” This would presumably mean claiming responsibility for staging the accidents—and asserting that Motta and Alfortish had believed the cases to be legitimate.

Garrison wasn’t inclined to take this offer. Among other reasons, he doubted that he’d ever receive such a big payoff. He had a cluster of scars on his back from a surgical procedure, performed in Baton Rouge a few years earlier, in which a doctor had fused two vertebrae in his spine. The surgery hadn’t been medically necessary, but Garrison had agreed to it, ostensibly to correct injuries sustained in an accident he’d staged with a charter bus in 2015. Back then, Motta was still in law school and Alfortish had only just been released from prison. But Garrison’s personal-injury lawsuit, which was handled by another local firm, had stalled, so he brought his case to Motta. She managed to disgorge nearly seven hundred thousand dollars from the defendants. Yet Garrison only ever received roughly ninety thousand, and he still suffered from pain, though it was unclear whether the pain derived from the bus accident, from other crashes, or from the surgery itself. His back was “always bothering him,” his mother said.

Eventually, Garrison confronted Motta about the sum he believed he was still owed from the bus-accident lawsuit. “If I don’t get my money, I’m going to call the Feds and tell them what you’re doing,” he warned.

“I’ve been good to you!” Motta protested, and began to cry.

As the pandemic set in, Garrison occasionally drove downtown in his Cadillac and met with Claude Kelly, the public defender, in his deserted office. “He was just a pleasure,” Kelly said later. “All he talked about were his kids.” Garrison’s younger son had played basketball for the University of Louisiana at Lafayette; this made Garrison proud. After whatever

business they had that day was finished, he and Kelly would linger on the sidewalk. “We talked about his plans after this was all over,” Kelly said. Garrison knew that he would likely have to “take his lick” and serve some time, but after that he wanted to leave New Orleans and move to Seattle.

On September 18, 2020, the Justice Department unsealed a seven-count indictment charging Garrison with “staging over fifty accidents.” Alfortish and Motta weren’t indicted or named in the document, but they were described, respectively, as “Co-Conspirator A” and “Attorney B.”

Garrison’s coöperation with the F.B.I. wasn’t referenced in the text—and it might have seemed that charging him in such a public fashion would be a good way to conceal his role as an informant. But a close reading of the filing encouraged certain inferences. One stray sentence asserted that “Co-Conspirator A instructed Garrison on the number of passengers to include in staged collisions.” Alfortish might have made some unconventional life choices, but he wasn’t a total idiot. He certainly hadn’t supplied that information to the Feds—and the only other person who could have done so was Garrison.

Four days after the indictment was made public, Garrison had dinner with his mother, Sandra Fontenette, who was seventy-four, at the tidy condominium that she owned, on Foy Street. They ate gumbo and talked. Garrison had been texting with a woman named Kim that afternoon, and they had made plans to hang out after dinner. At around eight-thirty, the doorbell rang, and Garrison went to meet her. But, upon opening the front door, he shouted to his mother, “Get down!” Ten shots rang out, and Garrison collapsed on the floor, dead.

Peter Strasser, the U.S. Attorney, was in his office when one of his prosecutors entered, looking shaken, and said that the key coöperating witness in the slammers case had just been murdered. “I would never have believed it, because this was a *nonviolent* case,” Strasser recalled. Louisiana is a death-penalty state, so for criminals there the calculus should be straightforward: it makes sense to risk the death penalty only if you might be facing it to begin with. But this was a fraud case. It felt like “a crisis moment,” Strasser said, adding, “One of the prosecutors on the case was afraid they were going to come after her next.”

The F.B.I. dispatched a special team from Washington, D.C., to help the Louisiana agents contend with a fraud investigation that had transformed into a murder conspiracy. Meanwhile, Operation Sideswipe kept expanding and racking up prosecutorial victories, building off the work of private-sector investigators and lawyers for the trucking companies. Mike Perlstein, a local TV journalist who covered the investigation, told me, “It was like handing the Feds this pretty massive case on a silver platter.” At the time of Garrison’s murder, twenty-eight people had already been charged. By the end of 2024, the indictment count would jump to sixty-three.



“Do you have this in a goldfish?”
Cartoon by Liam Francis Walsh

From a distance, this resembled the progress of a racketeering case, in which prosecutors often start by picking off street-level pawns and then work their way up to the kingpins. But, in the slammers investigation, nearly all the people being prosecuted were pawns—passengers who’d agreed to ride in cars. “None of these people are professional criminals,” Strasser acknowledged to me. He said that most had pleaded guilty. “They fold immediately—it’s like dominoes.” Only one lawyer, and not a single doctor, had been charged. Perlstein reported each new benchmark in the case as it was announced, but privately he was growing skeptical. He characterized most of the passengers who rode with slammers as “church ladies who got convinced—or got greedy.” Perlstein started to wonder if the F.B.I. investigation “was shaping up to miss the big target and drag a bunch of poor Black people to jail.”

In January, 2024, a *Times-Picayune* reporter named John Simerman wrote an article about this disparity. One passenger in a slammer accident described the pitch she'd received: "You're gonna get a bunch of money. You can come up off of this, and the legal firm is gonna make sure you get it." In a town south of New Orleans, some locals had actually paid two hundred and fifty dollars each to be a passenger in a staged accident; nine neighbors along one street in the town had pleaded guilty to federal charges. "Nobody made any money—the lawyers made money, the doctors," a fifty-eight-year-old passenger told Simerman. "I got to do eighteen months for what?" A woman who had been sentenced to probation emphasized her own modest circumstances by saying, "Where's the Lamborghini?"

Marlene Kennedy, the shoplifter who had signed the fraudulent affidavit drawn up by Motta, ended up getting deposed by lawyers for one of the trucking companies. She was frustrated to have become tangled up in the case; she had been very clear to Motta and her supposed cop friend that she wanted no part of this drama. Kennedy felt as though she had become an instrument of larger forces that were indifferent, if not outright hostile, to her needs. "Not nobody here to defend *me*," she blurted to the lawyers who had assembled to depose her. "Who here for Marlene Kennedy?"

The lawyers, having realized how comprehensively Motta appeared to be linked to different fraud cases, questioned Kennedy about her. But this only made Kennedy more flustered. "Ask *her*!" she countered. "You attorney, she attorney, right? Y'all should be talking to *each other*. Not to me. To her. Y'all went to college together. Y'all need to talk. Not me. I don't have nothing to do with nothing." They kept pressing, but to no avail. "I don't remember," Kennedy said. "I'm telling you, it's like Alzheimer's. Dementia. I don't remember." There was one attorney in the room whom she found more sympathetic. Recognizing his surname, she realized that he must be related to a kindly man who had facilitated a drug-treatment program she once took part in. Pulling this lawyer aside at the end of the deposition, Kennedy appealed to him directly: "You ain't gonna let nobody hurt me, huh?"

The murder of Cornelius Garrison had the efficiency of a professional hit. His mother, who had witnessed the shooting from inside the apartment and

called the police, said subsequently, “Whoever did that knew what they were doing.” When officers arrived, they found Garrison’s phone by his body, and they soon discovered the texts he’d been exchanging with Kim—the woman he’d been planning to meet.

“How mom’s doing?” Kim had texted not long before the shooting.

“She is good,” Garrison had replied.

“I’ll text you when I’m outside,” Kim wrote.

Tracing Kim’s number, investigators found that it corresponded to a burner phone that had been purchased at a local Family Dollar a day before the shooting. The phone had been paid for in cash, as had a second burner phone, and when authorities consulted the phone-service carrier they learned that the two burners had been in contact with each other on the day of the shooting. The Family Dollar had a CCTV system, so it was possible to pull up footage from the moment the phones were bought. When the buyer appeared on camera, investigators recognized a familiar face: Garrison’s fellow-slammer Red Harris.



Lawyers hired by trucking companies pieced together the conspiracy—and prosecutors eventually indicted several dozen New Orleans residents.

When the police went to arrest Harris, he was wearing the same sweatshirt he'd had on in the surveillance video. The authorities later determined that the person Garrison had thought he was texting, Kim, was in fact a New Orleans East woman named Jovanna Gardner. Harris and Gardner shared a child—and both were clients of Motta's in accident cases. Under questioning, Gardner insisted that she hadn't known she was setting Garrison up to be murdered. Her understanding had been that “the lawyers”—Motta and Alfortish—wanted to pay Garrison to stop cooperating with the authorities, but they were worried that he might not agree to meet for that purpose, and so Harris had instructed her to pose as a potential love interest. According to Gardner, “the lawyers” supplied Harris with the address where Garrison could be found. Later that night, she said, Harris had confessed to her that Garrison was dead, saying, “I killed him.”

After Garrison first taught Harris how to be a slammer, around 2016, the two had worked together productively for a time. But they fell out over money, and at one point Garrison told Motta that Harris was not to be trusted. On May 7, 2024, Harris and Gardner were charged with conspiracy to murder, along with wire fraud. Gardner pleaded guilty and began cooperating, telling police that, even though Harris was the father of her child, he had threatened to kill her if she told anyone about his role in the murder.

In a surprising development in early 2025, Harris also entered a guilty plea—and clarified to the F.B.I. that he had not personally carried out the murder. Instead, he implicated a man named Leon (Chunky) Parker, who was in a romantic relationship with Harris's mother. On September 16, 2020, Harris had sent Parker a photo of a 9-millimetre he wanted to buy at a gun outlet in Metairie. “Man, that thing nice,” Parker texted back. “Almost look like mines.”

Harris did not end up buying the firearm, but, six days later, a gun of the same calibre was used to kill Garrison. Harris told authorities that, after the shooting, he and Parker had dumped the murder weapon in a canal.

According to Harris, when Alfortish and Motta became aware that Garrison was cooperating with authorities, they called him a “rat”—and intimated that it might be better if he were dead. Alfortish “wanted him gone,” Harris

said. As for Motta, she told Harris that “she could not believe Garrison had done this to them after everything they’d done for him.”

Alfortish asked Harris if he knew anyone who could help solve the problem of Garrison. Harris organized a meeting at his auto-body shop with Chunky Parker. As a government filing later summarized, “During the meeting, Alfortish offered to pay Parker to murder Garrison.”

When authorities searched Harris’s auto-body shop, they discovered a blank retainer form for Motta, along with a contract in which Motta agreed to represent a cousin of Harris’s who was in a crash in November, 2023. A more cautious lawyer than Motta might have reacted to recent events—being referenced in a federal indictment, the murder of a former confidant—by backing away, at least temporarily, from truck-accident cases. Jason Baer, the lawyer who’d shared several cases with Motta, began the process of withdrawing as co-counsel at the first sign of a federal investigation. He later explained, “I was, like, ‘Man, I’m just a litigator. This is way past my pay grade.’ ” But Motta, with a brazenness that had become her signature, kept taking on new clients. “I already had to settle another case because of all this bullshit,” she complained to Baer impatiently. As Alfortish once observed, “My fiancée . . . loves to win.”

In December, 2024, Motta received a settlement offer in one of her accident cases on the very day that she, along with Alfortish, was finally indicted in the fraud scheme. Her law license was suspended, but even then she was determined not to give up her caseload. In a filing, Motta proposed designating an outside attorney named Lionel Sutton to take control of Motta Law, adding that she would keep working for the firm as a paralegal. A judge denied Motta’s request, saying that it would be “a danger to the public” for her to continue working in the profession.

Despite the non-negligible risk that she’d soon be in prison, Motta had given birth to a baby girl in 2023; Alfortish was the father. After the indictment, Motta, citing the needs of her children and her current inability to work, protested that she was facing “financial ruin,” and argued in one motion that she’d effectively “been ‘debanked’ (much like President Trump while he was being unjustly prosecuted).” Such claims of penury, however, were difficult to square with certain facts. When Motta was indicted, she

had been permitted to stay out of prison pending trial. One condition of her bond was that she could not travel out of state without prior authorization from her probation officer. But, in a later filing, prosecutors revealed that Motta had gone to Biloxi, Mississippi, on multiple occasions, to gamble at the Beau Rivage Resort & Casino.

In fact, according to the government, between 2020 and 2025 Motta spent \$836,401.81 playing slot machines at the Beau Rivage. Motta has claimed that this figure is misleading, explaining that it relates to an MGM Rewards card that she shares with her mother. But she did acknowledge visiting the casino, pointing out that in some cases she had received permission from pretrial services to bring her daughter Julia and one of Julia's friends to hang out at the pool. If Motta chose to "unwind" with a little gambling after the children were in bed, she contended, this was "more than justified." As for Motta's mother, last year she petitioned the former U.S. Attorney General Pam Bondi to drop the charges against her daughter, characterizing her indictment as a "targeted persecution."

One rainy day this past December, I passed through security at the federal courthouse on Poydras Street, in downtown New Orleans, and took a seat in a windowless courtroom. The atmosphere was hushed and businesslike; this was a routine pretrial hearing, and only a few other spectators joined me in the gallery. A door opened and Alfortish shuffled in, escorted by marshals. He was surprisingly tall, dressed in an orange jumpsuit and plastic slides. Until the end of 2024, Alfortish had been a free man, and he would often show up at local horse races, sometimes with Motta and the children. He had been training horses, and having some luck at the track. In a video from 2023, he spoke at Fair Grounds Race Course, in New Orleans, boasting about a Thoroughbred he'd named Julia's Warrior, for Motta's older daughter. Motta and Julia were with him, and he gestured to Julia and said, "Without trying to cry, this one here has been through a ton. . . . Let's just hope the horse is as special as you are." Motta, in a floral dress, praised Alfortish's "dedication." Julia's Warrior won a six-furlong race in November, 2024. Less than a month later, Alfortish was indicted.

In the courtroom, Alfortish's face looked gaunt after spending roughly a year in prison, and his hair, thinning now, had gone white. Motta entered,

dressed in a black suit and Louboutin heels. Their relationship had struck me as having an amour-fou quality, so I had half anticipated a histrionic display of affection. But Motta strode directly to the defense table, straight-backed and all business, as though she were just another attorney in this proceeding, rather than a lead defendant. Acknowledging her shackled fiancé with the briefest and tightest of smiles, she took a seat.

It seemed highly probable that Alfortish, who was fifty-eight, might spend the rest of his life in prison. Not only did he have a previous felony conviction; he also faced the additional charge of conspiring to murder a federal witness. As I watched the strained interactions between Alfortish and Motta in the courtroom, I wondered if, given that the child they shared was still just a toddler, they had concluded that their best shot at keeping at least one parent out of prison was for Motta to turn on her partner.

When the first of two trials began, in early March, it became evident that this was indeed the strategy. The judge, Wendy Vitter, had split the case into two separate proceedings. First, Motta would face fraud charges relating to the staged accidents; then, in a trial scheduled for August, Alfortish would face his own fraud charges while also being tried, with Chunky Parker, for the murder of Garrison. (Both have pleaded not guilty.)

“The heart wants what the heart wants,” Motta’s lawyer, Sean Toomey, told the jury, describing a naïve young woman who had fallen under the spell of a malign and more mature Svengali. In his opening statement, Toomey described Motta three times as a “baby lawyer,” and at different points in the trial he suggested that she was “inexperienced,” “a bad lawyer,” even “stupid,” and that she had “terrible taste in men.” Motta had been completely unaware that the accidents Garrison and Alfortish had brought her were illegitimate, Toomey insisted.

But prosecutors presented an avalanche of evidence to indicate that Motta was anything but naïve—and that she’d known all along what Garrison was doing. Red Harris, his arms inked with tattoos, testified that Motta had explicitly directed him to slam, recalling, “She said make sure I hit ’em right, and that the policy was high.” Former clients described Motta encouraging people to get surgeries, and others discussed one particularly shameless episode in which a large church van, crammed with prospective

plaintiffs, intentionally collided with a truck. A dash-cam video from another incident, which was played for the jury, showed Garrison exiting a Toyota S.U.V. after smashing it into an eighteen-wheeler and walking calmly along I-10, as traffic whizzed past, before climbing into a spotter car and driving off.

Although Motta dressed demurely for court, she seemed incapable of maintaining a poker face. Most days, she sat at the defense table with her back to the jury, which struck me as an odd choice; then it occurred to me that her lawyer may have insisted on it, lest jurors witness the dramatic eye rolls and arch expressions of indignation with which she tended to greet testimony by government witnesses. Alfortish wasn't in the courtroom during the trial, but his presence hung heavy in the air. "Alfortish and Motta were partners in business, romance, and crime," one prosecutor said, and Garrison had been murdered because he "was a threat" to both of them.

The trial lasted three weeks, but when the case went to the jury, on March 20th, deliberations took less than six hours. The jurors found Motta guilty of fraud, obstruction of justice, and witness tampering. According to someone who knows her, she had remained stubbornly, irrationally overconfident about her prospects, even as damning evidence against her accumulated by the day.

When Judge Vitter read the verdict, Motta started to shake and cry. The courtroom erupted. Motta's mother shrieked and appeared to faint, collapsing on the ground. Motta hunched over and vomited into a trash can. "I have no reason whatsoever to believe that she is naïve, or under the influence of anyone else," Vitter said, adding that, though Motta might not be charged in relation to Garrison's murder, she had unquestionably "acquiesced in the death of a witness." Vitter announced that Motta would be taken into custody immediately, rather than permitted to remain free until her sentencing. She could get up to twenty years in prison.

A car crash, the novelist J. G. Ballard once suggested, is "probably the most dramatic event in our lives apart from our own deaths." After the murder of Garrison, his sister, Andrea Garrison-Robertson, reflected glumly, "When people love money, they do things." It is tempting to wonder whether Motta's conviction, and the murder trial this summer, might give rise to any

sustained policy reform. For all the resources that the U.S. government devoted to Operation Sideswipe, the case is notable for the many implicated parties who have *not* been indicted. No doctors appear to be facing consequences. As Peter Strasser, the former U.S. Attorney, explained to me, it can be difficult to prove beyond a reasonable doubt that a clinician knew a procedure was medically unnecessary, even if the same surgeons repeatedly worked with the same nefarious lawyers, conducting gratuitous surgical procedures again and again. Jason Giles, the bent lawyer at the King Firm who worked with Garrison and with Damian Labeaud, was tried in the same proceeding as Motta, and was also convicted. The two other partners who founded the King Firm with Giles were implicated in trial testimony, suggesting that they were either aware of or active participants in fraudulent accident cases. But they have not been charged and are still licensed to practice law in Louisiana. (Neither responded to requests for comment.)

The prospect of serious tort reform in the state seems unlikely. Jeff Landry, Louisiana's governor, has claimed that he wants to "rein in" the ubiquitous advertising of trial lawyers, but the state legislature, which is generously subsidized by the plaintiffs' bar, has a history of stymieing such correctives, and more than one local attorney suggested to me that Landry's comments are no more than lip service. By many measures, Louisiana now has the second-highest auto-insurance rates in the country, trailing only Florida. And the business of litigating accidents has become so lucrative that, earlier this year, one Baton Rouge personal-injury firm announced a novel partnership with a private-equity fund. It's a queasy indication of what may lie ahead.

Not long ago, I drove out to Clay Street, in Kenner, which runs through a light-industrial stretch between the Mississippi River and a drainage canal. The sky was gray and the grass along the railroad track was overgrown. Alfortish sold the building at 525 Clay around the time the Feds started investigating him, and Motta Law has vacated the premises. But, when I approached the building, I saw that it was still home to law offices. Out front was a parked Jeep that had been decorated in garish camouflage and emblazoned with the grinning face of a man who went by Lawyer Don. It was a billboard on wheels. I wondered if Lawyer Don used the Jeep for his

commute to work or if he kept something more sensible out back. “Personal Injury Response Vehicle,” a sign on the Jeep announced. “Don’t Take Any Bull from the Insurance Company!” ♦

*[Patrick Radden Keefe](#), a staff writer, has been contributing to *The New Yorker* since 2006. His books include “[London Falling: A Mysterious Death in a Gilded City and a Family's Search for Truth](#)” (2026).*

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The Return of Family Detention

Under the Trump Administration, thousands of immigrant children have been detained, and many have suffered from medical neglect.

By [Sarah Stillman](#)

April 13, 2026



Kheilin Valero Marcano recalled asking detention-center staffers, “Are you going to watch my baby die in my arms?” Photographs by Carlos Jaramillo for The New Yorker

In early February, Elora Mukherjee, who runs one of the country’s leading immigrants’-rights clinics, at Columbia Law School, told me about a client of hers who was detained in South Texas. The client, Mukherjee explained, was in the midst of a life-threatening medical crisis. What’s more, she was eighteen months old. Baby Amalia, as Mukherjee called her, had been sent to a San Antonio hospital with critically low oxygen levels. She’d spent more than a week in intensive care, where she and her mother were watched by *ICE* agents. After being discharged from the hospital, the toddler had been sent back to the place where she had nearly died: the Dilley Immigration Processing Center, where many children had severe respiratory

illnesses. “The doctors prescribed Amalia a medication by nebulizer,” Mukherjee told me, but, when the child and her mother returned to Dilley, “the officers took those meds.” (A spokesperson for the Department of Homeland Security said that any claims that Amalia “did not receive her medication or proper medical treatment” are false.)

For months, I’d been investigating how the suffering of children, including infants and toddlers, has become central to the Trump Administration’s immigration-enforcement strategy. In Chicago and Portland, Oregon, federal agents had fired chemical munitions at children. In Idaho, I reviewed evidence of children being swept up in a vast and violent immigration raid on a family-friendly horse race and zip-tied until their wrists bruised or bled.

When children’s bodies bear the brunt of federal immigration enforcement, it’s not merely a matter of collateral damage. In the first days of Donald Trump’s second term, his Administration launched a series of executive actions that, in effect, directed immigration enforcement against kids. Under Joe Biden, D.H.S. had designated “protected areas,” where *ICE* and Customs and Border Protection were discouraged from conducting operations; these included places “where children gather.” Trump’s D.H.S. rescinded that designation, freeing agents to target children, parents, and caregivers at playgrounds, child-care centers, and schools. (In March, Democrats in Congress released a report that documented forty-two such incidents in or around “schools, school bus stops, and day care centers,” with “devastating consequences for children learning and being cared for at these locations.”) Similarly, Trump’s Executive Office for Immigration Review cancelled a Biden-era memo that urged immigration judges to adopt “child-friendly courtroom procedures.” Later, a new *ICE* initiative urged agents to track down unaccompanied migrant children, ostensibly to insure that they weren’t being trafficked but also, in many cases, to deport them. “The real through line is a strategic and coordinated effort specifically to target kids, with the goal to make life so unbearable for immigrant families at every point of contact that they feel they have no choice but to leave,” Kica Matos, the president of the National Immigration Law Center, an immigrants’-rights group, told me.

The harm to children is particularly clear in the Trump Administration's revival and expansion of family detention at Dilley, where Amalia and more than five thousand other children and parents have been held during the past year. In a report released on April 1st, Human Rights First and *RAICES*—two major nonprofits working on immigrants' rights—offer a close look at what they call a “new era of *ICE* family prisons.” Based on interviews with thirty-five families who have spent time during the past year in family detention and more than three hundred legal cases in which *RAICES* has represented asylum seekers, the report describes more than a dozen family separations that have been conducted by U.S. immigration enforcement since Trump returned to office; most of the incidents occurred at Dilley. It also alleges that significant due-process violations have led to the summary deportations of children and families with credible asylum claims. And it documents accounts of widespread medical neglect of children, including infants, in the care of CoreCivic, the private contractor that operates Dilley, which reported more than two billion dollars in total revenue last year. Faisal al-Juburi, a co-C.E.O. of *RAICES*, told me, “Right now, the egregious medical neglect alone could, isolated from all the other horrors, be considered clear evidence of intentional harm.” (D.H.S. said that all detainees receive due process and proper medical treatment. The agency also denied that *ICE* targets children.)

This January, the average daily population at Dilley soared to more than nine hundred. By mid-March, it fell to under a hundred before rising again. Robyn Barnard, a co-author of the report and the senior director of refugee advocacy at Human Rights First, told me, “There is no indication that they plan to wind down at Dilley.” She was aware of at least two families in the facility who'd been there for longer than a hundred days—more than five times the legal limit for holding a child in immigration detention, as indicated by a settlement called the Flores agreement. “If these are the horrors we know about, what are the ones we still don't know about?” she asked. She also pointed out that, unlike in the past, many of the families detained at Dilley had put down roots in the U.S. In early April, I spoke to an Indian family of four who'd lived in the Los Angeles area since 2022; when we talked, they'd been held at Dilley for nearly fifty days. The father, Jagdish, told me that one of his children was vomiting and the other had bloody stools; both were depressed. “The suffering is too big,” he said.

Amalia and her parents, Stiven Arrieta Prieto and Kheilin Valero Marcano, were released in early February. On their first weekend out of detention, Prieto and Marcano sat down at a sponsor's home to speak with me, joined by Mukherjee and three law students who'd worked many late nights to get them released. "I want to be a spokesperson for all the women with children at Dilley who are living with the nerves and desperation of not knowing if their child will survive," Marcano told me. "So that they won't lose hope. So that they won't keep living in purgatory."

Amalia was a healthy child last December 11th, when she and her parents were arrested by immigration-enforcement officials in El Paso. Prieto and Marcano had grown up in Venezuela, a country they never wanted to leave. But, in 2024, they sought asylum in the U.S., on the basis that they had opposed the Nicolás Maduro regime and faced persecution.

They took all the steps required by the Biden Administration. Arriving at the southern border, they registered for an appointment with Customs and Border Protection. They then waited for months in Mexico, during which time Marcano gave birth to Amalia. The family received an immigration court date in 2027 and were granted humanitarian parole, a status that allowed them to live lawfully in the U.S. until they appeared in court.



"I love listening to the birds in the morning."
Cartoon by Jeremy Nguyen

The family moved to El Paso, where they found a playground that Amalia loved and a close-knit church. Amalia learned her first words: “Mamá,” “Papá,” and “agua.” But, in 2025, the Trump Administration attempted to terminate many forms of immigration protection for asylum seekers, including humanitarian parole programs, and began apprehending families who were awaiting their chance to go before a judge. (“The law requires those in the country illegally claiming asylum to be detained pending removal,” a D.H.S. spokesperson told me.) In early December, Prieto was told to show up for an immigration check-in at an earlier date than *ICE* had initially requested and to bring his family. He complied. At the check-in, Prieto, Marcano, and Amalia were arrested. They weren’t provided with arrest warrants or any paperwork explaining why they were being apprehended. Amalia cried after the family was loaded into a van full of other parents and young children. “Why are you doing this?” Prieto asked the immigration agents. He recalled that an agent replied, “It’s a change of Administration. They pay us to deport you.”

When the family reached Dilley, they noticed that the water smelled strange. At the commissary, Prieto bought packs of bottled water, which they reserved for Amalia. (*RAICES* and Human Rights First note that families at Dilley routinely describe water that is “unclean, foul-smelling, and causes stomachaches”; bottled water, the report observes, must be purchased, despite the fact that detainees have typically been stripped of any sources of income.) In the cafeteria, Marcano told me, “a girl pulled a bug from her hamburger meat and showed it to all of us—and the kids didn’t eat that day.” Then, Marcano recalled, “the kids started falling sick.” (CoreCivic said that inspections have confirmed that the water at Dilley is “safe and clean for consumption” and that it has no record of a bug being removed from food at the facility.)

On January 1st, Amalia developed a high fever. The next day, Marcano took her to Dilley’s medical clinic; she told me that a clinician prescribed Amalia ibuprofen. The same thing happened the following day. “A fever is good, because it means she’s fighting off a virus,” Marcano recalled a clinician saying. But the fever didn’t go away, and Amalia was clearly suffering. After nearly two weeks, she began vomiting and having diarrhea.

Often, Marcano had to stand in line for hours with her sick daughter to insure that Amalia was seen by Dilley's medical team. She waited in line at least eight times, she told me, only to get her concerns shrugged off by the staff. One day, after Marcano tried to lower her daughter's temperature with a cool bath, Amalia lost consciousness. Marcano went back to the clinic and screamed, "Are you going to watch my baby die in my arms?"

Family detention is hardly unique to the Trump Administration. George W. Bush launched the first large-scale, for-profit family-detention facility, although it proved short-lived, on account of legal challenges and public outcry. The Obama Administration revived the concept in 2014 by opening family-detention camps, including Dilley, to deal with an influx of asylum seekers from Central America. At an event marking the opening of Dilley, Jeh Johnson, then the Secretary of Homeland Security, described the detention center as an "effective deterrent" against the rise in family border crossings. By the summer of 2015, the facility reportedly held more than seventeen hundred people, about a thousand of them children. When I first interviewed Mukherjee about Dilley, years ago, she was helping to coordinate an effort to provide pro-bono legal representation to families there. Back then, Mukherjee took her law students on an annual trip to Dilley; some of the students called it "spring break in baby jail."

During the Obama Administration, allegations of neglect at Dilley were common. I wrote about a client of Mukherjee's, a Honduran asylum seeker named Suny Rodríguez, who'd been detained there with her seven-year-old son for four months, in violation of Flores. In federal court, the pair alleged that they were subjected to "inhumane conditions" (including disregard for Rodríguez's son's asthma and weight loss), pressured to self-deport, and threatened with separation, claims for which they reached a settlement. Similarly, a group of ten mothers filed formal complaints in 2016, alleging substandard medical care in D.H.S. custody. One of those mothers noted, "I thought I came to this country to escape abuse, mistreatment, and disrespect. But it's the same here."

During Trump's first term, family detention soared, and so, too, did accounts of medical horrors at Dilley. In the spring of 2018, a Guatemalan toddler contracted a respiratory infection there and died six weeks after

being released; then, between September of 2018 and May of 2019, six children died in U.S. immigration custody, after nearly a decade without any such deaths. Under Biden, Dilley was shuttered. Asylum seekers were largely allowed to await their court dates outside detention, and many, like Amalia's family, were granted humanitarian parole.

The second Trump Administration reopened Dilley in March of last year. By January 16, 2026, more than five hundred and fifty children were held in *ICE* detention, according to government data analyzed by the Marshall Project. Recently, detained families at Dilley have come from such countries as Afghanistan, China, Colombia, Haiti, Russia, and Uzbekistan. Often, Juburi and Barnard told me, children from non-Spanish-speaking countries have been asked to translate for their parents in high-stakes interactions with *ICE* officers, owing to Dilley's limited interpretation services.

According to Barnard, the center has both threatened family separations and enacted them. "Many of the families we interviewed recounted being threatened that, if you don't comply with us, we will separate you from your loved ones," Barnard said.

In one case, an eleven-year-old boy and his parents fled Mongolia, flying to Chicago with the intention of seeking asylum. D.H.S. sent the family to Dilley, where officials, lacking a translator, allegedly asked the boy to inform his parents that *ICE* intended to separate him from them. The parents were shackled and sent to adult detention; the child was shipped to a federal shelter as an unaccompanied minor. "I am devastated," the mother said in an official declaration. "*ICE* officers have not explained anything to me." The family was only reunited two months later, in order to be deported back to Mongolia.

In another case, a thirty-seven-year-old woman from China and her ten-year-old son sought asylum at the border in San Diego. They were taken to the airport, where, she said, agents told her that she could accept deportation to China with her son or be forced to return on her own and have him "taken away" from her. She physically resisted and was briefly dragged by an agent. (In a sworn statement, she recounted one of the agents saying, "Fuck! You're going on a military plane back to China!") The

mother and her son were sent to Dilley. There, according to *RAICES* records, they were officially separated: the son was sent, alone, to a federal shelter in New York, while she was sent to detention centers, first in New Jersey, and then in Texas and New Mexico. As of early April, the two remained separated.



Before they were arrested by the Trump Administration, Amalia and her parents had been granted humanitarian parole under Biden.

Often, threats of family separation work hand in hand with medical neglect, Juburi told me, persuading families to accept deportation. He described the case of a woman and her five-year-old daughter who were apprehended in an *ICE* raid in Chicago last September, then transferred to Dilley. The mother, he said, had ovarian cysts and, because she couldn't access her usual medication while at Dilley, experienced profuse bleeding; she agreed to "voluntary departure" with her daughter because she didn't want to die of blood loss in front of her. Juburi said that his team has represented scores of families who've accepted deportation only in the context of serious medical neglect. "Parents make these life-threatening journeys to the U.S. in service to their children, for their children's safety, and so this Administration is very well aware of that parental psychology, that the parents would do

anything to insure their child isn't harmed," he told me. "The evidence at Dilley points to the weaponization of that primal instinct."

At one point, when Amalia was extremely sick, an *ICE* officer approached Prieto and Marciano and pressured them to sign paperwork that they could not understand. Mukherjee later told me that it was a motion intended to withdraw their application for admission to the U.S. "They felt they had no choice but to sign," she said. "Had we not intervened, it would have resulted in their deportations."

A few days after the incident in which Amalia lost consciousness, Marciano brought her back to the clinic at Dilley. A staffer measured Amalia's blood-oxygen saturation—which, in a healthy individual, is between ninety-five and a hundred per cent—and found that it was in the low fifties. "Such a low amount of oxygen going to the brain can, if it's long enough, kill off parts of the brain—it's really, really high-stakes," Prantik Saha, a pediatrician who reviewed Amalia's medical records, told me. "It's shocking that this level of callousness and omission of care could occur." Amalia was taken to a local hospital, where it became clear that she needed care beyond what the facility could provide. She was transferred to a larger hospital in San Antonio, where she was given five diagnoses: *Covid-19*, RSV, bronchitis, pneumonia, and an ear infection. She received supplemental oxygen and intensive care.

While at the hospital with her daughter, Marciano sometimes went to the bathroom, knelt on the floor, and prayed, "Don't let Amalia die!" As she watched over her daughter, two *ICE* agents monitored the pair at all times, even when Amalia was breast-feeding. "The officers never left me alone," Marciano told me. "If a nurse entered, they'd write it down, and if I moved to touch my baby, they'd write it down."

On the second day in the hospital, the nurses kindly gave Marciano a bag of clothes and hygiene items for her and Amalia. An *ICE* agent angrily confronted the nurses, Marciano told me, and scolded her, too. "I don't know why the nurses are giving you gifts like you're a beggar," Marciano recalled him saying. He told her that she should be grateful for the expensive medical care her daughter was receiving: "The nurses don't understand that *ICE* is your protector."

After ten days, Amalia and her mother were returned to Dilley. At that point, Mukherjee and her team got involved in Amalia's case. "In previous Administrations, including the first Trump Administration, when I came across a kid with severe medical needs in detention, I could almost always work with *ICE* to insure that the child and parents were released," Mukherjee said. But, during the past year, "in case after case, requests for parole that usually would have been granted in the past were ignored or denied."

When that happened, she'd send a second urgent request. If needed, she'd send a third, including "medical testimony from highly respected experts in the field, sworn under oath." When that proved fruitless—as it did in Amalia's case—she'd turn to working with organizations such as *RAICES* and the Texas Civil Rights Project, a nonprofit legal group, to file a federal habeas petition pleading with the court for a family's release. Essentially, she told me in early February, *ICE* was "no longer engaging in any individualized consideration of a toddler or baby's urgent humanitarian needs."

Older children endure their own kinds of pain. Shortly after meeting Amalia and her parents, I interviewed a Russian family of five in detention at Dilley, who'd also become clients of Mukherjee's. The family spoke to me on a video call from Dilley. The youngest, a four-year-old boy named Konstantin, held up a drawing of a train he'd just made. "He said, 'This train will take us away from here!'" his mother, a former nurse named Oksana, told me. Beside her sat her thirteen-year-old son, Kirill, a talented pianist who spent the interview with his head buried in his hands. Oksana's eleven-year-old daughter, Kamilla, began the call upright but looked exhausted; she soon lay down on the bare floor without a pillow. Back in Russia, she'd been in a dance troupe. "She's a very creative kid, and she loves to read poetry," her mother told me.

The family, like Amalia's, had come to the U.S. legally, seeking asylum. They fled first to Mexico, then presented themselves, last October 5th, at an official port of entry in San Diego. Their suffering, like Amalia's, began promptly. First, they were detained in a Customs and Border Protection facility, where, Oksana told me, "we'd knock for an hour just to try to get

them to let our kids go to the bathroom.” Oksana’s husband was separated from the rest of the family and held in a one-person cell, where he fell ill with a high fever. Soon, the whole family was sent to Dilley, where medical personnel seemed poorly equipped to address his symptoms; Oksana saw the staff Googling them. Meanwhile, Kamilla had developed a shooting pain in her ear. “They said, ‘Everything looks good,’ ” Oksana told me of the intake officials.

The next day, Oksana brought Kamilla to the medical office. Confident that her daughter had an ear infection, she wanted to obtain proper antibiotics. She was dismissed, she told me, but soon returned. This time, she recalled, a clinician said that it was just allergies and gave Kamilla antihistamines, telling them, “You came to the dustiest state!”

“I was outraged,” Oksana told me. “As a former medical professional, I can tell the difference between an ear infection and allergies!”

“After I created a ruckus, the nurse said, ‘Fine, give her an antibiotic,’ ” Oksana said. To obtain antibiotics and ear drops, Oksana and Kamilla had to stand in a long outdoor line. “We stood in line for two hours that night, in the cold, my child with a high fever and ear pain, until we finally got the drops,” Oksana said. She found it peculiar that the drops were in an unmarked vial; it was cold to the touch. She tried to warm the vial with her hands before administering the drops to her daughter. “But the guards said, ‘You’re holding up the line, you have to give them to her right now!’ ” Oksana told me. “They intimidated me, and so I did it, and right away Kamilla started crying and complaining of sharp pain. Pus started pouring from her ear.”



After weeks in family detention, Amalia had critically low oxygen levels. At a hospital, she received five diagnoses, including RSV and pneumonia.

Oksana shook her head as she recounted this to me; Kamilla remained motionless on the floor. “She cried that entire night,” Oksana continued. “After this treatment—if you can call it a treatment—my daughter said, ‘I can’t hear in this ear.’ It’s been nearly four months, and still her hearing has not been restored.” By the time we spoke, the family had been in detention for more than a hundred and twenty days—six times the legal limit.

Oksana told me that she had concluded that many of the people at Dilley were not qualified to administer the medical services that they were providing. Similar concerns had been raised about medical care in family detention during the first Trump Administration. In 2023, researchers affiliated with Harvard University and Massachusetts General Hospital analyzed the medical records of a hundred and sixty-five children who’d been held in family detention in Karnes County, Texas, between June, 2018, and October, 2020. According to the report, “There appeared to be a preponderance of providers practicing outside of their scope” and a “lack of pediatric-specific medical knowledge, evident in many medical records and

inadequate documentation of medical reasoning.” More recently, the Human Rights First and *RAICES* report alleged “consistent patterns” with medical care at Dilley: “delayed and denied treatments, misdiagnoses, ignored emergencies, and direct interference with ongoing care.”

At the end of our interview, Kamilla rose from the floor. She perked up as her mother described the small collection of Russian-language books that Kamilla had cherished in detention, provided by the facility: the fairy tales of Pushkin, “The Wonderful Wizard of Oz,” “Alice’s Adventures in Wonderland,” and the work of a Russian poet named Korney Chukovsky. Oksana seemed flush with a mix of pride and devastation as she spoke of her daughter’s literary curiosity. She told me, “Kamilla is turning twelve tomorrow.” She added that recently a woman had been released on her birthday. “So she got the idea that *ICE* gives birthday gifts and that maybe tomorrow, because of her birthday, she will be released.” Oksana had to urge Kamilla not to hope for their immediate freedom. She told me, “I’d always heard that America is wonderful with children, and that there’s so much love and nurturing toward kids here.” She continued, “So we’re bewildered. Is this not America?”

Prompt release wasn’t impossible for the family, I knew. Unlike many others in detention, they had an expert legal team. On the night of February 6th, I’d got word from Mukherjee that, after fifty-seven days in detention, Amalia and her parents had been released from Dilley. A staffer had driven the family more than an hour to Laredo and dropped them at a migrant shelter, without returning Amalia’s birth certificate, her vaccination records, or the medications she’d been prescribed at the hospital. (The family did eventually receive copies of the documents, after multiple requests.) They made their way to their sponsor’s home in California, where Amalia found balloons awaiting her, along with a music box and a train set.

When I spoke to the family, two nights later on Zoom, they looked elated to be sitting on a comfortable red couch, with Amalia snuggling into her mother’s arms. Marcano wore her hair in braids and smiled often. After an hour or so, Amalia fell asleep. “Amalia loved the welcome balloons,” Marcano said, as she cradled the sleeping child. “She loved tossing them in the air.”

Not long after that conversation, Mukherjee sent me more news: Oksana's family was also slated for release. Soon, she told me, all five of them would be en route to a sponsor's home, also in California. She took this development as a sign of progress; increasingly, she's been able to get families out of detention after two or three parole requests. Still, Mukherjee told me, "Literally every day, I'm getting phone calls from families detained at Dilley who need help. It's just one horrifying situation after another."

When I spoke to the Indian family of four at Dilley, Guri, aged twelve, told me that he missed playing soccer at his school, back in L.A. Now, he said, he felt like "a bird in a cage—they just feed you and keep you here, like you're trapped." His sister, Manpreet, an eleven-year-old math whiz, had been at the medical clinic the night before we spoke, seeking help for vomiting, only to be turned away. That incident and others like it made her angry: "It's like when you're locked in a place and you can't move anywhere and you don't even have a little bit of freedom." Soon, their parents began to weep. "Before being here, my daughter spoke normally, but now, she lashes out," their father told me. Watching both of his children struggle with confinement and medical neglect had been, he said, a form of "mental torture."

Recently, I looked up Korney Chukovsky, whose poetry Kamilla had been reading. One of his series, I learned, features a character named Dr. Aybolit—which translates loosely to "Dr. Ouch It Hurts"—who tends to the ailments of animals. When presented with a medical crisis, Dr. Aybolit acts with great skill and compassion: "No problem," he calls out in one poem. "Give it here!" A mother hare is so pleased, at one point, that she laughs and shouts, "Well, thank you, Aybolit!"

I could see why Kamilla might have loved Chukovsky, and not just for his sense of humor. I sent her and her mother one of the poems I'd encountered in translation. When the doctor learns of young animals sick with cholera, appendicitis, malaria, and bronchitis, he races across fields, forests, and mountains to treat them. By the poem's end, one of the creatures calls out, "Glory, glory . . . Glory to the good doctors!" ♦

[Sarah Stillman](#), a staff writer, won a 2024 Pulitzer Prize for her [investigation into the legal doctrine of felony murder](#). She runs the Investigative Reporting Lab at Yale, and was named a MacArthur

Fellow in 2016.

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By Zach Zimmerman and Blythe Roberson | I will wear the perfect amount of sunscreen so that I don't look like clown-faced Mark Zuckerberg on that surfboard or red-faced Mark Zuckerberg at a Senate hearing.

[Shouts & Murmurs](#)

When It Gets Warm . . .

By [Zach Zimmerman](#) and [Blythe Roberson](#)

April 13, 2026



Illustration by Luci Gutiérrez

I will plant a garden, providing the plants with water, sunlight, and that third thing that plants need.

I will clean my house top to bottom until I lose interest and decide that dirty windows give me more privacy.

I will wear the perfect amount of sunscreen so that I don't look like clown-faced Mark Zuckerberg on that surfboard or red-faced Mark Zuckerberg at a Senate hearing.

I will buy tulips from the grocery store, and when they droop all the way over within twelve hours I will not take that as an omen about what spring holds.

You better believe I'm gonna start wearing my hat!

I will commit blackmail against any number of people wearing Tevas until one of them tells me where I can forage some ramps.

I will say, “This is the year I get really into baseball!,” and then I will go to one Yankees game but decide to leave because it is *too loud*.

I will learn what scapes are, and I will grow them in my perfect garden, which I still need to research so that I know what that third thing is that plants need.

I will join a run club, and I’ll run so regularly that I won’t even yell to everyone I meet, “I joined a run club!”

I will read “The Body Keeps the Score” on a park bench, after spending a decade just saying the title aloud and nodding.

I swear to God I’m going to ride a horse.

I will go to the botanical garden at the exact moment that the cherry blossoms reach peak bloom, and I’ll hate everyone else for also being at the botanical garden at the exact moment that the cherry blossoms reach peak bloom.

I will start biking, and, when I get where I’m going, I’ll spend the whole time worried that my bike has been stolen.

I will commit to never losing my sunglasses by never remembering to bring my sunglasses.

I will become a person who goes camping and gets Lyme disease so that I will finally be on trend.

I will realize that life is a series of seasons, phases, repeated attempts to be our best selves, and noble failures, but then I will forget all this when it’s summer and it’s too hot to have ideas.

Soil! The third thing is soil. I knew this garden was missing something. ♦
[*Zach Zimmerman* is the author of “Is It Hot in Here \(Or Am I Suffering for All Eternity for the Sins I Committed on Earth\)?” Their special “Surprise Me” was released in 2025.](#)

[*Blythe Roberson*](#) is the author of “[*How to Date Men When You Hate Men*](#)” and “[*America the Beautiful?*](#)”

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By Douglas Stuart | “Oh, not another story about me,” she cried. “Another book about how I was the world’s worst mother. I wish you could find something else to write about.”

[Fiction](#)

A Private View

By [Douglas Stuart](#)

April 12, 2026



Illustration by Karolis Strautniekas

None of the men looked up as my mother came down the museum stairs. I felt sorry for her. I wished I could make them notice. When she reached the middle landing, she paused, and I could tell she was resisting the urge to go back up and give them a second chance to get a good look. I smiled as she began to descend the final set. She gave a little kick with each step so that her long coat parted and revealed a shapely leg.

Jean wasn't wearing her glasses, which helped to spare her from disappointment. She couldn't see that the men had ignored her but I was certain she had felt it. She couldn't see me from this distance, either, but she didn't squint or search about; she simply arrived in the space knowing I would be there for her. I was always there for her.

[Read an interview with the author for the story behind the story.](#)

As she neared the bottom of the stairs, she unbuttoned her coat. She was wearing her favorite dress, the knitted one with herons embroidered on the front, their necks intertwined and the moonlit sky behind them set with paillettes and sequins. It had the cheap glint of Lurex and although it was loose it clung to her body in the places she was softest.

At the weekend I had taken her to Ann Taylor and then to Eileen Fisher and offered to buy her anything she liked. She came out of the changing room in one outfit after the other and stood before me as though I had talked her into trying on a hessian sack. I wondered aloud if she wouldn't like to look a little more refined for the opening. We persevered for ages before she said, in a voice so low that I almost missed it, "In all these years, I have never once tried to change you."

My mother crossed the foyer toward me.

"Do we have to stay long?" she asked.

"Hello to you, too," I said. "And no. Just long enough to be supportive."

Earlier that afternoon, my husband, David, had phoned in a panic because he had forgotten a folder full of checklists. I promised to bring the folder to him. I told my mother that I would stay uptown and would arrange a car to

bring her to the museum later that evening. I walked her through all the details for recognizing the Uber I'd order and assured her that everything would be all right.

The art crowd made me uncomfortable. I always needed a bracer before one of David's openings. When I came out of the subway, I went into the first hotel I saw, where I sat at the bar and drank an Islay malt. I would have liked nothing better than to waste the afternoon in a bar with my mother. But Jean was only fun to drink with until she drank too much.

Podcast: The Writer's Voice

[Listen to Douglas Stuart read "A Private View."](#)

As she stood before me now I realized how she had spent the afternoon in my absence: she had dyed her hair cough-syrup red. She had teased it into its usual, brittle coif and lacquered it with hair spray that made it sparkle like loft insulation.

"For goodness' sake. I was only gone a few hours."

She patted the back of her head. "Don't you like it?"

Jean had recently come to the opinion that her hair color—which had been bottle black since I was a boy—had been prematurely aging her. Now, in her sixties, she had stopped dyeing it and for a while had seemed to embrace its natural pigeon tones. When she arrived in New York, I hardly recognized her because she looked surprisingly appropriate for her age. I told her that the silver brightened her gray-green eyes, but every morning while she had been staying with us, she had worried that her smoking was staining the front. She didn't trust our bathroom mirror so I took her to the window. I held her chin and turned her in the daylight to see if there was a trace of nicotine in her curls. I liked to be this close to her, so I took longer than I needed to reassure her that, no, her hair was fine and that, yes, she was, despite the years, still beautiful.

I held her hands; the tips of her fingers were stained with red dye. She grinned as if she were my child and I had caught her playing with ink markers.

“I would have paid for a proper salon.”

“I was feeling drab. I couldn’t wait.” Pulling her hands from mine, she looked toward the exhibition.

“Please, Mum, just try and behave yourself.”

She scratched her top lip with her bottom teeth. With a little nod of her head, she indicated that I should look down. I saw that inside her coat pocket lay a quarter bottle of Smirnoff. “Just in case,” she said, and then, with two fingers held aloft, she grinned and gave me the Scout’s salute, “Best to be prepared, dyb, dyb, dyb.”

We walked toward the first gallery and I could tell by the scrape of her left shoe that she was still favoring her right hip.

“And how did the taxi know where to bring me?”

“I told you. I do it all from my phone.”

I loved introducing my mother to new technologies—I could spend hours explaining how dating sites and ChatGPT worked. “When I was a girl, we listened to records,” she would say. “And, when I was done having my own children, we still listened to records.”

The unveiling of the new wing had been timed to coincide with a mid-career retrospective of an Italian sculptor. The artist created devotional scenes representing the fourteen Stations of the Cross. For each station he arranged different figures around the room. Viewers could walk through the scenes and feel as if they were witness to the Passion of the Christ. It was a sprawling work that had taken the sculptor the better part of two decades to complete.

As David and I had lain in bed that morning, I had read the reviews to him. The critics said the show was well worth seeing and David was relieved. They saw a little Koons, and a little Hanson, and they said that the artist had clearly borrowed from Rubens with his mass of twisted bodies and the faithful who were crying out to the heavens. They saw the influence of

Tintoretto in the way the minor characters were caught up in their own petty dramas, in the way the baker haggled over bread as Jesus collapsed for the third and final time.

From a distance, the scenes seemed like classical interpretations of the Stations, but on closer inspection things became a little stranger. Throughout, the artist had substituted some of the Biblical figures for characters from popular culture. He swapped Pontius Pilate for a sneering Starscream from the Transformers. The weeping women of Jerusalem were interspersed with a half-dozen inconsolable Smurfs. There were other jarring, anachronistic details in the vignettes. Swiss Guards showed up in the crowd scenes with their feathered helmets and their square, muscular buttocks. Italian *nonne* stirred pots full of sauce with a look of utter boredom and, here and there, Neapolitan *ragazzi* sat atop their *motorini* and gawped at the torture. They held ceramic phones aloft, as if recording the Crucifixion for their social-media feeds.

The critic for the *Times* had debated whether it was “a triumph of artistic genius or the work of an obsessive shut-in, a grandmother who was mad for porcelain ornaments.” If I were being honest—which I could rarely be with David—it felt like a little bit of both.

The sculptures showed the strain and the delicacy of their materials. They wore their flaws without apology. The figures had cracked in many places and some of the statues revealed their complicated armature. All the reviews had featured one particular scene in which Mary Magdalene was replaced by a tight-faced Melania Trump. She was wearing her military jacket with “*I REALLY DON’T CARE DO U?*” emblazoned on the back. She had her arms folded and her hands were broken off in what was assumed to be a statement of her indifference toward suffering.

To fill the cracks in all the sculptures, the artist had melted vats of beeswax. To the beeswax he’d added his own blood and cups of semen that he had milked from anonymous Italian men he’d met on dating apps. In a type of *kintsugi*, he had lovingly mended the fault lines with this rose-colored paste so that all the figures seemed shot through with pale veins. The galleries were suffused with the tang of iron and old cum.

Tonight's private viewing was for curatorial staff and the museum's board of directors, but, more important, it was a chance to dazzle the wealthy donors who had bequeathed the permanent collection that filled the other halls. I was here purely because my husband was the assistant to the chief curator. I loved the museum, but I disliked the people who attended these events and how quickly they decided that I had nothing to offer them.

I felt fat and uncomfortable in my only suit. My trouser button was undone, concealed and secured by my belt. Earlier, as I waited for my mother to arrive, I had wandered through the exhibition alone. I knew a few of David's colleagues and they seemed similarly shoehorned into their best outfits. The benefactors, on the other hand, wore their wealth with ease. The men were in custom suits and the women in sleeveless dresses, all the better to show off the tans they had acquired over Christmas.

My mother walked around the first station. I was relieved to see that it held her attention. The rendering was so lifelike that even if the meaning and the metaphor were lost on her, she could appreciate the dedication that had created it. She stopped and frowned at the intergalactic robot standing in for Pontius Pilate. I wondered if she understood the reference to childhood cartoons. My sister, Louise, had spent hours perfecting the screechy, imperious cry of Starscream, only to use it when phoning the takeaway and ordering curry sauce and chips. I must have been smirking because my mother turned suddenly with the suspicion that I was laughing at her.

“What's so funny?”



"There's no easy way to say this, so I'll just put it in the chat."

Cartoon by Benjamin Schwartz

I caught myself, but it was too late. My mother was looking at me expectantly and I scrambled to erase my sister from the story. "You remember the cartoons I liked when I was little, with the robots that turned into cars and jets and things? Well, this guy is the baddie. The second-in-command."

My mother nodded loosely, as if a fly were buzzing around her head. It let me know that she heard me, but that she barely cared.

I followed her into the next gallery, where a photographer was shooting a large group of people. The man at the center looked so traumatized that I could only imagine that he was the sculptor. A chorus of museum staff was gathered around him, and my mother stopped to watch them. There were two young women, arty types in thick-framed glasses. They were wearing variations on the same rumpled plissé frock, and, just before my mother said it, I knew she would ask me if the women owned an iron.

"The crinkles are deliberate, Mum. They bought them like that."

"Would it kill them to buy a belt?"

As the tallest man in most rooms, David was usually easy to spot. I searched the crowd for him. It was strange that he was not with this group.

I turned back to my mother, but she had wandered away. I meandered among the statues a while. A magnificent Raffaella Carrà appeared in a celestial vision to a crowd of Roman soldiers, while off to the side a gathering of ceramic youths did the Dougie for our fallen Christ.

“Is there much more to see?” my mother asked, startling me slightly.

“Where did you slink off to?”

She shrugged. “See, that taxi you sent for me . . .”

I thought I could smell vodka on her breath.

“It wasn’t yellow. This man pulled up and rolled down the window and started calling out your name. But I couldn’t understand him because he had an accent.”

“Jeanie, you have an accent.”

“And so I had to walk right up to the window, like a common prostitute.”

My mother could look so small sometimes. I was aware that she did it deliberately. She relaxed her shoulders and let her arms go limp. It was an old trick but I was powerless to resist. “Another half hour and then we’ll go for a drink, yeah?” I said.

“Yeah,” she said with a sudden smile. “You have yourself a deal.”

As soon as I looked up again, I glimpsed David in the next room. He was watching me and frowning. We locked eyes and I smiled and gave him two enthusiastic thumbs-up. “I’m so proud of you,” I mouthed silently, but David only puffed out his cheeks in exasperation.

I wondered how much he had seen of my mother and me.

He was in a group of employees who were following in slow procession behind an older man who was being pushed through the galleries in a wheelchair.

Fredrik Bolin had been the chief curator of painting and sculpture for almost three decades. This was to be the Norwegian's last show for the museum before he was forced into retirement at the end of the year. David was the first assistant to the soon-to-be former chief curator, while the women he trailed were assistant curators. It was a slight rearrangement of words that annoyed David because it defined roles that were, in fact, very different. It was the women's job to worry about the art and the artists, to curate shows and concern themselves with provenance. It was David's job to take care of Mr. Bolin.

We had discussed the wheelchair many times before. It was David's belief that, as soon as he put his hands on the back of the chair, his career would be over and he would be reduced to some kind of human-powered locomotive. He asked me if that was fair. Didn't he already order the man's lunch and pick up his dry cleaning? Didn't he manage his calendar and decipher every crumpled receipt that Fredrik tossed on his desk? It was too much to be expected to move the man from room to room, from desk to bathroom.

He had perfected the art of looking the other way whenever Fredrik needed assistance. He simply moved toward the back and waited for a woman to feel the pressure to step forward and push the curator. It rarely failed. When I had asked him why Fredrik didn't just buy a motorized wheelchair, David huffed and said that it was because Fredrik was in denial, and even after fifteen years in the chair he still believed that he would soon be back on his feet.

David looked handsome in his suit. I jabbed my tongue into my cheek, letting him know I would suck him off later. He crossed his eyes quickly. Then he scanned the room to see if anyone had seen him act the fool. I was smiling as he turned back to the curatorial cortège.

He was the tallest of five tall brothers. His father was the fourth generation in a long line of gentlemen ranchers—weekend cowboys who'd made their fortune in Austin as attorneys for large oil companies, but whose identity was still tied to the thousands of acres that the family owned near Marfa.

His mother was caught between the opinions of her church and the newfound liberalism of the Austin élites. One weekend at the ranch, she said that David had broken her heart, but if “you boys”—and she used the phrase “you boys” with a flap of her hands to mean all the little queers in the country—“if you boys can get married now, then perhaps you boys should.” To her mind, if David insisted on being gay, then perhaps matrimony would keep her church friends from obsessing about his sex life.

Until we were married, whenever I visited the ranch, David slept in the main house while I bunked in a well-appointed cabin that sat at the end of a dirt road. At first, David complained that none of his brothers’ girlfriends had been asked to do the same, but it soon became clear that the casita was preferable to the main house, where his mother hovered over everything and darkened the mood if she was not the constant center of her sons’ attention.

As we sprawled in his grandmother’s old oak bed, he made me promise never to write about his family. I agreed on condition that I could become the lady of the house when his mother died. He rolled on top of me and said that my mind was too precious to spoil in the dusty Texan heat.

I had been in Marfa the Thanksgiving that David announced he’d be assisting the chief curator. I had witnessed his father puncture his joy by telling him that no Loudon man would ever put his hands to another man’s wheelchair.

Later that night, we drove to a distant gas station simply to escape the compound. I complained about what his father had said and David yelled at me. He said that I didn’t understand how complicated class issues were in Texas but that I should, seeing as I was a Scotsman, who never, ever shut the fuck up about oppression. He mocked me and did a hideous impression of a Dickensian urchin. As cruel as his words were, to hear a Texan attempt a Cockney cretin who seemed somehow related to Mrs. Doubtfire was infuriatingly funny.

I laughed bitterly. Then I agreed that class was indeed a tricky subject, but, in fact, it was quite easy to not be a cunt.

He often treated me like a yokel, like a cousin from the Old Country who didn't understand the workings of a nation as great as America. His family wore bluejeans and sun-beaten hats, and when they were among their laborers they almost seemed of the people. But I could feel the way they maintained a subtle distance, a faint superiority as defined as any English lord's. They were Scottish Presbyterians from generations back and so they overlooked it when I used phrases like "council house" and "school dinners," because although I had been poor, at least I was Scottish, pale and pure from the source.

David's favorite insult was to tell me I didn't know what I was talking about. He did it so often that I once made a list of all the things that he granted me expertise over. Those were rain, housecleaning, and alcoholism.

"I'm tired of you looking at my family like that."

"Like what?"

"Like they're villains."

"Yeah," I said snidely, "I apologize. I do. I was wrong. I see that now. How dare I think badly of a family that stole everything from Mexicans."

He pulled the car over and told me to get out.

When I refused, he lifted his boot and kicked me out.

He left me there, sitting on an embankment, shivering in the darkness, for an hour or more. There was no phone signal, no passing cars, no house lights for at least thirty miles.

Eventually, guilt or shame got the better of him and he came back to collect me.

"You can't look down on another person's family," he said.

"I know that," I said.

I had been humbled by the cold. More afraid of the dark plains than I would admit.

“No, I mean you, *you* specifically. How dare you look down on someone else’s family?”

“A penny for them?” Jean asked.

I made sure that David was out of my line of sight before I replied. “I was thinking about a story I want to write.”

“Oh, not another story about me,” she cried. “Another book about how I was the world’s worst mother. I wish you could find something else to write about.”

“Yeah? Me, too,” I said. “I’m trying, but every time I think I’m writing about something else, I always end up writing about you.”

“Obsessed,” she said. “That’s what you are.”

“It was my childhood.”

“Well, it’s not healthy. It’s high time you got over it.”

“What?” I scoffed. “Just like my sister did?”

At the mention of our Louise, my mother reared back. She turned and said to the room behind her, “Do you hear how he talks to me? How he talks to his only mother?”

But no one was listening.

My sister, Louise, taught art at a secondary school within one of the city’s most deprived housing schemes. She joked that, really, she was a bouncer in a night club where the patrons didn’t need to be drunk to start a fight. She lived with her husband and their three daughters in an airy flat on the leafy south side of Glasgow. It would have taken Jean two short bus rides to visit her. But Louise had cut our mother out of her life many years ago.

Louise's breaking point had come one Christmas. It was to be the last Christmas before I left Glasgow to live in New York. For several years, our mother had been asking to host us at her small flat, saying that she wanted to make it up to us for spoiling so many of our Christmases when we were growing up. Louise had been able to duck this in the past, but, this particular year, Jean had started her pleading early and I had bullied my sister until she agreed to give our mother one more chance.

On Christmas Day, I showed up on time and knew instantly that something was wrong. My sister was scowling and pacing the path outside my mother's flat. Her car was parked nearby and the engine was running. I peered into the car. My eldest niece looked to be on the verge of tears. She was wearing a velvet dress and her hair was in ribbons. Her presents were arranged all around her as if she were the centerpiece in a gift basket. I rapped on the glass and waved hello to my brother-in-law.

It had begun to snow. The tip of Louise's nose was bright red, which made her eyes seem ferociously blue. Without asking, I tried to guess what she already knew: that Jean was lying dead—or, more likely, dead drunk somewhere—and that Christmas was cancelled again.

We waited half an hour or more, debating whether to call the police out on Christmas Day. Then, while Louise was peering through the letterbox, our mother alighted from the back of a black cab. A young man I had never seen before got out and paid the driver with a handful of loose change. Jean was all smiles. She had a single rotisserie chicken in one hand and was swinging a plastic bag in the other. The bag was full of winnings from an all-nighter at the Corinthian. The coins were rattling, and the pale pallor of a sleepless night made her seem more like Jacob Marley than like anyone's idea of Santa Claus.

Louise never spoke to our mother again. When she fell pregnant with her third daughter, she bought herself a journal with a photograph of a baby wrapped in cabbage leaves on the cover. She wrote a manifesto, a promise to her unborn child about the type of mother she would be: *When you're feeling sad, I won't tell you that men don't like that in a girl. When you wake up in the middle of the night, I will be at home.*

After the baby was born, she wrote our mother a forty-six-page goodbye. I'd moved to New York by then, and Louise's letter—which my mother read down the phone—made it clear I would be the only one of her children to stay in contact with her.

For the first few years, I hoped that my mother and my sister could make amends and so I acted as a courier of sorts. I kept my mother updated on my nieces' progress. If, one day, there was a reconciliation, I didn't want the girls to be strangers to Big Jean. But if I made it sound as if my sister and her daughters were enjoying their lives, it only sank my mother into the drink. I couldn't tell her how much joy the girls brought to everyone who knew them. How one was born for the stage or how the other had inexplicably inherited Jean's love for animal prints. So, instead, when she asked how they were doing, I stuck to the driest narration: yes, they were getting big; yes, they were enjoying school.

When I was alone with my nieces—and out of earshot of my sister—I regaled them with the legends of Granny Jean. If one of my nieces mentioned that she had heard that Granny Jean was a bad woman, I would admit that sometimes she drank so much she fell in the street, but sometimes when she fell, she could catch herself in a forward roll, and spring up to her feet again like an acrobat.



Cartoon by Jared Nangle

The girls liked that. It made them laugh.

When I was alone with my sister, I spoke of our mother as if I were a social worker, as if Jean were a foster kid who had made mistakes but needed another chance. When our mother achieved fleeting periods of sobriety—a month, four months, a hundred and fifty-three days—I was disgusted to hear myself speak of it with naïve optimism, as though our family had nearly won the lottery, and, if we played again, then next time, maybe next time, we would win.

I looked around for Jean and saw her near a grouping where Jesus meets his mother on the road to Calvary. The sculptor had managed to carve Mary's robes with such realistic folds it was difficult to imagine that they were not actually cloth. I watched my mother look left and right before she reached out her hand to touch.

"They're a bit like massive Nativity scenes," I said. "I don't get the hype."

She ignored me and walked on.

I followed her but I caught my foot on one of the pediments and tripped slightly. I locked eyes with the docent and bent to wipe the scuff from the plinth.

My mother wandered ahead and I took the opportunity to regard her instead of the art. I didn't care for the sculptures, not really. I found them repetitive, and being forced to find the incongruous characters was like playing "Where's Wally?" over and over. My mother paused by a wall plaque and for a moment I tried to imagine her as an independent New Yorker, as a person who belonged in these circles. Perhaps she was a faded star. An eccentric burnout, someone for whom the eighties had been dazzling but dimming at the same time. She could have been a painter of geometric abstracts who lived in a former squat on the Lower East Side, a woman with many lovers, whose work had never quite broken through but would find an appreciative audience after she died.

We moved along to the fifth station, where Simon of Cyrene was carrying Jesus' Cross for him. An inquisition of potbellied priests stood at the side of the road. They wore satisfied expressions and appeared oblivious to the suffering of our Saviour. Two priests had raised their cassocks and were peeing into his path. The artist had coated their stubby penises in gold leaf.

I heard my mother tut. She was looking around for someone to protest to. "That's a fucking disgrace," she said. "Children could see that."

"Oh, they have, Jean, they have."

I considered telling her about the three different penises I had seen by the time I was twelve. It seemed that all my mother's boyfriends had liked to wear her short, quilted housecoat. Some mornings they would emerge from her bedroom and join me while I knelt before the television and watched cartoons. As the men spooned sugar puffs into their mouths they would spread their legs—perhaps to avoid spilling milk on themselves—and the gown would splay open. One man had sat so close I could smell him.

Years later, I asked my sister if she remembered these men and if they had ever flashed her. I was relieved when she looked at me with genuine horror. As my sister poured more wine, I wondered aloud if it had been carelessness or if these men had in fact enjoyed exposing themselves to a little boy. Louise said that it probably was sexual, considering the idlers and wastrels our mother was attracted to, but perhaps they were also expressing their dominance, stating their claim to the territory by showing themselves to the only other male in the house. I could not forget the long, sallow penis of one particular boyfriend. It had been so much darker than his pale, melancholy face.

My mother said that she had seen enough, so we made our way back through. The reception was in full swing now. I saw David standing in a corner talking to a German gallerist he knew. I could tell by the flush in his cheeks that he had finally had a drink and had managed to relax a little.

“You want to be careful with that one,” she said. “He’s too used to getting his own way.”

“I know.”

“And you’ve let yourself go.”

“It’s the writing,” I said. “The better it goes, the less I move.”

“So, it’s my fault you’re getting fat?”

“What the fuck are you doing!”

His anger took me by surprise. He had raised his voice and several people turned to look.

While I had been distracted by my mother, David had crossed the galleries toward us. He grabbed my arm and pulled me round the far side of one of the sculptures.

“Babe, the show looks so goo—”

“I’ve been watching you all night!” he spat. “You’ve been doing that mumbling again.” He raised his hands to his face. His fingers splayed and writhed like a terrible mandible. “That fucking . . . *chattering*.”

“I was working up a story,” I said. “I’m sorry.”

It was a bad habit, but when I was writing I mumbled to myself. I was unaware that I was doing it. When it was going well, I imagined whole conversations and spoke them out loud. I couldn’t write without talking to myself.

“Don’t lie to me,” he said. “You were talking to your mother again.”

“I wasn’t—”

“You were! You were talking to your mother. Everyone can see you!”

Flecks of spume were gathering in the corners of his mouth.

I wanted to wipe them away.

The crowd had gathered in the foyer to hear the sculptor give his speech. The men’s bathroom was empty. I sat on the toilet lid with the stall door open and watched as my mother fixed her makeup at the mirror. The elegant clutch she had arrived with had somehow morphed into the massive, bottomless handbag of my youth. She took a brace of Carlsberg lager from its depths, separated one from the pack, cracked it open, and sucked the foam from the top. “You shouldn’t let him talk to you like that,” she said between slurps. “Once they start they never stop.”

I wanted to say: Look at him, and then look at me. He was the best I would ever get, and anybody who saw us together thought the exact same thing.

But before I could tell her this, I noticed that she had changed her shoes. When had she done that? She was wearing the scuffed black heels that she used to color in with a bingo marker.

This was the problem with conjuring my mother. All the memories I had of her were out of date. All those memories made me sad. I didn't want to be sad. I wanted to be happy. I wanted her to see how well I was doing here in New York.

"So you fought." She took a large hairbrush from her bag and brushed the volume back into her hair. "Big whoop."

"You're wrong to use the past tense. You need the present continuous."

"What? I wish you would let me talk in my own voice."

"I do," I said, sounding more hurt than I would care to admit.

Jean gave a hollow laugh. "You twist my words. And you do it in your stupid books, too. I don't sound anything like maself."

"Don't say that. *Please.*"

She laid her meagre makeup on the counter. The dried-out mascara she needed to spit on, the tube of worn-down lipstick. I registered that her hair was no longer cough-syrup red but the bottled blue-black that she liked. When had she dyed it again?

She caught my eye in the mirror and held it a moment. "You're not going to cry, are you?"

"You're not allowed to ask men that."

"Who says?"

“And you can’t ask us about our weight, either. We feel bad about our bodies.”

She frowned at me.

“And you should know that we’re not allowed to flirt with you anymore.”

She spun around. “Why not?”

“You complained.”

“Not me.”

“No, Jean,” I laughed. “Not you.”

She dabbed a little lipstick on the blades of her cheeks then smoothed it in. “Maybe I left at the right time.”

There was a round of applause out in the gallery and I knew the speeches were finished. I came out of the stall and crossed to the sink. I washed my hands.

“I hate to say it. But what if David was right?” she said. “What if you need to stop all this?”

“But I like talking to you. Don’t you like talking to me?”

“But I’m not talking to you.”

I disliked that as an answer and so I screwed my eyes shut. When I opened them again I forced her to say, “Of course I do, darling. I like talking to you very much.”

Two banker types came in to use the facilities. I cupped my phone to my ear and chatted to myself as though I were on a call.

Outside, the galleries were mostly empty. Anyone who was left was gathering at the bar.

David had been watching my muttering for some months before he asked what I was doing. Later, the fact that he had waited those months would be used as evidence in one of our fights to show how painfully self-absorbed he was. When he first asked who I was talking to, I had lied and said I was working on a screenplay and obsessing over dialogue.

He was American, so he liked that.

The next time he caught me was in public. We were heading in different directions on the 6 train when he spied me across the tracks. I had been unaware that he was watching as I talked to my mother. I was laughing out loud, pulling faces in response to some funny little thing she'd said. He rushed up the stairs and along the platform toward me.

People were staring. I thought I should be honest. I told him what I was doing. I told him that I was talking to her. I told him that it comforted me sometimes.

He looked at me like I was mad.



"If he's going to become an equestrian, I'd rather he did it at home."
Cartoon by Justin Sheen

I felt a sadness. I was homesick. But I was not out of my mind. I didn't feel unwell. I knew what was real and what was not.

If I felt anything then it was a shameful guilt that my own life should be so good when my mother's had been so tough.

I tried to explain all this to David but I could see he didn't understand. How could he understand when his own mother was still alive?

It was difficult to calibrate Jean in my imagination. It was horrible, but for all our happy memories I remembered her most vividly in 2014, in the months before she died. She had gone missing for a few days and one of her neighbors alerted the police, who then phoned me in New York. I had flown back to Glasgow and landed mere hours before the police brought her home. Jean had been on a bad bender, and a good Samaritan had found her wandering by the river, shoeless in the January sleet.

It did me no good to think of her this way. That was a bad memory, an old film that should never be rewound.

What I wanted was to share the now with her. I wanted to bring her into my life and spoil her. To do all the things I never got to do with her when she was alive.

I wanted to take her to Las Vegas because she would have loved the ceilings painted to resemble skies. I wanted to bring her to brunch with my friends and then waste a Sunday walking to Tompkins Square Park and feeling a little tipsy as we laughed at the puppies in the dog run.

I looked around for David but he was nowhere to be seen. I figured the team had moved on to dinner, so I went to the bar and got myself a glass of prosecco. I returned to my mother and in my mind I handed a glass to her. She tasted it, then she grimaced.

"You'll have to develop a taste for the finer things. No more of the cheap Commotion Lotion, you old lush."

She liked to be insulted. She squeezed my arm and pulled into my side. She was chuckling to herself and I closed my eyes. I loved the smell of her hair spray.

We moved in the direction of the twelfth station. Without discussing it, we had skipped several rooms, coming to the tacit agreement that we didn't

really care for the art. I sipped my prosecco, while my mother downed hers in three gulps.

The bar staff were beginning to clear up for the night. When I turned back to my mother she was wearing a demure shift dress and I smiled to see it.

“You look nice.”

I had gone to Ann Taylor recently. I liked to spend time picking out hypothetical outfits, choosing dresses for a gallery opening or maybe something pretty for a summer wedding. I wanted to update her, to imagine her here and in this moment. I had a hidden folder on my laptop and I clipped images of clothing and hair styles that she might like.

I was often drawn to women on the subway, older, elegant women who took good care of themselves. I sat opposite them and studied their appearance and imagined my mother had lived to her fifties and become one of them. I liked to dream that I had been able to improve her life, and that, as my own circumstances improved, I had spoiled her the way a son should.

We arrived at the final station. Jesus was being taken down from the Cross. The rendering of his lifeless body was so realistic, the grief etched on the faces of the crowd so plaintive, that despite feeling lightheaded from the wine, we both fell silent. We walked in opposite directions around the sculpture. As though in reverence to Mary’s pain, the sculptor had limited the substitutions, but there, at the edge of the scene, sat Bambi and Thumper. Here, in this new context, their large eyes did not seem wide with their usual wonder but swollen with grief and disbelief. We stood for a while considering the gouges in our Lord’s hands. Nicodemus, looking on as the body was unhooked, had a face that seemed familiar—a strong nose, a soft, curling beard, an expression that said he could bear this weight with dignity.

“Don’t you think that looks like your dad?” she said quietly.

I swallowed the last of my prosecco and winced. All the grit and sugar had settled at the bottom.

Jean took a step toward the sculpture. “Your father could have done better than me. I always thought that.”

“We could *all* have done better than you, Jeanie.”

My mother laughed.

“I like to look at your wedding photo,” I said. “You were so young.”

“We thought we knew it all.” She took my hand and squeezed it. “I wish you hadn’t changed your name. I like Jack, but you were always my wee Jimmy.” She seemed lost to her own thoughts for a moment. Then she said, “Mary Magdalene is a hard act to follow.”

I forgave her the cliché because it felt very much like a thing she would actually say. Besides, wasn’t the whole thing a cliché? I dared not look at my life from the outside. I mortified myself when I did.

I texted David. *Where are you? Can I come?*

I watched the dots as he started typing. Then I watched the dots disappear.

I went to the coat check and collected my puffer. I imagined that they’d given me my mother’s coat, too, and that it was a thick, floor-length fur.

I returned to her. She was standing alone in the empty gallery. When she saw me she smiled. For all my mother’s faults, she rarely dwelled on sadness.

Her stomach made an audible gurgle. She placed her hand on it. “I was so nervous that I couldn’t eat. Do they not feed you at these things?”

I helped her into her coat. “Listen, Mum. I can’t see you for a while.”

“I know,” she turned and put her arm into the sleeve. Her hand was so small. “Och, you go on now. Sure, I’ll be all right.”

“I always wanted to see you in a museum.”

She looked up at me a long moment. Then she placed her hand on my cheek. I could almost feel it.

She didn't dissolve or blow away in a gust of rose petals. There was never any cinematic ending. I simply turned away. I stopped thinking of her and she was gone.

I zipped up my jacket and headed up the stairs with the last of the patrons. Out on the street, the snow had turned to slush again. I took out my phone and texted David that I was sorry, that I would try harder. This time he didn't bother to open the text and I knew that he was punishing me with silence. ♦

[Douglas Stuart](#) is the author of "[Shuggie Bain](#)," which won the Booker Prize, and "[John of John](#)" (May 2026).

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A Lesson of Vietnam: Getting in Is Easier than Getting Out

The war was sustained by a seductive delusion: that an unwinnable conflict might still be managed into an outcome short of humiliation.

By [Louis Menand](#)

April 13, 2026



In the final collapse of South Vietnam, evacuation flights became scenes of panic, desperation, and abandonment. Photograph from Rolls Press / Popperfoto / Getty

On March 8, 1965, at 9 *a.m.*, United States marines landed on a beach ten miles north of the city of Da Nang, South Vietnam. Americans had been providing direct military support in South Vietnam since 1954, the year the country was split in two, and the war, beginning with France's fight to preserve its colony, had been going on since 1946. But the marines were the first American combat troops to arrive.

The Johnson Administration downplayed the significance of the landing. It explained that the marines were being deployed to secure an airbase used for Operation Rolling Thunder, a bombing campaign against North Vietnam that had begun a week earlier and that would continue, with two brief pauses, for three and a half years.

You can always stop bombing, though. When boots are, as they say, on the ground, your off-ramp options dwindle. Everyone understood that sending in the marines marked a fork in the road that could not be easily unforked. Once Americans started getting killed, it would be hard to leave without winning the war, and the war might prove very hard to win. For this reason, the marines had spent the previous thirty-two days on boats circling in the South China Sea, waiting while the decision to land was being debated in Washington, D.C.

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Most of the marines in the first wave had little idea what to expect. They came in on landing craft, D Day style, and leaped into the surf in full battle dress, carrying M-14s. As they stormed the beach, they were astonished to be greeted not by enemy fire but by photographers, young Vietnamese women handing out garlands of flowers, and a few sightseers. A banner read “Welcome to the Gallant Marines.”

It wasn't only the marines who were uninformed about what was happening. The South Vietnamese government was, too. The United States had neglected to tell it that the marines were coming. It was a sign, if one were needed, that this would be a war in which nothing would go according to plan.

Ten years later, on April 30, 1975, the United States did get out of Vietnam, an episode that is the setting for Elisa Tamarkin's unusual and imaginative book "Done in a Day: Telex from the Fall of Saigon" (Chicago). It could be said that the end did not go according to plan, either, except that there was not much of a plan to begin with. Despite intelligence that Saigon would be overrun by the North Vietnamese Army in a matter of days, the American Ambassador, Graham Martin, refused to prepare for an evacuation.

Martin seemed to have believed, up to the very last minute, that a negotiated settlement was possible, and he worried that it would be demoralizing for the South Vietnamese to see Americans packing up. So he did nothing except reassure Henry Kissinger, who was the national-security adviser and the Secretary of State (under Gerald Ford, now the fourth American President to wish that Vietnam would just go away), that it was "a bit premature" to think about departure.

But everyone else knew the end had come. That winter, the North Vietnamese had launched a major offensive. There was initial resistance from the South Vietnamese Army (ARVN), but, on March 13th, the President of South Vietnam, Nguyen Van Thieu, ordered a retreat from the central part of the country. The soldiers had little time to prepare; the retreat turned into a rout. Many ARVN soldiers deserted, and the North Vietnamese advanced without much trouble.

Two major cities north of Saigon, Hue and Da Nang, fell rapidly—Hue on March 25th and Da Nang five days later. And the North Vietnamese were taking no prisoners. Tens of thousands fled by boat from Hue, many drowning in the attempt, and by the end of March a million refugees—soldiers, civilians, whole extended families—were clogging Route 7B, a major highway, trying to get farther south. The caravan along the road came to be known as the Convoy of Tears.

On March 29th, a private contractor flew a 727 jet into the airport at Da Nang on a mission to rescue women and children. The moment the plane landed, a mob poured onto the runway and began chasing it by jeep, by motorbike, and on foot. Three hundred managed to clamber aboard before it took off. People shot others ahead of them in line. Women and children were trampled. As the plane ascended, someone threw a grenade at it,

damaging a wing. All but five of the adults who made it on were men, most of them soldiers. Dozens climbed into the cargo bay. Seven people hung on to the outside and fell off during the flight. (A similar scene is rendered in Viet Thanh Nguyen's "The Sympathizer," one of a number of things in that amazing novel which, if you did not know the history, you would find unbelievable.)

During the week of April 21st, the United States Air Force transport of evacuees out of Saigon's airport, Tan Son Nhut, was in full swing. Those with proper paperwork were instructed to wait for a bus at a designated pickup point to be driven to the airport, but sometimes the buses did not show up, and sometimes the paperwork was inadequate or nonexistent.

At Tan Son Nhut, the terminal was jammed. All sorts of trickery were tried, from claiming to be a family member of someone who had the right paperwork—one man got three "wives" out that way—to naked bribery. People were bandaged or put in casts, then driven onto the tarmac in ambulances with sirens blaring. Flights for orphans were organized. (It was highly unlikely that the North Vietnamese were going to harm orphans.) The first "baby flight" crashed when taking off, killing a hundred and thirty-eight people, including seventy-eight children.

Nevertheless, according to Max Hastings's stupendous military history "Vietnam: An Epic Tragedy, 1945-1975" (2018), Air Force planes were able to make three hundred and four sorties out of Tan Son Nhut, successfully evacuating nearly forty-three thousand Americans and Vietnamese. Then, in the early morning of April 29th, the North Vietnamese shelled the airport, rendering the runways useless for fixed-wing aircraft. Two marines, Corporal Charles McMahan and Lance Corporal Darwin Judge, were killed in that strike, the last American soldiers to die in Vietnam.

By the time Ambassador Martin authorized an evacuation, the only way out—since Martin had vetoed a proposal to put refugees on freighters and take them down the Saigon River to the coast (too demoralizing a spectacle)—was by helicopter. The scheme (unfortunate code name: Operation Frequent Wind) was a desperate measure. The rooftop and courtyard of the American Embassy, plus thirteen other buildings in Saigon and Tan Son Nhut, were

designated as departure points. People gathered there in the hope that there would be space for them on a helicopter.



Cartoon by Emily Bernstein

Hastings reports that, over a period of eighteen hours, Marine helicopters flew six hundred and eighty-two missions, carrying 1,373 Americans and 5,595 Vietnamese and other nationals to ships in the South China Sea, where the Seventh Fleet was moored. When there was not enough room on the ships' decks for incoming helicopters to land, empty ones were pushed into the sea. Thirty or forty helicopters were sunk.

On the streets of Saigon, there was widespread looting. ARVN soldiers stripped to their underwear so that the North Vietnamese could not identify them. At the U.S. Embassy, a frantic attempt to destroy papers that could be used to identify collaborators went wrong when backwash created by helicopter propellers scattered shredded files all over the courtyard for the North Vietnamese to reconstruct, which they did. The Embassy was pillaged. Five million American dollars were burned.

Martin flew out in the next-to-last helicopter, at 4:58 A.M. on April 30th. Eventually, every American who wanted to evacuate was evacuated, but thousands of Vietnamese who had worked for or collaborated with the Americans were left to the mercy of the North Vietnamese. Many had been assured that they would be evacuated. They had been lied to. Before Martin left, Ford had ordered that only Americans were to board the remaining helicopters, and Martin and Kissinger feared that, if the Vietnamese realized they were being abandoned, they would begin shooting Americans. When the last helicopter left the Embassy, at 7:53 a.m. on April 30th, four hundred and twenty Vietnamese stood in the courtyard, waiting for the rescue they had been promised. Thousands more were massed outside the gates.

The last people to leave were eleven marines who had been assigned to protect the Embassy. When they got onto the roof, they dropped a tear-gas grenade down the stairwell to prevent Vietnamese from trying to join them. They had to wait two hours for a helicopter to arrive, and one marine slipped while trying to get on board and had to be pulled in as the helicopter was lifting off. He was Juan Jose Valdez, a sergeant from Texas. He had landed in Vietnam ten years earlier, one of the first marines to arrive. Now he was the last American out.

The fall of Saigon is an extremely well-documented event. Hundreds of reporters and photojournalists came to Vietnam to witness the end of a war that had lasted thirty years and in which millions had died, and many recorded their impressions. It was something of a scene. (Hunter S. Thompson was there for *Rolling Stone*, though he does not seem to have done much reporting.)

The English writer James Fenton came to see the dénouement. More or less by accident, he found himself riding on the first North Vietnamese tank to enter the courtyard of the Presidential palace in Saigon. His article “The Fall of Saigon,” published in *Granta* in 1985, is a classic account. Philip Caputo, who had landed as a marine in 1965, returned in 1975 as a journalist for the *Chicago Tribune* and described the evacuation in his best-selling memoir, “A Rumor of War” (1977). He was airlifted out from Tan Son Nhut airport on April 29th.



A C.I.A.-run Air America helicopter takes on evacuees during the improvised final evacuation from Saigon. Photograph from Bettmann / Getty

American officials provided their accounts, too, most monumentally the C.I.A. analyst Frank Snepp's "Decent Interval," published in 1977 at almost six hundred pages—a book that exposed the American failure to organize an efficient evacuation. (The C.I.A. sued Snepp for breach of the secrecy agreement he had signed when he joined the agency, and the case went to the Supreme Court, which ruled in favor of the C.I.A. Snepp had to hand his royalties over to the government.) Larry Engelmann's oral history, "Tears Before the Rain" (1990), published vivid firsthand stories by American and Vietnamese survivors.

Footage of those final days can be seen in Ken Burns and Lynn Novick's ten-part PBS docuseries "The Vietnam War" (2017), and in a previous PBS series, the thirteen-part "Vietnam: A Television History" (1983), a first-rate documentary with less of the voice-of-God gravitas that sometimes afflicts Burns's productions. And, of course, there are photographs, the best known by a Dutch photojournalist, Hubert van Es: a line of people trying to get up a ladder to a helicopter perched on a rooftop. (The photo was incorrectly captioned: the building in the picture is not the U.S. Embassy, and that helicopter was not the last helicopter. It is an Air America aircraft, which means it belonged to the C.I.A. The agency had its own airline.)

One reason the ending came as a shock was that Vietnam was the original forever war. Daniel Ellsberg, the man who liberated the Pentagon Papers, called it a "stalemate machine." And yet, as Tamarkin says in "Done in a Day," the outcome should not have surprised anyone, since there was never

any intelligence suggesting that the war could end in anything other than a defeat for the U.S.

Heads of state—Charles de Gaulle, Jawaharlal Nehru—warned American Presidents to stay out of Southeast Asia. When Kissinger visited Saigon in October, 1965, as an adviser to the American Ambassador, Henry Cabot Lodge, he wrote in his diary that “no one could really explain to me how even on the most favorable assumptions . . . the war was going to end.”

What the Pentagon Papers revealed is that the American government had reason to know all along that the venture was ill-fated. After 1968, the goal was to somehow abandon the war but avoid defeat. Richard Nixon’s euphemism for this was “peace with honor.” Nixon had run for President in 1968 on a promise to end the war, but, by the time the troops were finally removed, in March, 1973, twenty thousand more U.S. soldiers had died. Those lives were sacrificed on the altar of national honor. The United States got nothing in 1973 that it could not have gotten in 1969.

Tamarkin has a fresh angle on the fall of Saigon, a personal one: her stepfather, Bob Tamarkin, flew out on the last civilian helicopter on the morning of April 30th. Bob was not an American official. He was a reporter, the Saigon bureau chief for the *Chicago Daily News*. He managed to get over the wall and onto the Embassy grounds, and then to the rooftop and out. He was the last correspondent to leave.

He was flown to the U.S.S. Blue Ridge, an amphibious-command ship, and from there to the carrier U.S.S. Okinawa, where he wrote a diary of his last hours in Saigon, published in the *Chicago Daily News* on May 6th. He concludes the piece:

My chopper lifted off, its red lights blinking, and headed toward the South China Sea. The passengers, including me, sat stoically in the dark, tired and numb. Some were dazed, finding it difficult to believe that the Americans were pulling out in this manner, skulking away in the darkness.

Below in the courtyard where the big choppers had been loading, the headlights from the cars and trucks surrounding the parking lot were

still on to light the way for the choppers.

Hundreds of Vietnamese looked up, waiting for the next one.

It never came.

“Done in a Day” is an unclassifiable book. It is not quite a memoir, not quite a biography. Elisa Tamarkin was four years old when Saigon fell. She and her mother were there, but only for a couple of weeks. (In April, they had been shipped off to Hong Kong.) So the author has no stories of the evacuation to tell us. And Bob Tamarkin—who died when Elisa, now an English professor, was in graduate school—is a rather remote figure in the book.

It’s hard to know whether this was advertent or inadvertent. But, whatever her feelings for him as a parent, Elisa clearly devoted herself to excavating this episode in Bob’s life. He proved an elusive subject. When, in her research, she finally comes across a partial image of him—just the back of his head, really—in a photograph of the crowd trying to get over the Embassy wall, it is as though he has been brought back, fleetingly, to life. Maybe the correct genre for “Done in a Day” is elegy. Tamarkin’s book is a kind of time capsule of the late sixties and early seventies. A lot makes its way into her pages, from Frank Kermode’s “The Sense of an Ending” to Thomas Harris’s self-help best-seller “I’m OK—You’re OK.”

But it eventually emerges that Tamarkin’s main topic is not Vietnam. It’s the press—more specifically, the newspaper business. For the end of the war was also, it turns out, the beginning of the end of the American daily, and, in the book, she casts Bob in the role of the last hardboiled foreign correspondent, a guy in a trenchcoat who never uses the first person. The *Chicago Daily News* had been one of the first to assign correspondents to permanent posts abroad in peacetime, back in 1898. It closed its foreign service in 1976, a year after Bob was helicoptered out of Saigon. The paper folded in 1978.

Tamarkin’s title, “Done in a Day,” refers, of course, to the fall of Saigon. But “Done in a Day” was also the newsroom motto at the *Chicago Daily News*. The phrase was meant to capture the special ethos of daily

journalism. Each issue has to be written in a day (no old news) and to represent a day, the day just past. And then it had to be done all over again tomorrow.

There is a bit of romanticizing here, but it's a personal story; she's entitled. The world of the daily reporter is lovingly close-read (which is what English professors do), from the telex machine that was standard technology for getting copy from the field to the editor's desk, to the use of "-30-" to mark the end of copy and the idea that an article in a daily paper should be literature, written, she says, "like steel" (which is not the way English professors write).

The newspaper theme works with the Vietnam theme because Vietnam was possibly the most covered war in history. At its height, there were nearly seven hundred credentialed journalists in Vietnam. Thirty-three were killed there. And the press was given virtually unlimited access (a big mistake, as American officials realized, and one that has not been repeated). Reporters were allowed to ride on military transports, to eat and sleep with the troops, to tag along on search-and-destroy missions (Michael Herr's 1977 book "Dispatches" is a harrowing description of what that was like), and to photograph everything (pictures by the French photojournalist Catherine Leroy, recently collected as "One-Way Ticket to Vietnam, 1966-1968," show how close photographers came to the action).



"Did you procrastinate at work by reading the menu and deciding what to order, or do you need a few more minutes?"

Cartoon by Julia Thomas

Television was then the most powerful journalistic medium. Something like thirty million people watched the “CBS Evening News with Walter Cronkite,” every night. Tamarkin cites *The New Yorker*’s television critic Michael Arlen’s term “the living-room war.” The phrase, which Arlen first used in 1966, is taken to mean that Vietnam was a war people experienced nightly on TV. Arlen did mean that, but, as Tamarkin says, he meant more. He meant that the war was the air Americans breathed after 1965, that Vietnam was everywhere. “Vietnam wasn’t the only thing that mattered in American life in those years,” Arlen wrote, “but operatively it mattered most; as long as it was on, it mattered most.”

But why was that? It is a little mysterious how quickly the war became the defining issue in American politics. It was as though everyone was waiting for this shoe to drop. Within three days of the Da Nang landing in 1965, a group of professors at the University of Michigan met to discuss a response. They called for a work moratorium (i.e., a strike, as such campus demonstrations would later more frankly be called), and a meeting was organized for March 24th. Three thousand students showed up. The teach-in began at 8 P.M. and continued all night, though it was interrupted by bomb threats.

Two days later, there was a teach-in at Columbia University. On April 17th, barely a month after the marines landed, twenty thousand people marched against the war in Washington, D.C., in a demonstration organized by Students for a Democratic Society. On May 21st, an antiwar teach-in at the University of California, Berkeley, attracted thirty-thousand people and lasted thirty-six hours. And for four years, the temperature kept rising. Everyone seemed to know from the start that Vietnam was bound to happen and that it would not go well.

Yet between 1950 and 1953, 38,574 Americans had died in Korea, a much higher casualty rate than in Vietnam. That war was not popular, but there were no major “U.S. Out of Korea” demonstrations. Comparatively speaking, sending a few marines to Da Nang was just a spark. Still, it started a conflagration that took years to extinguish and that fractured the American left.

If we wanted to indulge in what historians call “retrospective determinism,” it is easy enough to line up the dots that lead to the last helicopter. On January 27, 1973, the United States and the governments of North and South Vietnam signed the Paris Peace Accords, negotiated by Kissinger, in his capacity as Nixon’s national-security adviser, and the North Vietnamese diplomat Le Duc Tho. Though Kissinger and Tho received the Nobel Peace Prize later that year, Kissinger knew that the accord meant the end of South Vietnam. He did not think that the North would just quit. He was bargaining for what he deemed “a decent interval” between the withdrawal of American troops and the collapse of the South. That way, the United States could abandon the war without losing it.

A key provision of the accords was an agreement for the United States to withdraw its troops in exchange for the release of close to six hundred American P.O.W.s in the North, held in places like the notorious “Hanoi Hilton.” (South Vietnam held thirty thousand P.O.W.s, who were also released. These received less attention.) One of the oldest American P.O.W.s in Hanoi had been shot down in August, 1964, and was incarcerated for eight and a half years. By 1973, the American public had ceased to care about the fate of South Vietnam. But they cared about the P.O.W.s. It was the era of “Tie a Yellow Ribbon.” In terms of domestic politics, whatever deal the American government cut, it had to get the P.O.W.s back. (Later on, the emotional issue was the M.I.A.s.)

The most important parts of the accords, though, were not in the accords. They were in private letters, drafted by Kissinger, that Nixon sent to Nguyen Van Thieu to persuade him to sign the treaty. In the letters, Nixon conveyed “my absolute assurance that if Hanoi refuses to abide by the terms of the agreement it is my intention to take swift and retaliatory action.” The United States, he said, “will respond with full force should the settlement be violated by North Vietnam.” Thieu would not have signed the treaty without that assurance. He is supposed to have said of Nixon, “He is an honest man. I am going to trust him.” Famous last words.

The ceasefire was broken by both sides almost immediately, but in minor ways. The North Vietnamese surely knew of Nixon’s secret promise (they had double agents everywhere), and although they had weathered years of

bombardment—the United States dropped more than three times as many tons of bombs than the Allies dropped during the entire Second World War—they did fear the B-52s. They were careful not to push too hard. They also needed time to rebuild their forces.

The initial attack of the 1975 offensive was therefore a test. The North took the provincial capital of Buôn Ma Thuột, and then they crossed their fingers and waited. Nothing happened. The Americans did not send the Marines. They did not launch a bomber. The United States was saying, “You guys are Thieu’s problem now,” and the North got the message. They knew that Saigon would not be defended by American ground forces or air power, and that it was ripe for the taking. A campaign they had expected would last two years was over in two months.

As the North bore down on Saigon, Thieu begged for American financial support, but Congress was in no mood to pour more millions into the black hole of Southeast Asia. In a speech at Tulane University, on April 23rd, President Ford announced that the Vietnam War “is finished as far as America is concerned.” The line received a standing ovation. Thieu heard him. On April 26th, Thieu, having stepped down as President, fled to Taiwan.

By April 30th, the South Vietnamese had nothing left. When their new President, Duong Van Minh, offered a transfer of power, the North Vietnamese just laughed at him. “All power has passed into the hands of the revolution,” one of them told him. “You cannot hand over what you don’t have.”

The North Vietnamese had done nothing to interfere with Operation Frequent Wind. Their goal was to get all Americans out of Vietnam, and they were pleased to see the Americans deporting themselves. Afterward, there was no bloodbath. There were executions, mostly of the revenge variety, and not ordered by the politburo in Hanoi. Yet the North Vietnamese were not the ideological comrades of American college students and Jane Fonda. They were genuine totalitarians. Perhaps a million South Vietnamese were arrested, and many of them were sent to concentration camps for “reëducation.” Their families were told that they would be gone for a few days, but some remained there for as many as seventeen years.

Meanwhile, between 1975 and 1995, more than three million people from Indochina continued to flee, this time without American assistance, and many on boats launched into the South China Sea. At least two hundred thousand Vietnamese are estimated to have died on the water.

What was the United States fighting for in Vietnam? “Humiliation” is a word that recurs continually in memorandums circulated in the Administration when the decision was being made to send the marines, back in 1965. In March, shortly after the Da Nang landing, an Assistant Secretary of Defense, John McNaughton, wrote a memo assigning relative weights to American objectives in Vietnam. In his view, the principal aim was “to avoid a humiliating U.S. defeat.” He assigned this a weight of seventy per cent. Second, at twenty per cent, was to keep Southeast Asia out of Chinese hands. And the third, at ten per cent, was to permit the people of South Vietnam to enjoy a better, freer way of life.

Another State Department official, George Ball, told Lyndon B. Johnson in late June, “Once we suffer large casualties, we will have started a well-nigh irreversible process. Our involvement will be so great that we cannot—without national humiliation—stop short of achieving our complete objectives. Of the two possibilities, I think humiliation would be more likely than the achievement of our objectives—even after we had paid terrible costs.”

From the beginning, in other words, a paramount American interest in Vietnam was “face.” The important thing was not to lose. “I knew from the start that I was bound to be crucified either way I moved,” Johnson told Doris Kearns Goodwin. “If I left the woman I really loved—the Great Society—in order to get involved with that bitch of a war on the other side of the world, then I would lose everything at home. . . . If I left that war and let the communists take over South Vietnam, then I would be seen as a coward and my nation would be seen as an appeaser and we would both find it impossible to accomplish anything for anybody anywhere on the entire globe.”

Johnson had to do it to show that he could do it. Much like Vietnam, only a lot faster, the American war in Iran has reduced itself to saving face. Within

two weeks, the United States was trying to figure out how to end the war without losing it. Meanwhile, people were being killed. ♦

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The Violence in Vermeer

It is easy to treat the Dutch artist as an agreeable intimist—a transcriber of domestic niceties. But he grew up in a world of war, starvation, and massacres. His paintings were safe havens.

By [Anthony Lane](#)

April 13, 2026



“Woman Writing a Letter with Her Maid,” circa 1670. One thing that sets Vermeer apart from his contemporaries is a sense that the stillness in his quiet rooms may not hold. Art work by Johannes Vermeer / Courtesy National Gallery of Ireland

In October, 2022, a man approached Vermeer’s “Girl with a Pearl Earring” in the Mauritshuis museum, in The Hague, and rested his shaved head against the painting. He was not an eager art historian who believed that the work demanded the closest possible inspection and hoped to meet the subject eyeball to eyeball. (A not unreasonable plan: the speck of reflected

light in each of the girl's irises is a famous touch.) He was a climate protester, wearing a T-shirt that bore the slogan "Just Stop Oil," and he was seeking to glue himself to the glass that shields the canvas from assault. A sidekick, similarly clad, then doused him with a canful of Campbell's tomato soup, thus lending the stunt a mild but confusing flavor of Andy Warhol. The two men were barked at by angry visitors, removed by museum staff, and later charged with "violence against property." The painting was undamaged. The planet continued on its fateful course. As for the girl with the earring, nothing changed. It was as though she had seen it all before.

Of the many ways in which people have tackled "Girl with a Pearl Earring," the adhesive method used that day is merely one. Others include the spectrometric, the iconographic, the gemological, and the horny. In 2018, eight microscopic paint samples taken from the work were examined for varieties in isotopic composition; you will be relieved to learn that "the data were consistent with seventeenth-century Dutch lead white." Another study, in 2020, revealed that there was no perceptible hook attaching the earring to the girl's ear; only in our mind's credulous eye do we see an earring at all. Oh, and one small thing: the pearl is not a pearl. According to the catalogue of a comprehensive Vermeer exhibition, at the Rijksmuseum, in Amsterdam, in 2023, it is "probable that in Vermeer's work we are looking at imitation glass pearls, which in his time were mainly sold by Venetian glassblowers."

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As for the pearl, so for the girl. She, too, is hard to catch. In a 2001 book on Vermeer, Anthony Bailey, a former staff writer for this magazine, tries to pin her down. "One wonders if the model's name was Margriet, since that is

the Dutch form of the Latin *margarita*, meaning ‘pearl,’ ” he writes. An alternative theory is that Vermeer employed one of his daughters, Maria, as the model. And don’t ignore Griet, the servant who sits for Vermeer in Tracy Chevalier’s novel “Girl with a Pearl Earring” (1999). With her firm grasp of pictorial structure, Griet has no doubt that the painting needs the earring—“Without it there were only my eyes, my mouth, the band of my chemise.” As the artist unleashes his lead isotopes, the excitement mounts:

“Lick your lips, Griet.”

I licked my lips.

“Leave your mouth open.”

I was so surprised by this request that my mouth remained open of its own will. I blinked back tears. Virtuous women did not open their mouths in paintings.

As yet, archival research has failed to substantiate this conversation, although it appears, more or less intact, in the 2003 movie version of Chevalier’s book, with Colin Firth, as a well-wigged Vermeer, issuing instructions to Scarlett Johansson, as Griet. Meanwhile, we have a fresh contender for the role of the girl in the painting. In a new book, “Vermeer: A Life Lost and Found” (Norton), Andrew Graham-Dixon identifies her as Magdalena van Ruijven, the daughter of Vermeer’s most significant patrons, and offers a reason for her parted lips: “Not only does the girl seem on the point of utterance, she has the air of someone about to say the most urgent thing they have ever said.”

The someone, we are told, is another Magdalena—Mary Magdalene, who, in the darkness of early morning, goes to Christ’s tomb and finds it empty. She sees Jesus but believes him to be the gardener. (Is there a more wonderful example of mistaken identity—revelation delayed by human error?) In the words of St. John’s Gospel, “She turned herself, and saith unto him, Rabboni; which is to say, Master.” Virtuous women, it would seem, *do* open their mouths in paintings. That momentous turning, according to Graham-Dixon, is what we observe in Vermeer’s picture. As the girl looks over her shoulder, we are standing where Christ stood. And what of the pearl? “It is no simple jewel,” Graham-Dixon writes, “but a

reflection of the state of her soul, bursting with joy and irradiated with divine light.” Try sticking your head to that.

How, why, and by what right does a person produce tranquil art in the midst, or the wake, of tumultuous times? Well, it helps if you hail from flat, contested northern lands. Think of Watteau, born on the join between present-day France and Belgium, in 1684, six years after the end of the Franco-Dutch War. Twenty-seven miles south lies the town where Matisse grew up and which German soldiers invaded when he was a year and a day old, at the dawn of 1871. (At the far end of his life, the *éclat* of his cutouts was conjured under Nazi occupation. His daughter, Marguerite, was tortured by the Gestapo.) Matisse’s father began in the textile trade, as did Reynier Jansz Vermeer, who was living in Amsterdam and engaged in the manufacture of *caffa*, a costly woven fabric, when he met a woman named Digna Baltens. They married in 1615, and it was not until 1632 that their son, Johannes, was born. As befits such an environment, his handling of tactile stuff—not just silk and fur but bread and brickwork, too—never deserted him. The raised ridges of a map, unrolled and hung on a wall, asked to be registered in paint.



“I’m a little nervous—it’s my first one, and my first time seeing this weird glass baby prison.”
Cartoon by Joe Dator

There are areas in the life of Vermeer, who died in his forties, in 1675, that have never been mapped. In all likelihood, they never will be. Given how acutely some of his work refers to Italian artists of the previous generation,

for instance, it's not inconceivable that he went to Italy; regardless, no record of the visit exists. To the millions of people who recognize "Girl with a Pearl Earring" or "The Lacemaker," Vermeer is little more than a name and a place: Delft, where his life began and ended, and where he is buried in the Oude Kerk, or old church. (A sign in the church declares that the coffin of one of his children was laid on top of his.) Beyond the bounds of Delft, the living Vermeer was largely uncelebrated. His reputation, such as it was, went into eclipse, until he was reclaimed and illuminated by French critics in the latter half of the nineteenth century.

An earlier book by Graham-Dixon—his vigorous biography of Caravaggio, from 2010—was alert to the brunt of pestilence and the ardors of the Counter-Reformation, and "Vermeer: A Life Lost and Found," likewise, deals with a deeper background. Thanks to the religious hostilities that burst open in the late sixteenth century, the prevailing hue is blood. Among the atrocities committed by Catholic Spanish-led forces in the Low Countries, bent on the suppression of local rebels, was the 1576 Sack of Antwerp by mutinous Spanish troops. In Graham-Dixon's account, they "descended on the city like wolves." As many as eight thousand citizens were massacred. One of the children who somehow survived the slaughter grew up to be the maternal grandfather of Vermeer.

The reader who pauses for breath, after this recitation of horrors, is soon rewarded by being plunged into a yet more catastrophic mire. The Thirty Years' War, which was concluded by the Peace of Westphalia, in 1648, spread across mainland Europe and killed some eight million people. Aware that its battlefields have been exhaustively tilled by historians, Graham-Dixon prefers, wisely, to snag our attention on a few details that we would rather forget. "People were so crazed by hunger that they tore the bodies of dead criminals from gallows and gibbet," he writes. Vermeer, in short, grew up in a world where the living consumed the departed. One German mother, we are told, ate her own son.

What does all this have to do, pray, with a woman pouring milk from a jug, or reading a letter, or patiently making lace—the kind of activity, that is, pursued in Vermeer's art? One answer would be that the more savage the storm, the more urgent the need for safe havens. If you wanted to live in

peace, however frail; to worship as you wished, however furtively; to prosper in business and to educate your children; to walk the streets without dread and to die a natural death, uneaten; if that was your desire, in the guts of the seventeenth century, then Holland was the best, maybe the only, place to be. There was even a transport network, via *trekschuiten*, horse-drawn barges that travelled along the canals; an appendix to “Vermeer: A Life Lost and Found” lists a timetable, showing that the daytime service from Delft to The Hague ran every half hour. Given what the rest of Europe endured, such benign civic efficiency verges on the comic. Indoors, reportedly, one came across a corresponding ease, to the surprise of outsiders. An English visitor of the period is cited by Graham-Dixon:

It’s very ordinary to find the Man of the House of one Opinion, his Wife of another, his Children of a third, and his Servants of one different from them all; and yet they live without the least Jangling or Dissension.

Compare this with the United States of 2026, where you can’t hear yourself think for the jangle. There is a trap, though. All too readily, we can slide into treating Vermeer as an agreeable intimist—a transcriber of the smooth-running niceties of the domestic. Hence the merchandise that I found, recently, in a gift shop on the Voldersgracht, in central Delft, where Vermeer once lived: placemats, cookie tins, tote bags, and chocolate bars adorned with images from his art. Many major painters get the same treatment these days, but Vermeer has more than most to lose from the indignity, because of the mysterious tensions in his work that are not there for the selling. One thing that sets him apart from a contemporary such as Pieter de Hooch, to whom he is instinctively likened, is a murmur that the stillness may not hold. Something in these quiet rooms is getting ready to happen. The letter, held in a lady’s hand, might bring transforming news. The paradox is well captured by Lawrence Gowing, in an elegant monograph on Vermeer, from 1952:

The common characteristics of all the painter’s work, the remarkable order which he extracts from the world, his elaborate evasion of its human claims, suggest the imminent possibility of opposite qualities, a fearsome anarchy.

At the start of “Vermeer: A Life Lost and Found,” Graham-Dixon pays tribute to Gowing, but he ventures along very different paths. Where Gowing concentrates on what he calls the “unremitting internal pressure” of Vermeer’s compositions, Graham-Dixon gauges the pressures from outside. His contention is that the people who inhabit the paintings are breathing a specific spiritual atmosphere, bred by the company that Vermeer kept. The parents of Magdalena, say, nominated by Graham-Dixon as the “one plausible candidate” for the girl with the earring, were Maria de Knuijt and Pieter Claesz van Ruijven. A wealthy couple, they owned around twenty pictures by Vermeer, the majority of his known output, keeping them in their house in Delft and finally bequeathing them to Magdalena. They are listed in an inventory of possessions that was compiled after she died, in 1682.



“The Concert,” circa 1663-1666. Art work by Johannes Vermeer / Courtesy Isabella Stewart Gardner Museum

Pieter van Ruijven was a Remonstrant—that is, he belonged to a radical Protestant movement whose roots lay in the teachings of Jacobus Arminius (1560-1609). Most of Arminius’s family had been murdered by Spanish soldiers. Schooled in Calvinism, he had moved away from the severity of its doctrines, notably that of a predestined elect, toward a more tolerant

(and, among the Dutch, grudgingly tolerated) faith. Remonstrants mustered, semi-secretly, in private houses, or *schuilkerken*, hidden churches. One such meeting place was the home of van Ruijven and his wife: such, at any rate, is the thesis propounded by Graham-Dixon. He sets the imagined scene:

At the gatherings held in the house by the hidden Remonstrant church in Delft there would be more than words and music to stir the souls of the faithful. There would be paintings.

This becomes the wellspring of the book. From it flows a new interpretation of most, though not all, of Vermeer's work. At the Met, for instance, "A Maid Asleep" (or, "A drunken sleeping maid at a table," as it was described when sold at auction, in 1696) shows not a young hedonist who has been overdoing the booze, as might be inferred from the glass in front of her, but someone who has just unveiled her heart to God. Her ghost of a smile should be parsed as beatific rapture. As for the glass, the affinity is with communion wine. In the same vein, if you are struck by Vermeer's "Woman Holding a Balance," in the National Gallery in Washington, D.C., and by the curious fact that the balance is empty, Graham-Dixon can explain. Indicating the jewels on the table in front of her, he says that she has undone them and laid them down, the better to renounce her worldly possessions for higher treasures: "She has put her conscience in the scales, and found it so light as to be weightless. She has done no evil, bears no burden of sin."

It's hard to predict how readers of the book will respond to these readings of the art. They are delivered with a confident brio, though the author is careful to enter caveats. Of "Woman Holding a Balance," he says, "Such an image might have spoken clearly and directly to pious women gathered in Maria de Knuijt's house, giving a shape and a direction to their prayers, also perhaps acting as a catalyst for their discussions or free prophecies." Fair enough, though what I want to ask is, How would that catalysis function in practice? Did somebody guide the assembled worshippers through the import of each painting, like a teacher with a chalkboard? Or was everyone present sufficiently schooled in Vermeer's symbolic array? It was, after all, a somewhat private mythology, more so than its Italian Renaissance counterparts. When Botticelli or Fra Angelico painted the infant Jesus

holding a pomegranate, they could rely on viewers who understood that the blood-red fruit denoted the Resurrection. Who in Delft, however, outside the Remonstrant clan, would know that your soul could be measured like a gold coin, or, for that matter, hung from your ear?

Parts of the Vermeer industry, I suspect, will bridle at the determined speculation that lends such energy to “Vermeer: A Life Lost and Found.” In an essay published in 2001, “Religion in the Art and Life of Vermeer,” Valerie Hedquist devotes no more than a few brief lines to the Remonstrant cause. A greater emphasis, instead, is laid on the painter’s marriage to Catharina Bolnes, in April, 1653. Bolnes was a Catholic, as was her rich and frankly terrifying mother, Maria Thins, with whom the young couple lodged. (If anyone ever compiles a list titled “Sitcoms of the Dutch Golden Age,” that setup would be the winner.) Hedquist comments, “Without documentation confirming Vermeer’s individual acceptance of Roman Catholicism, it is difficult to state definitively that he converted. Nevertheless, his marriage and eventual living situation firmly place him in the Roman Catholic center of Delft.” So, where did Vermeer belong, or take refuge: in the hidden church or the family home? No wonder the pictures are so coded and discreet. They might have been painted by a spy.

Getting into the Vermeer show at the Rijksmuseum, in 2023, was tough. Having failed to secure a ticket, I was taunted with pitying one-upmanship by acquaintances who had had more success. “You should have applied to be a friend of the museum *beforehand*,” they said, as if the chance to peer at twenty-eight Vermeers, through a swarm of rival fans, were akin to attending the hottest Broadway play. To see the paintings was, in a way, less important than the social exultation of having seen them. Hit exhibitions are seldom an unalloyed delight, and Vermeer, in particular, does not take kindly to being mobbed. He survived more than a hundred and fifty years of restful obscurity, and sometimes one can’t help wishing, for his sake, that he could dwindle back into the gloom.

A better way to study Vermeer is the Barney technique. It goes like this:

“What do you *want*, Barney?”

“I want to see every Vermeer in the world before I die.”

“Do I need to ask who got you started on Vermeer?”

“We talked about a lot of things in the middle of the night.”

Barney is the orderly who guarded Hannibal Lecter in Thomas Harris’s “The Silence of the Lambs.” This exchange comes from the sequel, “Hannibal,” and Barney’s interlocutor is Clarice Starling. Lecter is now at liberty. His taste in art was always less eccentric than his taste in flesh, and Barney has been well advised. To arrive at a lone Vermeer at the end of a patient pilgrimage is to invest the work with the meditated gravity that it deserves.

Not that the itinerary is too arduous. The Eastern Seaboard is especially fertile, though the thieves who relieved the Isabella Stewart Gardner Museum of its entrancing Vermeer, “The Concert,” in 1990, saved you a trip to Boston. Flee to Europe for a still richer harvest—first to London and Edinburgh, and thence to Dublin for “Woman Writing a Letter, with her Maid,” which has itself been stolen, twice, once for the I.R.A. and once by a local gangster. In spite of that thrilling history, the painting leaves Graham-Dixon unmoved. The light of it is “hard as stone,” he says, and he’s not wrong; yet I confess to being arrested, so to speak. The folded arms of the servant, who stares away from her mistress and out of the casement, tell a tale of long-suffering attendance, and, as so often in Vermeer-watching, you find yourself tempted to dig up a concealed plot.



“Woman Holding a Balance,” circa 1664. Art work by Johannes Vermeer / Courtesy National Gallery of Art, Washington, Widener Collection

From here, the Barney tour becomes a homing in. Berlin, Braunschweig, and Frankfurt. Dresden’s Gemäldegalerie, for “Girl Reading a Letter at an Open Window” and the spectral mirroring of her features in the glass. (The whole museum, I’d say, need detain you no longer than a lifetime.) Paris for “The Lacemaker,” if you don’t mind camping out in the line for the Louvre, plus Vienna for “The Art of Painting,” if you can scrub from your brain the fact that it was once owned by Adolf Hitler. “Cool colour is not a visual preference,” the art historian Kenneth Clark remarked of this crowning masterwork, “but expresses a complete attitude of mind.” He also compared the seated figure of the painter—framed from behind, and maybe intended as a self-portrait—to a giant cockroach. So, *that’s* what Vermeer was like.

In the end, you come to the Netherlands, and to the hints of Vermeer that litter the cityscape, clueing you in before you reach the pictures. Shutters decorated with two black triangles? View them in Delft, on a dwelling on the Voldersgracht, and then, again, in Vermeer’s “View of Delft,” in The Hague. The journey from one town to the other took me twelve minutes by train, though the slower pace of a *trekschuit*, three hundred and fifty years ago, would have been more suitable, and I kept looking out for a horse. As

for the Mauritshuis, it provides further proof, if any were needed, that to greet a painting in reproduction is to see it through a glass, darkly. See it face to face, wherever you can, and in proximity to the faces of other works; wittily positioned beside “Girl with a Pearl Earring,” for example, is another girl with a pearl earring, depicted in profile by Gerard ter Borch. (Do the two girls whisper to each other, after hours?) Then, there’s a dramatic landscape by Jacob van Ruisdael, with gray clouds muttering on high and brighter blues impending in the sky below. Two stretches of yellow-brown wall have caught the sun.

For the same details, walk into a nearby room and consult “View of Delft,” which was painted a few years earlier. The main difference is that Ruisdael cranes upward, to behold a castle on a hill, whereas Vermeer levels his gaze across open water. For all the splendor of Ruisdael’s picture, it is the second that partakes—in ways that countless gallerygoers have keenly felt but struggled to articulate—of the miraculous. My favorite sentence in Graham-Dixon’s book has him probing the nitty-gritty of Vermeer’s roofs: “It is possible that he ground actual red terracotta tiles in with his pigments and oil to get the required result.” So compelling are these critical closeups that I found myself leaning in to investigate the surface of a yellow roof on the right, and found it stippled and dotted, as if it bore a message in Braille. I was warned away by a guard, despite the fact that my shirt was not blazoned with “Just Stop Oil.” Breaking news: oils can just stop you in your tracks.

Needless to say, I am not the only person to glory in that luminescent patch. As Proustians and Vermeer junkies alike will rush to remind you, it’s one of the last things witnessed by Bergotte, a fictional writer, in “Remembrance of Things Past.” (Before expiring, he blames his swoon on undercooked potatoes.) What tends to be overlooked, in the aesthetic shock, is Proust’s elaborate hymn to its moral and spiritual implications. Brace yourself:

There is no reason inherent in the conditions of life on this earth that can make us consider ourselves obliged to do good, to be kind and thoughtful, even to be polite, nor for an atheist artist to consider himself obliged to begin over again a score of times a piece of work the admiration aroused by which will matter little to his worm-eaten

body, like the patch of yellow wall painted with so much skill and refinement by an artist destined to be forever unknown and barely identified under the name Vermeer. All these obligations, which have no sanction in our present life, seem to belong to a different world, a world based on kindness, scrupulousness, self-sacrifice, a world entirely different from this one and which we leave in order to be born on this earth.

That draws near, I think, to the territory laid out by Graham-Dixon. He regards the radiance in “View of Delft” both as that of a familiar, peaceable town, glittering after the rains and tempests of a brutal epoch, and as a vision of the heavenly city, as vouchsafed in the Book of Revelation. To look at the painting, he writes, is to sense “a rainbow at our backs.”

Amen to that—and, indeed, to the arguments that are sustained throughout “Vermeer: A Life Lost and Found.” You may disagree with them, fiercely so, but they could not be more persuasively put, and they rescue Vermeer from the shelf, as it were, on which we have placed him for our convenience. Far from being “forever unknown,” in Proust’s phrase, he is now in danger, like his countryman van Gogh, of being blurred and dulled by global fame. Graham-Dixon’s task, as it was in his biography of Caravaggio, is to resacralize an art that the current age consigns to the realms of the secular. In opting for Caravaggio the sexually roistering bad boy and Vermeer the charming celebrant of the mundane, we discard the imprint of faith. Graham-Dixon presses its claim afresh, and, in the process, discovers it everywhere. The light that falls from the left, through half-open windows, onto Vermeer’s walls, some of them bare, testifies not so much to an overcast Dutch day as to a suffusion of grace. Andrew Graham-Dixon may be on a mission, but so, he believes, was Vermeer. “He painted for the same reason that people pray: to make things come true.” ♦

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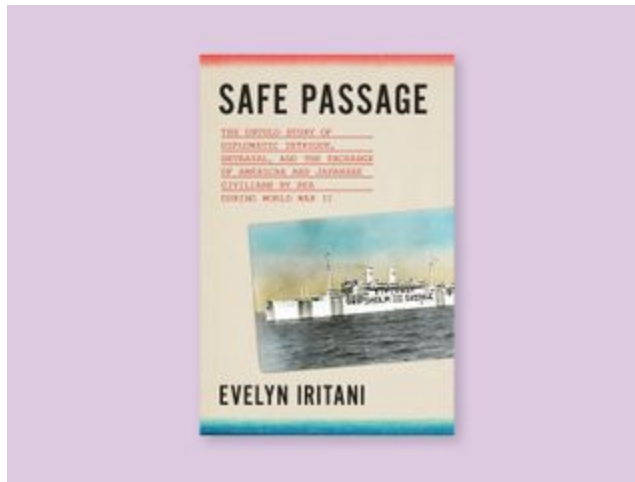
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[Books](#)

Briefly Noted

“Safe Passage,” “Cave Mountain,” “See You on the Other Side,” and “Almost Life.”

April 13, 2026



Safe Passage, by Evelyn Iritani (Farrar, Straus & Giroux). This engaging history focusses on civilian exchanges between the U.S. and Japan during the Second World War, which were arranged in large part to rescue citizens from enemy territory. Iritani, a journalist, follows a handful of individuals who were traded. Among them are the *New Yorker* writer Emily Hahn, who was living in Hong Kong under Japanese occupation, and Donald Hasuike, a fourteen-year-old Japanese American who was interned at a camp in Colorado with family before being shipped to Japan against his will. Iritani highlights both unconstitutional aspects of the U.S. government’s actions and the heroism of some of its diplomats.



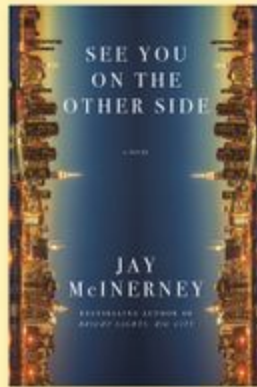
Cave Mountain, by *Benjamin Hale (Harper)*. In April, 2001, a little girl—Hale’s cousin—went missing while hiking with her grandparents through the Arkansas Ozarks forest. Hale’s account opens with the frantic search effort that led to her rescue, two days later. But that happy ending is marred by an eerie historical parallel: twenty-three years earlier, in the same month, in the same patch of wilderness, another young girl vanished. Her disappearance was later attributed to a millenarian cult. Hale traverses mountain trails, excavates court records, and reflects on his family’s roots in the region to examine the unexpected connections between the two events. The result is a stark portrait of religion in America and the dark turns that faith can cause people to take.

What We’re Reading

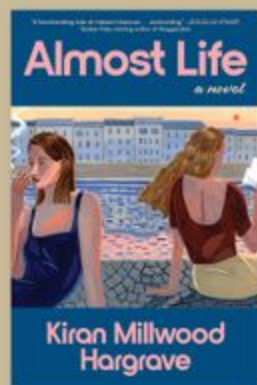


Illustration by Henri Campeã

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See You on the Other Side, by Jay McInerney (*Knopf*). This elegiac novel, the fourth in a sequence about the marriage of Russell and Corrine Calloway, takes place during the “tedious crisis” of the *COVID* pandemic. A successful publisher, Russell, now in his early sixties, has a dalliance with a gifted and flirtatious début novelist. Meanwhile, the couple’s daughter opens a restaurant, and their son volunteers for Bernie Sanders’s Presidential campaign. McInerney is a gently satirical chronicler of life among Manhattan’s élite (Russell belongs to a dining club where, one night, “corks were pulled on some forty thousand dollars’ worth of wine”), but the book’s prevailing mood is one of melancholy for “the loss of youthful ardor.”



Almost Life, by Kiran Millwood Hargrave (*Summit*). The core of this searching novel is a many-decades-long love between two women. Erica and Laure first encounter each other in Paris in the summer of 1978, when

they are reading the same book: Barthes's "A Lover's Discourse." Erica, who is visiting from England before starting university, quickly falls in love with Laure, a graduate student studying art theory. When the season ends, so, too, does their romance; the couple do not reunite until seven years later, when Laure is at loose ends and Erica is married to a rich man and planning to have children. They embark on an affair, and, as the novel tracks their longing through the years, it examines how, as Erica puts it, "lovers left impressions on each other, parts of themselves that would never be exorcised."

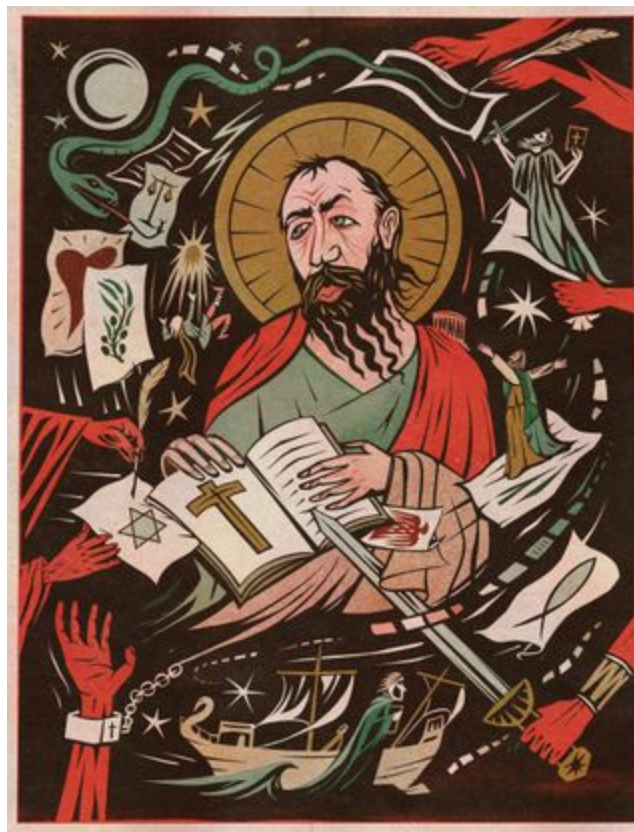
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New scholarship reconsiders the apostle who turned a Jewish sect into a world religion—and whose legacy remains contested two millennia later.

April 13, 2026



If Western civilization were asked, in the terms of the old *Reader's Digest* column, to name the Most Unforgettable Character It Ever Met, it would surely answer, with a single, sighing voice: Paul. Not Sir Paul the Beatle, blessed as he is in advanced age, but St. Paul the Apostle, who, in the first

century C.E., soon after the founding of the Jesus cult, brought to the Gentile world its salvationist doctrines shorn of the complex legalisms, dietary laws, and minutiae of devotion that marked the Judaism from which it sprang. In this way, Paul turned the heresy of a tiny sect of Messianic Jews into the dominant religious and cultural architecture of the West for the next couple of thousand years.

Christianity as we know it—the all-are-welcome Church, with fairly undemanding required rituals, no daily prostrations, no rules for separating cheese blintzes from corned beef, just confession, Communion, and prayer—owes more to Paul than to anyone else, perhaps even more than to the narrowly parochial and Jerusalem-centered Jesus. It was Paul, almost single-handed, and against the suspicions of Jesus' original disciples, who journeyed and pleaded and made the faith portable. Quite a character! So much so that, in the nineteen-fifties and sixties, the director Frank Capra was eager to make a movie of Paul's life starring Frank Sinatra. And though it sounds ridiculous when you say it, the casting actually makes sense. Whoever Paul was, he must have had charm, energy, and intensity, and been equally popular with the first-century equivalent of bobby-soxers and of made men. Raphael's great image of Paul preaching in Athens, arms outstretched, crowd rapt, could be the Chairman on tour in Greece.

Our strictly historical sources for Paul are thin. There are the Epistles, the letters Paul is believed to have written around the fifties C.E. to the small but burgeoning Christian assemblies of the Greek-speaking eastern Mediterranean. Of the thirteen letters attributed to him, only seven are generally regarded as authentic; the others are thought to be later forgeries written to make Paul endorse more conservative positions in death than he did in life. (In the genuine epistles, he shows a remarkable equanimity about women playing an active role in the new Church; the forged ones are openly misogynistic.) Then, there are the Acts of the Apostles, the New Testament account of the early years of Christian evangelism, generally thought to have been written by the author who is given the name Luke and who either accompanied Paul on his travels or heard about them afterward. The Epistles tell us what Paul said, the Acts some of what he might have done.

What We're Reading

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A detailed story of Paul's travels and mission, Acts is also generally agreed among scholars to be largely, if not entirely, fictionalized, containing an improbable number of shipwrecks and prison breaks and snakebites and other twists typical of Greek storytelling from the period. It also smooths away the conflicts that the Epistles put on the page. The polemical point of Acts was basically to placate the imperial power by showing that Romans are good, Jews are bad, and Christians, though practicing a mutated form of Judaism, are more like Romans than they are like Jews.

Just as important, the Epistles and the Acts date to different sides of the great divide in Jewish history: the "Jewish War" of the latter half of the first century, a quixotic and doomed revolt against Roman domination, which ended in 70 C.E. with the complete destruction of the Second Temple and the banishment of the Jews from Jerusalem—the greatest catastrophe in Jewish history until the Holocaust. As Jews now tend to forget, the Temple-based religion was very little like the disputatious, text-bound, and intellectual religion of rabbinic Judaism; more frankly pagan in feeling, it essentially pivoted on regular rites of animal sacrifice conducted by a set priestly caste.

Then, overnight, there were no more sacrifices, and the priest class had nothing to do. In the wake of this disaster—one that the Jewish general turned Roman historian Josephus blamed on a fanatic lack of common sense and realism among the Jewish rebels, of a kind well caricatured in Monty Python's "Life of Brian"—the choices for saving the old faith were varied. The orthodox response was the development of rabbinic Judaism, which we now think of simply as Judaism. The study of the Torah, and the elaborate argumentative commentaries of the Mishnah and the Talmud,

became the core of the religion, refereed by learned rabbis rather than supervisory priests. Another response was to drive forward the sectarian religion of the Jesus cult, and that's where the Pauline initiative took over.

If Paul's life can be reduced, from these polemical sources, to a set of more or less undisputed facts, it would be this: he was born, as Saul, in Tarsus, in what's now southern Turkey, sometime around the year zero, and came of age as a Greek-speaking Jew in the Diaspora. He became aware of the Jesus cult very shortly after its emergence, in the thirties C.E., and at first, by his own account, he "persecuted" the new faith—though, given how small the cult still must have been and how few public powers were available to Jews to enforce their prejudices, this was more likely persecution by argument than by torture. Then, sometime in the same decade, he had the most famous conversion experience in history, falling off his horse while trotting toward Damascus and seeing a celestial vision of the risen Jesus.

The epiphany took. For the next thirty or so years, Paul ceaselessly rode out on Christian missions, founding churches and corresponding with and correcting the movement's scattered small ones. (These churches tended to be little more than living-room gatherings of at most sixty or so people, usually from the same household, with a land-owning family, its servants, and enslaved people together.) He had decisive meetings in Jerusalem with the man he called Cephas and whom we call Peter—the two names, Aramaic and Greek, respectively, just meaning "rock." He also met a man named James, who is presented as Jesus' brother. After mutual suspicion, the two arrived at a reluctant truce in which Paul was free to bring non-Jews into the Jesus movement, emancipating them from Jewish ritual, while the original Jerusalem circle continued to keep kosher, circumcise, and all the rest. Acts has Paul then being arrested and, because he was a Roman citizen, transported to Rome for a trial, which is where the story abruptly ends. Later legend has him executed by the very Romans he worked so hard to placate; other accounts seem to locate his end in Spain.

The most remarkable thing that emerges from these texts is what you might call Paul's emotional availability. He instructs, cajoles, gives shrewd advice—"be all things to all people" is his positive counsel on how to build coalitions—and sometimes engages in what certainly sounds like the hyper-

cynical placation of opposing poles: cagily paying off that rival Jerusalem sect, warning against heretical influences, begging his far-off correspondents to avoid “splitting,” praising competitive apostles, and taking exasperated digs at obscure obstacles to his work, oddly personal in tone for one so inspired by the Lord. “Alexander the coppersmith,” he sighs at one point, “did me great harm.” Then Alexander and his copper disappear from the record.

Paul agonizes, too. In his epistle to the Christian community in Rome, his insistence on grace collides with an undiminished loyalty to his own people (he can’t accept that God has abandoned Israel), and the passage feels pained and real. “Some of the branches have been broken off,” Paul writes to the Greek Christians, referring to Jews who reject Jesus and stand outside God’s grace, “and you, though a wild olive shoot, have been grafted in among the others and now share in the nourishing sap from the olive root. Do not consider yourself to be superior to those other branches! . . . You do not support the root, but the root supports you. . . . Do not be arrogant, but tremble.”

Paul’s tone in the Epistles, to use a comparison that will scandalize followers of either half of the analogy, is strikingly like Leon Trotsky’s in his autobiography. Trotsky (né Bronstein) was also a Jew who had both stopped being one and, necessarily, remained one, took a new name to lead an organization made up of Gentiles, and combined a pragmatic appetite for alliances with a hard ideological line. Both Trotsky and Paul get absorbed in quarrelsome dialectics and in point-scoring built around minute differences. Trotsky’s arguments about revolution in one nation versus a revolution of the international proletariat, like the fine argumentative tracery of Paul’s Jewish Christians versus Greek ones, seemed vital to the movement at the time but weirdly trivial and abstract to those outside it.

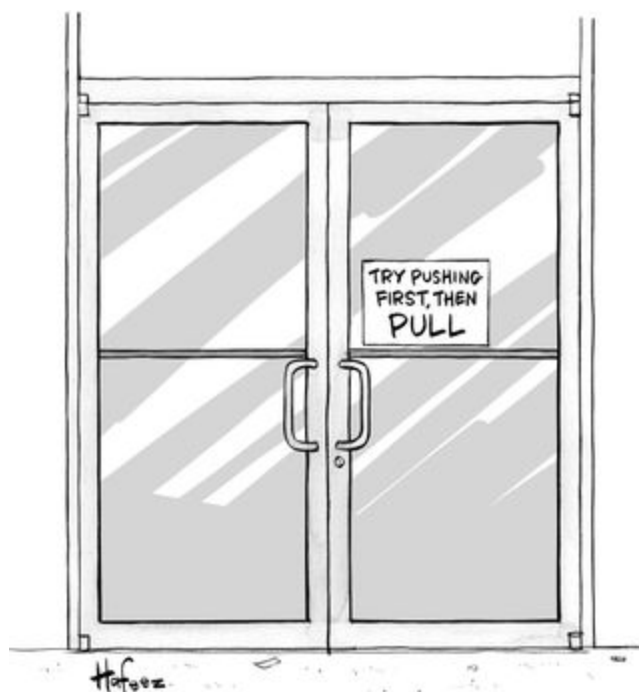
In the Epistle to the Galatians, Paul strains to show that the Gentile mission and the Jerusalem mission, though carried out by mutually mistrustful parties, belong to a single divine design. His mode of argumentation resembles nothing so much as Marxist dialectics, sinuously arguing from opposites and forcing a desired conclusion upon unobliging texts. He rereads God’s promise to Abraham as if it had always presaged the later

turn to “all nations,” boldly reinterpreting the Jewish patriarch’s “seed.” Although everyone had taken it to mean Israel, Paul writes instead, “The Scripture, foreseeing that God would justify the Gentiles by faith, preached the gospel to Abraham beforehand, saying, ‘In you all the nations shall be blessed.’ ” On that basis, he arrives at the bracing conclusion: “There is neither Jew nor Greek, there is neither slave nor free, and there is neither male nor female; for you are all one in Christ Jesus. If you are Christ’s, then you are Abraham’s seed, and heirs according to the promise.” The power of an orator who can, in this way, fuse feeling and doctrine is immense. (After hearing Trotsky speak in the nineteen-tens, my great-grandfather’s brothers were converted from Orthodox Judaism to a Jewish-inflected Bolshevism.) Trotsky himself had seen that the pragmatist follower who lacks true belief usually ends up on the other side; a passionate believer who lacks pragmatic planning skills usually ends up dead. In Paul’s time, Josephus was a perfect instance of the first kind, a brilliant military leader who, when faced with the fanaticism of his cohorts, chose to shift his allegiance to Rome. Foremost among the examples of the second kind was the rabbi Jesus.

Wherever he appears, Paul is not a saint in his cell but a messenger at work—a man of close shaves, sudden escapes, and high-stakes debates. His tales and truths have, for all their apocalyptic mysticism, a decidedly practical charge that makes them exceptional in the New Testament or almost any religious literature. It *would* be a good movie! You can almost see the toughened, sinewy Sinatra of the fifties as Paul, with Sammy Davis, Jr., as the suspicious James and Dean Martin as a slightly befuddled Peter.

There are, however, many lacunae in Paul’s writing and life that have puzzled readers. Why, across the tens of thousands of words of his epistles, does he never tell the story of the work and life of Jesus of Nazareth? There’s essentially no Mary, no Joseph, no Nativity (much less a virgin birth), no miracles, no mission, no overturned tables at the Temple, no Galilean ministry rendered through narrative. This silence has led a handful of scholars to insist that Paul knew no earthly Jesus at all. But it’s possible that Jesus was simply more important to Paul as a risen God than as an admirable man.

Just as we are lucky to have Mormonism as a near-at-hand experiment in how improbable religions rise and grow, we have the cult of the Brooklyn Lubavitcher Rebbe as a very near-at-hand reminder of how Jewish messianic cults come to life. And one of the lessons is that, although the Rebbe's personal history is widely known, it isn't part of his followers' messianic insistence. Ask an evangelical Lubavitcher whether he knows that the Rebbe studied for two years in Paris at the highly secular Sorbonne, and you'll often draw a blank look. Similarly, Malcolm X must have had some awareness of the actual life of Elijah Poole, but, when he was delivering the words of the Messenger, he didn't mention any of it, certainly not that he came from Georgia or had worked in Detroit factories or had been to prison. The Messenger and Elijah Poole were very different figures.



Cartoon by Kaamran Hafeez and Al Batt

Another puzzle relates to Paul's role, despite his Jewish training and identity, in early Christianity's open hatred of Jews. The older picture of Paul as the begetter of Christian antisemitism became, for obvious reasons, intolerable to many believing scholars after the Holocaust, and a counter-reading took shape that tried to return him to a sturdier Jewish setting. On this account, the Roman Paul gives way to a more strictly Jewish Paul; his outreach to Gentiles was meant to be expansive without being exclusionary, and the Jesus movement, even as it grew, still rested on the Torah.

The impulse is intelligible: to reassure post-Holocaust Christians that their faith does not, in fact, depend on the rejection of Jews that later Christian texts so plainly stage. You see the problem in the second-century Epistle of Barnabas, a post-Pauline codicil that treats circumcision not even as an obsolete rite but as a sort of mark of Cain. The old covenant is rewritten as a curse, with Jewish suffering cast as deserved punishment.

In more recent years, though, there has been a countermovement to restore Paul to a more credible Hellenistic context. Suddenly, we now have not the Roman Paul whom Acts depicts, nor the Jewish Paul, immersed in the prophetic traditions, whom his recent apologists conjure, but the Hellenistic Paul—Paul being a man who, after all, wrote in Greek and drew his imagery and instances from Greek myth and literature. The stakes of these disputes are high because of what they say about his inheritance. If Paul's creed is essentially Roman, then Christianity looks, from the outset, like a religion trained to live with empire, its compass always set toward placating power. If significantly Greek, then the question becomes how philosophical—and, more specifically, how Platonic—the religion is at its core, with doctrines that can seem mystical and otherworldly. If foundationally Jewish, or even anti-Jewish, then the question is: how much of the old faith remains in the bloodstream, and what did Paul think he was doing to it?

This new, revisionist view is well represented in a recent scholarly collection, "Paul Within Paganism: Restoring the Mediterranean Context to the Apostle" (Fortress), edited by Alexander Chantzianthou, Paula Fredriksen, and Stephen L. Young. The Paul of these pages, sketched by sixteen scholars, is close to his contemporary Philo of Alexandria. Like Philo, he joins the Platonism current in his day, with its layered cosmos and transcendent God, to a boldly reworked reading of Biblical prophecy, encountered in Greek translation rather than in Hebrew. Robyn Faith Walsh offers a beautiful poetic analysis of Paul's otherwise odd celestial obsessions, making the case that "Paul, like other Middle Platonists, saw the moon as a clearinghouse for souls awaiting a cosmic judgment." He belongs to a liminal space where occult Jewish faith documents and the poetic universe of Plutarch and Platonists coexist. Trying to appease two audiences at once, Jewish and Greek, he instinctively combined their preoccupations.

In an even more startling essay, with the unforgettable title “Paul Among Pagan Penises,” Ryan D. Collman argues that Paul’s fixation on the politics of circumcision has been distorted by a simple mistranslation. A Greek term that means “foreskinned” has routinely been rendered as “uncircumcised.” Paul, Collman stresses, wasn’t saying that the Gentiles lack something the Jews have. He was talking about two different kinds of possession: Gentiles have foreskins; Jews have the ritual that removes them. More startling still, Collman demonstrates that, since the glans of the uncircumcised penis is visible only when aroused, Greeks assumed Jewish penises to be in a state of permanent arousal, thus producing a standing Hellenistic joke that only a “penis from Jerusalem” could satisfy a lustful woman. The politics of penises in this period gave enticing credit to Jews as erotic masters—an idea that sat well with the larger allure of Jewish exoticism to Christian converts. Rather like Indian gurus in nineteen-sixties hippie culture, the Jews were assumed to be repositories of every kind of mystical and human elevation. Indeed, Walsh is sympathetic to an account of Pauline Christianity’s allure that emphasizes its “exemptive” ostentation: the peasant simplicity and extreme antiquity of the Jewish-Christian faith was perfectly designed to appeal to alienated Roman urbanites who, like those hippie guru followers, wanted a new faith that was old, exotic, and of rustic origins, with incense burning day and night.

This revisionist view of Paul has reached a climax with Nina E. Livesey’s recent book, “The Letters of Paul in Their Roman Literary Context” (Cambridge). Despite its dry title, the book argues, astonishingly, that Paul’s epistles, indeed “Paul” himself, are inventions of the second century—that they actually were written largely by the crucial yet easily overlooked figure of the heretical editor Marcion and then backdated. Livesey, a professor emerita at the University of Oklahoma, is recognized as a significant Pauline scholar, and her book is closely argued, formidably annotated, and beautifully provocative. In her view, no first-century evidence exists for Paul, just as little exists for Jesus. More important, Paul’s preoccupations with the politics of circumcision, and with Jewish ritual generally, seem to fit badly within a first-century, pre-Jewish War context. Back then, with the Temple still intact, those things were not controversial. The preoccupations make far better sense in a second-century context, when a wave of anti-Jewish suspicion filled the Empire,

particularly after the Bar Kokhba revolt of 132-35 C.E., the last great Jewish uprising against Rome, which ended in catastrophic defeat, mass death, and the refounding of Jerusalem as a pagan city. No one cared about condemning circumcision in 50 C.E.; everyone did a century later.

Letters were, in any case, a genre more than an epistolary act: most collections of antique letters, Livesey points out, were unmailed and literary, written to enlarge a theme, not persuade a recipient. The proliferation of letters in the New Testament is also typical of second-century literary activity; letters written as rhetorical models, using the epistolary form as an intimate vehicle for argument, are everywhere in the later period. So Livesey thinks that Paul's letters make much better sense as a literary performance, too, if keyed to second-century Greek concerns and practices. This dramatic redating also contextualizes those odd interpolations—the Jew-hating sentences make more sense if written after the Bar Kokhba revolt—and, indeed, the broader question of how, exactly, there could have been so many practicing churches for Paul to correspond and commune with so soon after the establishment of the Jesus cult.

Livesey's thesis is so tightly and rationally argued that it can't be readily dismissed, and, even if it's wrong, it could be one of those theses which point the way to a larger rightness. Meanwhile, Livesey's arguments have been met with respectful—and, to this amateur reader, persuasive—rebuttals by several fellow-scholars, most formidably by Fredriksen and Walsh. Paul's letters, they note, read like *letters*, not literary performances, filled with local detail, tempest-in-a-teapot controversies, and people, like that coppersmith, who read only as living annoyances, not neat symbolic figures. They are also filled with apocalyptic premonitions that make sense only in a first-century context, when Jesus was credibly thought by his followers to soon be on his way back home, ready to take believers up to Heaven, or the moon, with him. By the second century, even devout Christians had to walk back this belief. Why, Fredriksen has asked, would writers of the mid-second century, composing pseudonymous letters in the voice of a first-century figure, include statements predicting Christ's imminent return?

Both Fredriksen and Walsh are convinced that, however Hellenized Paul might seem, he was entirely apocalyptic and millenarian in his thought and fully expected the world to burn within his lifetime. Is it inconceivable, though, that even a second-century invented Paul might have persisted in these premonitions? Those who raise millennial expectations often adjust to their disappointment without great difficulty. No one was more confident than William Miller, whose preaching gave rise to Seventh-day Adventism, about the timing of the world's end and Christ's return: October 22, 1844, to be exact. But when it didn't happen he responded, in a beautiful instance of direct American speech worthy of General Ulysses S. Grant, "I confess my error and acknowledge my disappointment." In the same spirit, the early Christians seem to have quickly adjusted their own apocalyptic beliefs, easily recasting Jesus' return from "soon" to "someday." Paul's belief in the approaching apocalypse was perhaps a mixture of self-persuaded propaganda, a desire to impress, a readiness to retreat if necessary, and a shrugging, side-eyed nerve that says, "Well, what's the worst that can happen if I'm wrong? And, if my words helped scare people straight, what's the harm?" A second-century Paul might well be imagined as apocalyptic in this more rhetorical manner, too.

All days of fulfillment in religious history are, in any case, Great Disappointments, since the thing expected—Nirvana, the Apocalypse, the New Jerusalem—never does happen. Sooner or later, we trust the disappointment more than the dream. The original "Jewish" Church, which flares out like a glorious firework in the last, apocalyptic book of the Bible, Revelation, faded away in time, and Paul's universal Church grew and eventually triumphed.

What is ultimately at stake in the new literature is the question of Paul's commitment to universalism and, through him, the universalism of his faith. We love Paul for his celebration of love, for his insistence, in a key that seems to echo Jesus, that "faith can move mountains," and for his remarkable amendment of that claim: "If I have a faith that can move mountains but do not have love, I am nothing." Yet his single-minded zeal is inseparable from his intolerance. As one revisionist scholar argues, this very insistence on doctrinal and moral boundaries became one of Christianity's most serviceable features once it encountered imperial power.

A religion that defined itself sharply could be mobilized by the state, because, from Paul onward, its leading voices showed a readiness to regulate and to enforce. Paul, in other words, hands down both the ethic of love and the habit of boundary-drawing, and leaves it to us to harmonize them.

Paul's account of love is complex, but on the aspects that matter it is clear. Love does not boast, it does not demean the weak, it is slow to anger, and it extends compassion to strangers. Contemporary Christians who give other Christians a pass on any of these do not seem to be very good correspondents of the Apostle. Paul's idea of agape is philosophically pointed; it carries the weight of duty and self-denial as much as of warmth and affection. But the originality is there. It is hard to think of an earlier Jewish, Greek, or Roman thinker giving pride of place to "love" of any kind. Even in Paul, though, the spiritual is balanced by the material. At the very end of Acts, when one might expect apotheosis, we are told that Paul lived in Rome "at his own expense."

Where the consensus of disinterested scholars on matters Pauline leads is to the usual place: the texts, like all sacred texts, are a mishmash of literary tropes, polemical invention, retrospective editing, and emotive appeal. They are conflicted, as we are. Jewish believers have had to come to terms with the inarguable truth that the story of the Hebrew enslavement, flight, and deliverance from Egypt is almost entirely mythical. The Hebrew people were not held in bondage in Egypt, and, in any case, there was no promised land to go to, since it was already under Egyptian control. Yet the meaning of the ritual is undiminished for its participants. Passover is not about a historical event but about a metaphoric explication of an ideal. If its objects are Hebrew enslavement and escape, its subject is hope. It does not reduce the ritual or pietistic content to know that it is fiction. In fact, the allegory travels more easily once it is freed from literalism. The same applies to Paul's case. "Fictional" needn't mean either fatuous or false. Jesus, who speaks in parables, not in dicta or dogmas, provides us with a primary instance of the power of the nonliteral tale. We do not ask where the prodigal son's father really lived, or whether the man who built his house on sand had a deed, or who could certify that the foolish virgins were virgins.

An oddity of modern life is that, just as humanists have made us newly alert to the irreducible power of stories, people of faith, who already possess the advantage of strong stories, reach for spurious “science” to underwrite them. Hence the appeals to a “fine-tuned universe,” as if divine order were proved by the fact that the cosmos had to meet an exquisitely narrow set of conditions to yield conscious human beings. In truth, this is the same argument, beloved of parents, that the whole point of the universe was to produce one particular child. Consider the chain of contingencies that had to align, and the child’s existence can feel like a miracle. In a sense, it is. Yet the pattern is blessed only in retrospect. We were always going to find ourselves in a universe compatible with our existence, because there is no other place in which we could be aware that we existed. And, if we are not cold or conscienceless, the universe that contains us cannot be wholly cold or conscienceless, either. It includes warmth because it includes us. Our values are human-made, but that does not make them unreal.

Was Paul’s effect on history, incalculably large, good or bad on the whole? Edward Gibbon argued that Paul carried a “Jewish” intolerance into a pagan world that, for all its cruelties, was broadly pluralistic in matters of worship. Yet Paul also offered a universalism so urgently moving that it remains powerful today. That may be as close as judgment gets for a figure of his scale. We turn to philosophers and essayists, from Socrates to Richard Rorty, for inquiry and self-doubt. We turn to apostles and prophets, from Paul to Dr. Martin Luther King, Jr., for the broader conviction that faith really can move mountains, and then for the still bolder thought that even moving mountains is not enough if love is absent. “All or Nothing at All,” Sinatra’s greatest epistle, revised across his life as the purposes of his music changed, might have served as a theme for that Capra bio-pic. It is bad advice for a lover. But it is good advice for a believer, since such intensity of commitment is, in the old-fashioned sense, awesome. St. Paul, whenever exactly he lived or whatever precisely he said, was nothing if not all in. ♦

*[Adam Gopnik](#), a staff writer, has been contributing to *The New Yorker* since 1986. His books include *[“The Real Work: On the Mystery of Mastery.”](#)**

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Zara Larsson Gets Her Flowers

On the “Midnight Sun” tour, the Swedish artist makes a comeback that feels like a début.

By [Doreen St. Félix](#)

April 13, 2026



Larsson's latest album evokes a world that is neon, languorous, and a little woo-woo. Illustration by Simone Noronha

The twenty-eight-year-old singer Zara Larsson could be called a veteran pop star. She earns the label in part because she's been releasing sticky Euro dance pop for half her life, and also because there's an undertow of struggle to her glittering party-girl persona. I was working at MTV about a decade ago when Larsson, a Swedish child star, made her way onto American radio; the teen-age version of her, so likable and so formless, remains lodged in my memory—a closeted power vocalist dulling her instrument to fit catchy and anodyne tracks like “Lush Life” and “Never Forget You.” Those songs, with their tinniness and their sentimentality, still had a visceral pull. I could sing the lyrics dumbly on the treadmill—“I will never forget

you / You will always be by my side”—even if I strained to materialize the vocalist in my mind. The singles, international smashes, subsumed Larsson in a way that calls to mind Loleatta Holloway and Martha Wash, the engines of “Good Vibrations” and “Gonna Make You Sweat (Everybody Dance Now)”—women deployed as emotional flourish, propping up the groove.

A few weeks ago, at the Brooklyn Paramount, Larsson made the argument for herself in spirit and in flesh. It was like her coming out. But as who? The last song played over the speakers to hype the crowd—a cross-section of girls younger than twelve, their mothers, and Zillennial connoisseurs of unadulterated pop—was Beyoncé’s “Love on Top.” A friend whipped her head around, squinting in suspicion, swearing that she could hear Larsson singing from backstage over that athletic vocal key change. One can see how Larsson, who opened for Beyoncé in 2016, at the London stop on the “Formation” tour, could induce hallucinations of a type of two-thousands diva: the invulnerable, perfectionist performers who mechanized the threatening sexual energy of seventies goddesses like Tina Turner and Donna Summer. “Beyoncé’s white daughter,” as Larsson has lately been called, strutted onstage seven minutes after nine. Before the screaming crowd, she cocked her silhouetted body against a backdrop of an illuminated sun, “Partition” style.

Larsson looked like an angelfish in the light, wearing a flowy purple two-piece that bared her midriff, as the tabloids used to say. Throughout the show, a wind machine worked her long blond hair, à la Beyoncé’s “Crazy in Love”; her dancers, in pum-pum denim shorts and tank tops like Fly Girls, introduced themselves through a shabooya roll call. The choreography—sexy, physical, disciplined—reminded me of Tyla and Tinashe, Black pop artists who approach live performance like a music video. “It doesn’t matter what it feels like outside, because in here it’s summertime,” Larsson cooed into a bedazzled mike. Her opener, “Midnight Sun,” the title track from her latest album and a synthy paean to Nordic summers, is a showcase for her latticelike vocal runs. It’s also a manifesto of sorts for the world that Larsson is building: neon, languorous, a little woo-woo.

“Midnight Sun” is more adult, more sexed, and more camp than Larsson’s past music, which tended toward the subgenre known as tropical house—E.D.M. mixed with floaty, naïve Caribbean rhythms. I wondered if opening with the album’s biggest song might drain the energy from the rest of the set. But the crowd, Larsson knew, was on her side; she did not have to persuade them to do a call-and-response to “Never Forget You,” or to “Pretty Ugly,” a stomp anthem with the lyric “Have you ever seen a pretty girl get ugly like this?” The audience, awash in plastic hibiscus flowers and rhinestones, was there to revel in the late-bloomer triumph of “Midnight Sun”: the seasoned performer finally anointed as an idol. Made primarily with the British producer MNEK, Larsson’s longtime collaborator, the record homes in on the idiosyncrasies of dance music, tapping regional manners like the Balkan accordion on “Euro Summer,” Baltimore club bass on “Blue Moon,” and Rio funk on “Hot & Sexy.” When it came out last fall, it seemed to signal that Larsson’s music had gained an expanded consciousness; she joked that it broke her out of the “Khia asylum,” what the extremely online call the imaginary holding cell for middling female artists. I personally find the main-girl-hierarchy talk resurging in pop circles a little tired, but Larsson evidently does not. On “Saturn’s Return,” from “Midnight Sun,” she contemplates her ambition in the scheming mode of a rapper:

When I was seventeen, I didn’t have no patience
Said by twenty I’d be fillin’ up stadiums
Didn’t happen, so I changed the deadline
Might take another twenty years, and that’s fine

At the age of ten, Larsson won “Talang,” Sweden’s version of “America’s Got Talent.” Technically, her first single was a cover of “My Heart Will Go On,” by Céline Dion, which was her star-making moment on the show. The appeal of Larsson lies less in her songcraft than in her got-it-out-the-mud performer’s grit. She is a transitional artist, straddling the old model of gruelling, radio-chasing artist development—she signed with Epic at fifteen, and recently founded her own label—and the newer terrain of spontaneous TikTok propulsion. Among her peers, Larsson is a traditionalist for her straightforward and sincere approach to live performance. A presence like Charli XCX—sunglasses on, back to the crowd—

sometimes reaches transcendence through an eroticized distance. Dua Lipa's glamour-bot routine is a bit slack, Fosse by way of a Jane Fonda aerobics tape. Even Sabrina Carpenter, whose hyper-femme aesthetic is closest to Larsson's, presents her act from a place of irony. Larsson is zealous. The leg stays flexed. She wants it bad and so we want it for her. Her stage banter, delivered in her delectable Euro twang, expressed this: "It really does mean so much to me that I get to live my dream and walk onstage each night and sing my songs and live my passion."

In that same interlude, Larsson described the strangeness of being well established internationally and newly beloved in the States: "I've been doing this for such a long time, but I feel like it's the beginning." Her early albums "So Good" and "Poster Girl" were bouncy bubblegum fare, knowingly indebted to Swedish pop, yet the turgid consistency of their sound gave the impression of a promising artist who was constantly debuting. Why hadn't any of her producers and writers over the years—a murderers' row including Tove Lo, Julia Michaels, and the duo Monsters & Strangerz, of the Max Martin school—struck the vein of her personality? You can occasionally hear, in Larsson's pre-"Midnight Sun" discography, her sense of wit and individual weirdness. I think that the sneaking melancholy of "All the Time," from 2019, is made of the same stuff that makes Charlie Puth's retro piano-man routine work, and I like the sample and flip of the Jamaican artist Sasha's dancehall hit "Dat Sexy Body"—itself a feminizing of Tony (CD) Kelly's "Bookshelf" riddim—on Larsson's "I Would Like." These songs evince the mix of pop virtuosity and indie sleaze that would eventually make Larsson a cult artist, part of the lineage of straight white girls who are embraced as guardian angels for the gay club scene. On a new remix of PinkPantheress's "Stateside," a pulsing garage track about pursuing American dreams, Larsson hits a flow state of asyncope singing about a Swedish boy that she's left behind: "'Cause I fly Stockholm to L.A. / In my feelings on the plane / Worries fade away / When I hit the stage."

At the Paramount, Larsson briefly disappeared and returned in a new outfit: orange shorts and a spray-painted tank top. A woman near me turned to her friend and said, "She's like Britney Spears." Larsson is too much of an R. & B. acolyte for this to track musically, but we all know what she means,

and no one understands it more than Larsson. She places a Spears tribute in the dead middle of her set, and it is her version of “Gimme More,” a critically maligned single about having your soul deadened by fame, from 2007. The public treats Spears as if she were a ghost, a haunting reminder of the nasty machinations that sustain the music industry. Larsson, in her paying of respects, made a point of singing the chant of the chorus as though it was balladry, swapping Spears’s nihilism for her own earnestness. She wanted her moment of ascendance to redeem our belief in the classic pop myth. She wanted to fashion an alternate reality where jadedness has no place. ♦

*[Doreen St. Félix](#), a staff writer at *The New Yorker* since 2017, is a regular contributor to the weekly column [Critic’s Notebook](#).*

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Clarion

By [Rae Armantrout](#)

April 13, 2026

There are people who don't hear an internal monologue or private dialogue in their heads.

I know people who don't imagine that songs on the radio are by or about them and their private affairs.

Humans live in a narrow slice of time compared with dogs for whom what we think of as recent history is still present on the air.

I have dreams in which I'm not even a protagonist. Am I the only one? It's like watching television with a sense of great urgency.

The ornamental pear puts out just two small leaves of such a clarion red amidst the green ones that I look up the meaning of clarion and find it refers to a small high-pitched medieval trumpet or to the sound it made.

This makes me want to weep and to be seen weeping. Do you know what I mean?

[Rae Armantrout](#), a Pulitzer Prize-winning poet, is the author of "[Go Figure](#)," among other books.

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Apocalypso

By [Dobby Gibson](#)

April 13, 2026

I couldn't finish the article about
short attention spans either,
armed feds in the Wendy's,
Saturn slowly losing its rings.
Turns out that sinking freighter
was loaded with rubber duckies,
and now the beach is filthy with kids,
tiny cameras in the cash machines,
a car alarm is triggering a car alarm
is triggering a car alarm, day-ay-ay O.
As far as the Arctic melting goes,
good thing we're already 70% water,
the rest old locker combos
and the memory of a kite
snagged high in a tree.
We probably expected too much
from a people held together
by something signed with a feather.
Calypso held Odysseus captive
on her island for years,
so don't be surprised to see
their ski masks getting sweaty.
Look at me through your doorbell cam,
the light is beautiful
and a particle
and a wave.

[Dobby Gibson](#) is the author of poetry collections including “[Little Glass Planet](#)” and “[Hold Everything](#).”

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The Crossword: Tuesday, April 7, 2026

A moderately challenging puzzle.

By [Paolo Pasco](#)

April 7, 2026

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[Paolo Pasco](#), a games editor at TED, won the American Crossword Puzzle Tournament in 2024 and 2025. He is the author of “[Crossword Puzzles for Kids](#).”

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